

History for Young Minds

Michael Gannotti

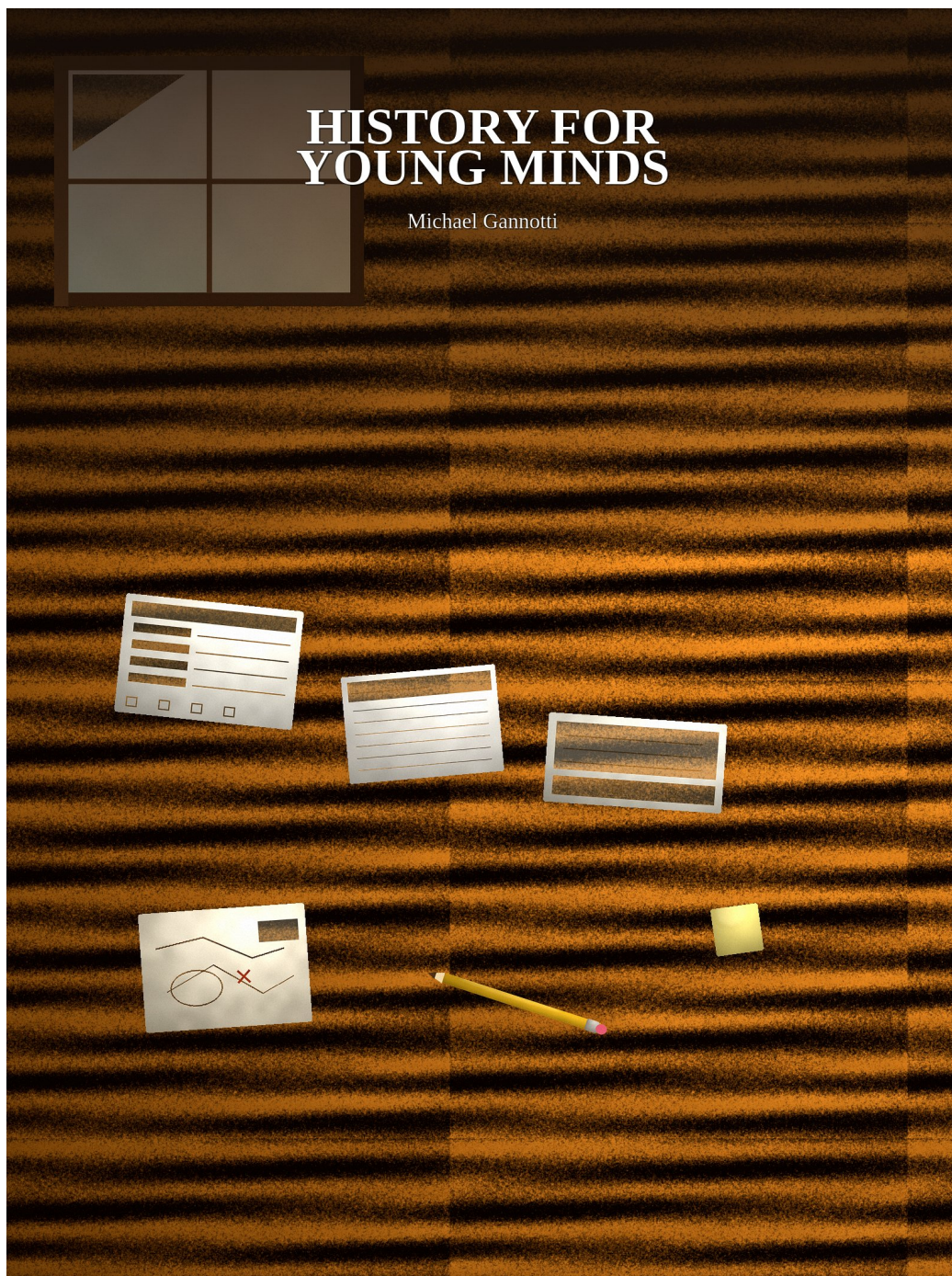


Figure 1: Cover

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This illustrated edition is the teaching-manual of 13 September 2026. Endnotes run in one series. Chapter-opening images are original still-lives, not portraits of persons or children. Documents still constrain the facts.

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Welcome

You are holding a how-to for teaching history at home with ages **11–14**.

The aim is simple. Put a **named source** on the table before the tidy summary story. Ask who made it, when, and for whom. Let your adolescent look and talk. You ask one good question and wait. That is the spine of this book: **source before summary**, with early civic texts treated gently as documents, not slogans.

You do not need to be a historian. You do need to hear a summary-first answer, a textbook-as-the-facts answer, a year-first quiz, a birthday gate (“wait until high school”), and a model summary parked where a credited piece should sit — and to ask a better question without grabbing the answer or filling the silence with the story.

Who this book is for

Two readers at once.

You, the parent or co-teacher at the table: busy, willing, and often a little rusty on names and dates. That rust is normal. Many adults were taught history as a list to memorize. This book makes you fluent enough in today’s looking move to run a short History Hour well — and to hear a wrong turn without turning the table into a fight.

Your student, ages 11–14: a person, not a percentile. They get short, respectful sections they can actually use. Never baby-talk. Never a lecture about their parents.

At **11–12**, they can cover the body until who-when-why is said, run Observe→Reflect→Question with purpose emerging, lightly compare two

short accounts, interrupt presentism with a their-world prompt, treat one short civic excerpt as a document with a maker, and write a spoken or one-sentence claim that points at a named source. They can use a map or timeline under a story they already own.

At **13–14**, they add audience and purpose more clearly, name limitations across kinds of sources, organize evidence for a short claim paragraph, compare accounts that answer different questions, and pair a grievance *shape* with a constitutional *limit* gently — still without a Constitution-chain march. They can ask who is missing from the record.

Place by **skill, not birthday**. A thirteen-year-old who still jumps to the summary may need the 11–12 scaffolds. An eleven-year-old who already sources before the body may take the next try. The work lives in the home and outside it: credited excerpt on the table, library primary hunt, museum one object, courthouse or plaque read, archive screen with an adult.

What a good History Hour looks like

Picture this.

A credited short excerpt sits on the table — a letter header, a diary day, a newspaper masthead, a soft period image, one civic clause. The body may be covered at first. Your student names maker, date, and type from the credit line. Then they look: Observe, Reflect, Question. You give a tiny bit of background — enough for the piece to make sense, not an encyclopedia tour. You ask one authentic question. You wait. They try. You end with a short exit ticket: one sourcing sentence, or (at 13–14) a short claim that names the source.

That session runs about **25–45 minutes**. Coverage is a map; depth is the hour. One named move done well beats a rushed medley. Shared looking, kitchen talk, and outings motivate. They do not replace the source-before-summary looking move.

This is not a 180-day worksheet dump. It is not a culture-war pamphlet. It is not a high-school Document-Based Lesson packet every week. Library and museum visits belong here — they supply real pieces and real places. The looking still happens on a named source.

Focus lock

Two promises, held for the whole book:

1. **Source before summary.** Attribution before the body. The credit line is part of the look. A fluent summary from a machine is performance, not the adolescent's looking. A generated diary is not a primary.
2. **Early civic texts gently.** Magna Carta, the Declaration, the Constitution (and compact, charter, amendment edges) appear as **document edges** — one clause, source card, then-words — not as a campaign speech and not as a forced march through a founding chain.

Everything else in these chapters serves those two locks: two accounts and light corroboration, context without drowning, maps and timelines as tools under owned stories, claim plus named source, short kitchen skill checks.

Safe objects only: a credited short excerpt, a newspaper voice with an honesty card, a diary day (honest excerpt), a soft political cartoon, a speech excerpt, a ship manifest or list kept soft, an image pair of the same event, a civic clause with maker and date, a period map, an owned-story timeline, a dated notebook. Soft entry on hard past. Graphic violence is not the default piece box.

What this book will not do

It will not sell you a curriculum. It will not promise a score or a percentile. It will not hand you a year of worksheets. It will not reprint *History for Little Thinkers* (ages 5–10 piece-from-then / who-made-this) with longer words — no Coin Clues, Kitchen Memory, or then/now clothesline scripts dressed up for middle grades. It will not reprint *History for Homeschooling* (grades 1–12 surveys, transcript export, AP/CLEP edges). One pointer each, then teach 11–14 history. It is not a sequel to *Critical Thinking for Young Minds* or *English for Young Minds*. One pointer each, then teach history as looking at a named source.

It will not title your subject **Young Minds History I**. A stranger-readable record says **History** or **Social Studies**. It will not dump a Constitution chain as the civic week (that deeper civic work lives elsewhere). It will not treat a generated diary as a primary, or a model summary as the source on the table. It will not invent a ninth teaching chapter called “life of the habit” — that rhythm lives in the History Hour, in done-enough checklists, and in the records you keep.

How the book is built

Front matter once: this welcome, how to use the book this week, five things to remember, and **the History Hour** (session shape, talk-box shape, in-home and out-of-home try-it shape, and the AI box once for ages 11–14).

Eight teaching chapters, each with the same eight headings: why it matters; for the parent; how to teach it this week; practice that builds learning; for the student; if it isn't clicking; tools including AI; what “done enough” looks like. Every teaching chapter has a talk box with a locked opening question, follow-ups, wait, and stuck-silence notes. Named try-its live **in the home and outside it**.

Then records and resources: what to keep under a stranger-readable title, and programs by fit — library and museum first — without crowning a winner.

Encouragement for this week

Parent: learn to put the attribution card down before the story. Practice who-when-why alone for five minutes with tomorrow's piece. Cut civic excerpts to size before you sit down.

Student: cover the body until you can say who made this, when, and for whom — then look. You are allowed to wait. You may change your mind when you look again.

You can do this. The piece is on the table. The summary can wait.

How to use this book this week

This book is a menu of looking moves, not a calendar you must finish. Pick one focus. Run a few short hours. Check what stuck. Move on when the skill holds — not when the birthday says so.

One focus, one week

1. **Name one focus move** from the chapter you are in. Examples: attribution before the body; Observe→Reflect→Question on a credit line; two short accounts without “one must be lying”; one civic clause as a document; a claim that names a source.
2. **Schedule three to five History Hours** of the named shape (~25–45 minutes each). You do not need five every week. Three solid hours beat five rushed ones.
3. **Pick one in-home try-it and one out-of-home try-it** from that chapter (or from the History Hour shapes). Time, materials, safety, the fun, and the skill are named so you can run them without inventing a field trip from scratch.
4. **Friday (or your last hour):** one diagnostic wrong answer you can hear, plus the “done enough” checklist from the chapter. Source a claim, corroborate two sources, or write a short argument when those are the week’s skills — kitchen checks, not a percentile battery.

That is the honest “lesson plan.” Not 180 worksheets. Not a NAEP panic. Not a brand name on a transcript line.

How to open a chapter

Read **Why this matters** and **For the parent** first — alone, before you sit with your student. Do the parent warm-up (five to eight minutes with tomorrow's piece). Then teach from **How to teach it this week** and **Practice**. Hand your student the **For the student** pages when they are ready to try. Use **If it isn't clicking** when a wrong reason shows up. Point back to the History Hour AI box from **Tools**; do not invent a new AI policy every chapter. End with **What “done enough” looks like** before you advance.

Sibling and mixed-age notes

Share the piece. Split the try.

A younger sibling who still lives in *History for Little Thinkers* grain (piece-from-then, who-made-this, oral retell) can look at the same object with a shorter ask: what do you notice; who might have made this; one wonder. Your 11–14 student runs the full source card, Observe→Reflect→Question, and the exit ticket for *this* book. Do not force the younger child into a claim paragraph. Do not shrink the older student's hour into a then/now clothesline.

If two adolescents sit at different bands, give both the same credited piece. Let the 11–12 student exit with a sourcing sentence. Let the 13–14 student add a limitation or a short claim paragraph. One table. Two exits.

Multilingual and hard-prose notes

Looking works in the family's talk language. When archaic English blocks the look, the adult reads the attribution aloud and scaffolds one hard sentence — that is access, not rescue of the *thinking*. Then return eyes to the credit line and the piece. Do not replace today's looking lesson with a full English morphology hour. Point once to *English for Young Minds* if print stamina is the real blocker, then come back to history looking.

What to have on the table

- One credited short excerpt or image (library printout, textbook primary page, public-domain civic clause, museum postcard).
- An attribution / honesty card (maker, date, type, original / excerpt / translation / reproduction).
- Sticky notes or a simple notebook line for Observe / Reflect / Question and the exit ticket.
- Optional: a second short account for corroboration weeks; a period map or owned-story timeline card when place or time is the focus.

You do not need a wall of posters. You do not need a generated “colonial diary.” You need a named piece and a question.

When to slow down or go ahead

Slow down when the student still narrates the year before anyone has looked at the credit line, treats the textbook as “the facts,” or freezes because the question was year-first. Stay on source-before-summary until attribution is said without shame.

Go ahead when they can name maker, date, and type from the credit line on a fresh piece, point at a line when asked how they know, and write (or say) a claim that names the source. Birthday is not the gate. Skill is.

Records this week

Date the notebook. Name the source. Write one line under **History** or **Social Studies** — never a curriculum brand, never **Young Minds History I**. Optional vendor review questions may sit beside the looking work; the title a stranger can read is still History or Social Studies.

If you only remember five things

Keep this page near the table. When the hour gets noisy, return here.

1. **Source before summary.**

Put a named piece on the table — a credited excerpt, image, list, or civic clause. Attribution before the body. The tidy adult story waits until eyes have been on the credit line. Coverage is a map; depth is the hour. An encyclopedia tour without a piece is not a History Hour.

2. **Ask who made this, when, and for whom — before the body.**

The credit line is part of the look. Say maker, date, type, and audience if known. Use an honesty card: original, excerpt, translation, reproduction, or uncertain. Unknown is allowed when the line does not say. Inventing a biography from a signature is not sourcing.

3. **Ask one good question and wait.**

The student looks and talks. You pose one authentic question, wait, and point back at the sourced line. Do not grab the answer. Do not fill the silence with the year. Stuck silence usually means the question was vague, wait-time was zero, or the piece never landed — fix the question or return to the credit line.

4. **Early civic texts are documents, not slogans.**

Magna Carta, the Declaration, the Constitution (and compact, charter, amendment edges) belong on the table as **document edges**: one clause, source card, then-words. Not a campaign speech. Not a Constitution-chain dump. Not a virtue machine. Point once elsewhere for deeper civic argument; keep this hour on the line in front of you.

5. **Place by skill, not birthday.**

An eleven-year-old who sources before the body may go ahead. A fourteen-

year-old who still summarizes first may need the scaffold. A path through middle-grades history looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A percentile is not. A stranger-readable record says **History** or **Social Studies** — never a brand, never Young Minds History I.

Keep these five clean. AI honesty — a generated diary is not a primary; a model summary is not the source; the parent holds or co-holds the account — lives in the History Hour box. Come back to it when a tool is on the table.

When in doubt this week: put the piece down, cover the body until who-when-why is said, ask one question, wait, and stop while a look remains. Tomorrow's summary can wait for tomorrow's credit line.

The History Hour

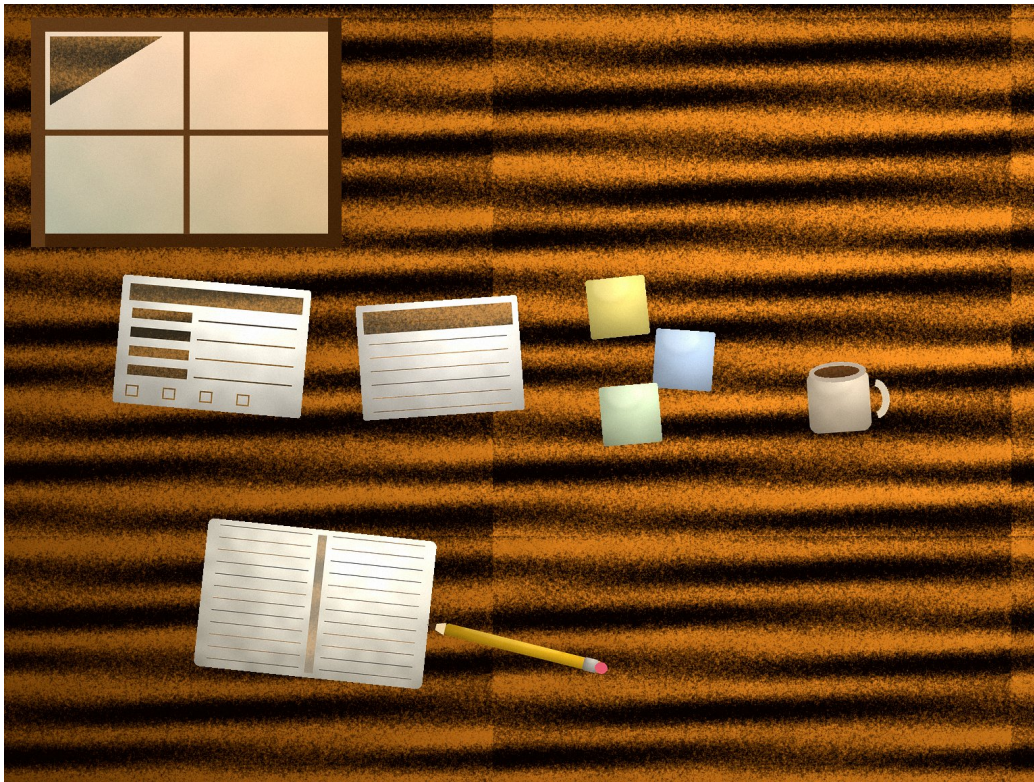


Figure 2: A kitchen table with an attribution card, a short credited excerpt, and Observe/Reflect/Question stickies — still-life, no people, no logos.

This chapter says the session once for the whole book. Later chapters point back. You do not need a new ritual every Tuesday. You need a named shape you can run

in about 25–45 minutes.

Session shape — five beats

1. Source before summary / attribution card (4–8 minutes).

Put the credit line in view first: maker, date, type of text, audience if known, and an honesty flag (original / later copy / excerpt / translation / reproduction). Cover the body if you need to. Ask what they notice about the *source*, not yet the full story. You do not dump the summary yet.

2. Short look at the body (5–12 minutes).

Read a short excerpt aloud together, or silently with scaffolds (glossary sticky; adult reads archaic lines). Run **Observe** → **Reflect** → **Question**. Pose one clear historical question the text can actually speak to. Stay in Observe long enough that Reflect is not a first-second guess.

3. Short background or talk (5–10 minutes).

Give enough story for the piece to make sense — a tiny picture of then’s world, not a chapter dump. Ask one authentic question. Wait. Point back at the sourced line.

4. One try (8–15 minutes).

One named try-it from the chapter: header before body, honesty card, two light excerpts, one civic clause, a claim sentence, a map annotation. Struggle before rescue: ask, wait, hint (a question or a named idea), then model one move if needed. Do not paste a machine’s past as theirs.

5. Exit ticket (2–4 minutes).

One oral sourcing sentence, one claim-plus-evidence line, one corroboration sticky, or (at 13–14) a short paragraph or annotated excerpt. Date the notebook. Name the source. Stop while a look remains.

Optional sixth beat when siblings share the table: a short post-response wait so each voice lands before the next try.

Band forks inside the hour

11–12. Source card → short look with scaffolds → short background → try that may include one civic clause or two light excerpts → exit as a sourcing sentence

or claim-plus-one-evidence. Dates as labels once the story is owned. Oral exit is fine.

13–14. Source card → more independent look → short background → try that may include light corroboration, a short claim paragraph, or a civic text with then-meaning of a key word → exit as paragraph or annotated excerpt. Still not a full AP Document-Based Question packet.

Dose honesty

If a day only holds twenty-five minutes: source card + one Observe/Reflect + exit ticket. One named move done well beats a rushed medley. There is no national “history minutes” study to chase. Do not invent one. A parent hour is not a failed school block.

Life of the habit as session rhythm

Revisit yesterday’s source card for two minutes. Mix last week’s two accounts once this week. Stop while a look remains. That rhythm lives here — not in a ninth teaching chapter titled “life of the habit.”

Hour debug table

What you see	Likely cause	Tomorrow’s move
Hour is only chapter summary	Source-before-summary skipped	Attribution card first
Only worksheets	No real piece	One credited excerpt + one oral question
Textbook alone as “the facts”	Textbook treated as primary	Cover textbook; open one primary
Freeze / empty silence	Vague question or zero wait	One clear question + count three
“They were just dumb”	Presentism at rest	Their-world prompt
Civic text becomes a speech	Slogan mode	Return to maker / audience / purpose

What you see	Likely cause	Tomorrow's move
AI "old letter" filed as real	Generated primary	Label fiction; find a credited piece
App or AR chase replaces looking	Tool as hide	Close the app; open the piece
Two accounts → "one is lying"	First corroboration wrong	Different questions / standpoints
Materials printed, no talk	Pose skipped	Pose, wait, point at sourced line

Talk-box shape (once for the book)

Every teaching chapter carries a talk box. The shape is always the same; the opening question is locked per chapter.

Opening. An authentic question about what they know from the source before the summary, who made this from the credit line, what matches across two accounts, what would have to be true in *their* world, what job a civic line is trying to do, where/when on map or timeline, what they claim with a named source, or what they can show two ways. Not "did you have fun." Not "what is the vocabulary quiz year."

Follow-ups (3–5). One for observe ("what do you *see* / *read*?"). One for maker/audience ("who made this / for whom?"). One for reason tied to the piece ("how do you know from *this* line?"). One for check or alternative ("what else could be true / what would have to be true in *their* world / which question does each account answer?"). One that lets them revise ("you may change your mind" / "try another line").

How to wait. After you ask, count a slow three — a classroom-origin think-time habit (Stahl; Rowe's classic wait-time work was in *science* class, so label it that way and do not mash the two into a kitchen history experiment). After they stop, wait again before you evaluate. If they are mid-look or mid-claim, do not cut them off. Look at the piece, the two accounts, or the map — not at the adolescent — if the silence is hard.

Stuck silence usually means: the question was vague; wait-time was zero; they are hunting a year because you asked year-first; they are guessing what you want;

the piece never landed; they offered a summary-only guess; they think history means “repeat the parent’s story”; they think looking means “the textbook is the facts”; archaic prose needs a scaffold before talk. Your job is to pose, wait, and point back at the sourced line — not to fill the silence with the right year.

In-home try-it shape

Name **time, materials, safety, the fun, the skill.**

Typical home materials: a credited short excerpt or image; attribution / honesty card; sticky notes; a dated notebook; sometimes two short accounts or one civic clause.

Safety is ordinary: no tasting unknown things, no shoplifting a “test,” no lecture to a stranger’s child. A civic clause is a document. It is not a culture-war pamphlet.

The fun is the look itself — covering the body, uncovering a caption last, sorting an honesty card, starring a line that answers the question.

The skill is always a looking move: attribution before body, Observe→Reflect→Question, match/differ across two accounts, their-world prompt, claim with named source.

Out-of-home try-it shape

Same five labels: time, materials, safety, the fun, the skill.

Library primary hunt. Find one credited piece. Name maker and date before reading the story in the caption book.

Museum one object. Observe before reading the placard. Then ask who wrote the placard.

Courthouse / plaque read. A plaque is print about a place — a later telling. Credit it as such.

Archive screen with adult. Attribution first on screen. Parent stays with the student.

Thrift / antique mystery soft. One object; ordinary aisle courtesy; no cold public quiz of strangers for “oral history”; no photographing strangers without care.

Cemetery soft only with family consent. Roads and museum hands-off rules apply. Outings motivate. They do not replace the source-before-summary move.

AI at the History Hour (ages 11–14)

Say this once. Later chapters point back in a sentence.

The student looks at the piece-from-then, sources it before the summary, and claims from what they saw. The tool does not write the year or invent the past. The student does not sit alone with an open chat as the only partner.

Ages 11–12 (under 13 — COPPA)

Parent holds the account. Scripts and parent–student talk. **Not** live open chat as the student’s partner. Unaided first on looking and sourcing. SCRIPT after the try.

You (the parent) may, on *your* account, before or after the student tries:

1. Ask the tool to **explain this week’s idea to you** from a **named** textbook page or credited primary — not to the student as a live partner.
2. Ask for **extra practice** that matches today’s looking (a blank timeline, a map with empty labels, a two-account sheet, a claim frame) with answers only on a **PARENT KEY** page the student never sees.
3. Ask for a short **SCRIPT** you will say *after* they look and try attribution, corroboration, or a claim — questions that keep *your* voice and the student’s eyes on the credited piece.
4. Ask for **revision questions after a claim draft** — not a rewrite of the student’s paragraph.
5. Ask for a **hint** that is not the finished essay and not a fake diary.
6. After they finish, show the tool **work they already did** (crop the photo to the paper or map) and ask what mix-up is likely — then *you* talk to the student.
7. Ask for **discussion questions** you will vet and ask yourself — the student answers you, not the tab.

Ages 13–14 (COPPA off; parent still in the room — not a licence)

Parent co-holds the account. Still no unsupervised chatbot as the only partner. Turning 13 is not a permission slip for a private historian companion or for “AI

writes the claim because they're ready for real history now."

Same seven allows as above. The student may sit *next to* the parent while the parent uses a tool. The student may hear revision questions after they have drafted a claim. The student may type their own "I claim ____ because [named source] says . **A limitation is** ." The blanks are the student's. A model that fills the blanks is still the crutch. Unaided first. SCRIPT after the try.

Must not (both grains)

1. Paste tonight's worksheet / DBQ packet / map and take the answers (**photo-to-key**).
2. Ask the tool to **write the student's history paragraph or essay** or "fix this to an A."
3. Ask the tool to **generate a diary, letter, or speech from then as if it were a real primary**.
4. Leave a chatbot running as the student's only partner during the attempt — not at 11, not at 14.
5. Put a **model summary** on the table as the source instead of a credited piece-from-then.
6. Use TTS, narrated rewrite, or a voice-clone toy to **replace looking** at the piece that is today's lesson.
7. Treat a **generated painting** of the past as a primary source (looking together labelled as modern make-believe is fine; filing it as evidence is not).
8. Invent research or trust a fluent citation without opening the paper — parent-side or student works cited.
9. Detector-grade the student's claim paragraph and call the score honesty.
10. Hand the student an agent (Hermes Agent, Grok Bot, or any cloud-computer worker) as a history partner. Print a certificate of history.

One crutch sentence, labelled OFF-AGE for literacy/history, then teach: in a **high-school math** trial (not this history band), an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse on the test with the window closed (Bastani et al., 2025). The kitchen-table rule it supports: the model may prepare the adult and the next looking page; it may not do the student's looking, sourcing, or claim when those are the lesson.

One looking sentence: sources do not by themselves constitute evidence; ask who made this, when, for whom, and why — on a real credited piece, not on a model

summary.

COPPA: 11–12 — parent holds the account. 13–14 — co-hold / still in the room; not a licence. Not a secret friend. Keep accounts, logs, and keys where the parent can open them.

Names that stay separate: Hermes 4 is not Hermes Agent. Grok is not Grok Bot and is not El Salvador Grok-as-tutor. There is no Grok Bot education SKU. Game artist makes pictures, not a history course. Agents are not chatbots. Detectors fail (Liang 2023) — do not detector-grade a student’s “According to this letter....” Fabricated citations are parent-side (Walters and Wilder 2023). If you asked a tool for a paper on primary sources, open the Library of Congress Teaching with Primary Sources page or the C3 Framework PDF yourself.

A fluent filled blank from a machine is performance, not the student’s history looking.

This-week reminder

One focus move. Three to five History Hours. One in-home try-it. One out-of-home try-it. Friday: one diagnostic wrong + done-enough. Date the notebook under **History** or **Social Studies**. Then stop while a look remains.

Chapter 1 — What history looks like at 11–14

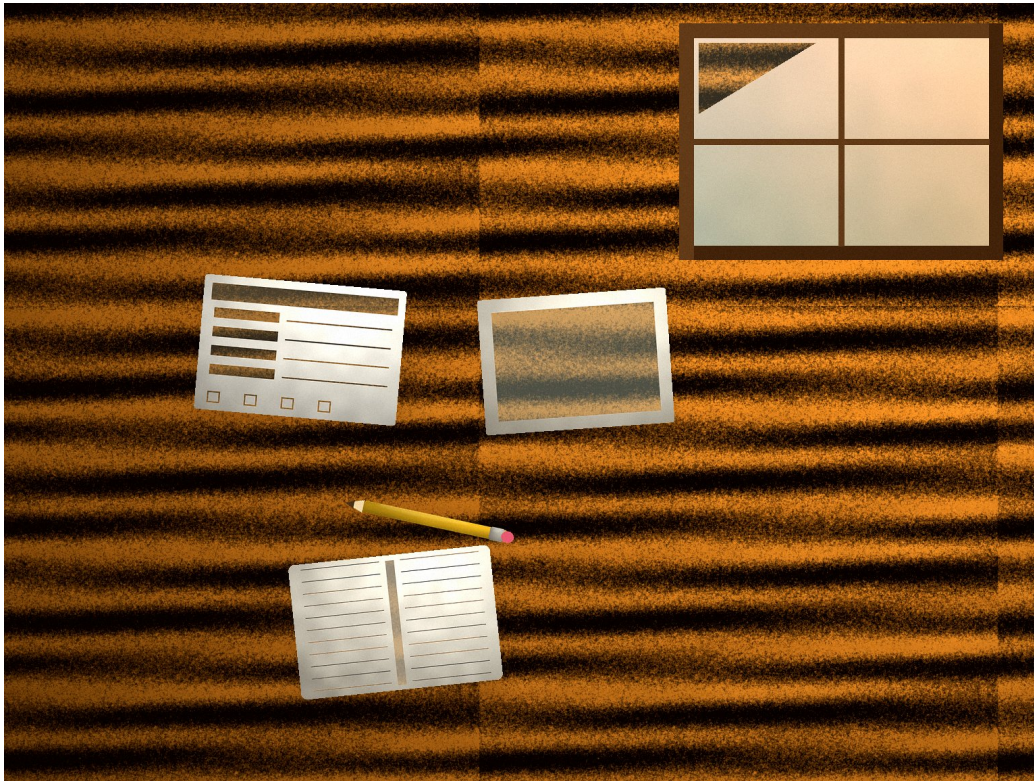


Figure 3: An attribution card beside a covered excerpt body — source before summary — still-life, no people, no logos.

Why this matters

History at eleven to fourteen is not a waiting room for high school. It is not an encyclopedia slog. It is a **named source on the table before the parent’s summary story** — attribution before the body — and placement by skill, not birthday.

If you only teach chapter summaries, the adolescent learns that history is a story adults already finished. If you only wait until “real” documents arrive in high school, you withhold a looking move they can already practice. Middle-grades work can treat short documents and images as evidence when teaching makes the moves explicit. National inquiry frameworks for grades 6–8 already name maker, date, place, audience, purpose, limitations, and organizing evidence for a claim. You do not need that language on the wall. You need the move on the table.

The middle-grades temptation is coverage pressure and textbook-as-primary. The hour’s spine is **source before summary**, aged up from the younger piece-from-then habit — same house, different noun. This chapter unlocks the rest of the book: every later skill assumes eyes on a credit line before the tidy telling.

Worth the struggle: once attribution is a habit, two accounts, context, civic edges, maps, and claims have somewhere to land. Without it, every later chapter collapses into summary-first again.

You are not trying to mint a little professor. You are trying to make one looking habit automatic enough that a wrong turn is audible — to you and, soon, to them. That is enough for this week. That is enough to start a life of history looking for ordinary middle-grades challenges.

Sister books live nearby and stay nearby. *History for Little Thinkers* owns ages 5–10 piece-from-then and who-made-this. *History for Homeschooling* owns grades 1–12 surveys and high-school edges. *Critical Thinking for Young Minds* and *English for Young Minds* own judgment craft and literacy craft. One pointer each — then teach 11–14 history as looking at a named source. Do not reprint those manuals here with the nouns swapped. Do not mash a high-school classroom packet into week one at the kitchen table.

What this chapter refuses, plainly: wait-until-high-school; encyclopedia-as-hour; birthday placement as the only gate; model summary as the day’s source; Little Thinkers then/now as the only spine with longer words; a culture-war pamphlet as the hour; Young Minds History I as a transcript title.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Everyday picture

You buy a used appliance. Before you trust the “works great” note on the listing, you look at who wrote it, when, and for whom. A seller’s summary is useful. It is not the same kind of voice as the serial plate on the machine. History looking is that habit with the past: credit line first, then the body, then your own short telling — labelled as a later telling.

Another everyday picture: a group chat forwards a photo with a caption. Eyes go to the caption. The caption may be kind, wrong, or half-true. Historians train the opposite reflex for the past: notice who made the image, when, and for what audience, before the caption finishes the story for you. Caption Last (later in this chapter) is that reflex on purpose.

Precise picture

Sourcing means asking who made this, when, what kind of text it is, and for whom — **before** reading the body as “what happened.” Historians do this almost automatically; students often dive into the paragraph first. Your job is to make the attribution move visible and practiceable. A textbook paragraph is an account written later for school readers. A letter, diary day, newspaper masthead, or civic clause is a different kind of voice. Both can be useful. They answer different questions. Neither becomes “the facts” just because the print looks official.

Presentism — judging then with only now’s common sense — is the mind at rest, not a character flaw to scold. When a twelve-year-old says “they were just stupid,” repair with a their-world prompt in chapter 4; this week, first get the credit line said. Deficit-past stories (“everything was worse / everyone was foolish until us”) are a cousin of presentism. You do not need a seminar. You need attribution first so the piece has a maker in a time.

Knowledge matters: a student cannot source a clause about a world they have no picture of. Give the piece and a tiny story. Do not demand multi-perspective analysis of an unfamiliar world in week one of age eleven. Coverage is a map; depth is the hour. Light tours leave few traces. Pattern builds slowly when eyes return to named pieces.

What counts as a source on the table this month: a credited short excerpt; a news-

paper voice with an honesty card; a diary day (honest excerpt); a soft period image; a speech paragraph; a ship manifest or list kept soft; a civic clause with maker and date; a period map; a dated notebook line that points at a named piece. What does not count as the day's source: a model summary, a generated diary filed as real, an unmarked modern "aged" image, a campaign rant with no credit line.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **Summary first.** "So basically what happened was..." before anyone has looked at the credit line. Usually means the story habit is stronger than the looking habit. Return to the covered body. Ask the locked opening. Wait.
2. **Textbook-as-primary.** "The book just says the facts." Usually means the textbook's later-writer voice is invisible. Source the textbook as an account; open one primary beside it. Ask which questions each can answer.
3. **Year-first.** Hunting the date as the whole point of the hour. Usually means past quizzes trained them to win by calendar. Ask what they know from the *source* before the summary story. Dates are tools under owned stories — chapter 6 deepens that; this week, do not let the year replace the look.
4. **Birthday gate.** "We'll do real documents in high school." Usually means wait-until-high-school folklore. Offer one short credited piece now. Place by skill. An eleven-year-old who can say who-when-type may go ahead; a fourteen-year-old who still summarizes first may need the scaffold.
5. **Encyclopedia hour / model summary as source.** A long survey or a chat-bot summary parked where the piece should sit. Usually means coverage itch or tool convenience. Put a credited excerpt down; label any summary as later telling. A fluent paragraph from a machine is performance, not their looking.

Parent warm-up (5–8 minutes, alone)

Take tomorrow's credited piece. Cover the body. Say aloud: maker, date, type, audience if known, one honesty flag (excerpt / translation / later printing). Only then uncover and skim. Write one sentence of summary and label it "later telling." Practice who-when-why before any summary sentence. Cut civic excerpts to size if that is tomorrow's piece — but this week's spine is attribution before body, even on ordinary letters and images.

If the piece has no clear credit line, fix that before the hour: copy maker and date from the library page, textbook credit, or archive label onto an honesty card. Do not invent a maker. “Unknown — credit incomplete” is honest sourcing.

How to teach it this week

Session shape

Use the History Hour five beats. This week’s focus: **source before summary**.

1. **Attribution card first (4–8 minutes).** Cover the body. Who / when / type / for whom if known. Honesty flag.
2. **Short look once attribution is said (5–12 minutes).** Observe→Reflect→Question lightly — chapter 2 deepens ORQ; here the win is not skipping the credit line.
3. **Short background (5–10 minutes).** Tiny story only — enough for the piece to make sense.
4. **One try (8–15 minutes).** Header Before Body, Caption Last, Textbook Is an Account, or Attribution First Always.
5. **Exit ticket (2–4 minutes).** “Writer: . **Audience:** . One thing we don’t know: ____.” Or: one thing known *before* the summary story.

Exact wording you can say:

- “Cover the body with me. What do you notice on the credit line?”
- “Who made this, when, and what kind of text is it — before we hear the story?”
- “You may change your mind when we uncover the body.”
- “My summary is a later telling. Your eyes on the source come first.”
- “Unknown is allowed if the line does not say.”

First try-it for the student

Header Before Body (SRC-01). One letter or memo photocopy with a clear header or signature. Sticky over the body. Uncover only header/signature/date. Who / to whom / when? Wait. Hypothesize purpose. Uncover one short body paragraph. Revise the purpose guess without shame. Exit: “Writer: . **Audience:** . One thing we don’t know: ____.”

How to fade help

Day 1–2: You point at the credit line and model who-when-type out loud.

Day 3: They point; you wait; you supply only a scaffold word if archaic prose blocks.

Day 4–5: They write or say the attribution card before you speak. At 13–14, they also name one limitation lightly (“this cannot tell us...”).

Struggle before rescue: ask, wait, hint (a question or a named idea — “look at the date line”), then model one move. Do not grab the answer. Do not fill the silence with the story. Do not paste a machine’s past as theirs.

What “struggle before rescue” looks like minute by minute

Minute 0–1: Piece on the table, body covered, credit line visible. You say nothing yet except “look at the top.”

Minute 1–2: Locked opening. Wait three. If empty silence from a mushy start, fix the question: “What name or date do you see?”

Minute 2–4: They speak. You wait after they stop. If they invent a biography, ask “What on the *line* makes you say that?”

Minute 4–6: One hint if needed — point to the date line or the “Dear...” — still not the summary.

Minute 6–8: Uncover one paragraph only. Ask what to revise. Stop talking.

If you narrate the whole war in minute three, you taught coverage, not sourcing.

Materials checklist for the week

- Two or three credited short pieces (letter, photo, textbook primary page, or public-domain civic clause cut to size for later — not all at once).
- Stickies or a paper strip for covering bodies and captions.
- Honesty cards: original / excerpt / translation / reproduction / uncertain.
- Dated notebook titled **History** or **Social Studies**.
- Optional: one textbook paragraph for SRC-03; one labelled “later telling” summary for AS-08.
- Library card or a parent-bookmarked archive page for the out-of-home try.

You do not need a wall timeline yet. You do not need a generated colonial journal. You need credit lines you can point at.

When to stop talking

After the authentic question. After they answer, wait again. If they jump to summary, return to the source card in one sentence — then stop. If they are mid-look, do not cut them off. Looking at the credit line yourself models where attention belongs.

Age-band moves

11–12. Adult scaffolds hard prose. Oral exit OK. Keep one piece on the table. Purpose may emerge as a guess labelled as a guess. Prefer SRC-01, SRC-02, SRC-05, AS-06. One civic text family later in the book — this week, ordinary letters and images are enough.

13–14. Student writes the attribution card. Names one limitation. May try Memoir Written Later (two dates visible), Textbook Is an Account with a sharper “which question” exit, or Model Summary Is Not a Source with a labelled later telling beside a primary. Still not an AP packet.

A sample week (illustration, not a law)

Labelled hypothetical — not a reported family and not a calendar you must copy.

- Monday: SRC-01 Header Before Body + talk box.
- Tuesday: AS-06 Attribution First Always (ten minutes) + SRC-02 Caption Last.
- Wednesday: SRC-03 Textbook Is an Account.
- Thursday: OUT-01 Library Primary Hunt (or OUT-04 if homebound).
- Friday: Diagnostic — student starts with summary; return to source card; SRC-05; done-enough checklist.

Three solid hours beat five rushed ones. If the week only holds three: Monday SRC-01, Wednesday SRC-03, Friday diagnostic + SRC-05.

Practice that actually builds learning

Talk box

Opening (locked): “What do you know from this source — before we hear the summary story?”

Follow-ups:

1. What do you notice on the credit line?
2. What kind of text is this?
3. Who was it for?
4. How do you know that from the *source lines*, not only from my summary?
5. You may change your mind when we look again.

How to wait: Count three after you ask. Count three after they stop. Look at the credit line if the silence is hard. Do not supply the summary to rescue discomfort. Classroom think-time research is a useful kitchen habit (labelled classroom-origin in the History Hour); it is not a home history experiment.

Stuck silence usually means: the question was vague; they are hunting a year; the piece never landed; they think history means repeating your story; the body was uncovered too soon; archaic prose needs a scaffold before talk. Return to the covered credit line. Fix the question. Wait again.

In-home try-its

SRC-01 Header Before Body

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** Letter or memo photocopy with clear header/signature; sticky covering the body
- **Safety:** Ordinary kitchen; no need to “perform” for guests
- **The fun:** The reveal — purpose guess revised after one paragraph
- **The skill:** Attribution before body
- **Steps:** (1) Uncover only header/signature/date. (2) Who / to whom / when? Wait. (3) Hypothesize purpose. (4) Uncover one short body paragraph. (5) Revise purpose guess without shame.
- **Error patterns:** Reading body first; inventing biography from a signature; treating an unsigned AI letter as real.

- **Exit ticket:** “Writer: . **Audience:** . One thing we don’t know: ____.”

SRC-02 Caption Last

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** Historical photo; sticky over caption/credit
- **Safety:** Soft images only; no graphic harm as default
- **The fun:** Eyes first, credit second — what the credit adds
- **The skill:** Observe before caption dependence
- **Steps:** Observe → Reflect; uncover caption/credit; compare; name what the credit adds that eyes alone could not.
- **Error patterns:** “Old because black-and-white”; treating caption as eyewitness.
- **Exit ticket:** One Observe + one Reflect + one credit fact.

SRC-03 Textbook Is an Account

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 25–35 min
- **Materials:** One textbook paragraph + one short primary on the same topic
- **Safety:** Low-heat topic
- **The fun:** Two voices, two jobs — not a liar hunt
- **The skill:** Textbook as later school account, not “the facts”
- **Steps:** Source the textbook (later writer, school audience) before reading it as “what happened”; source the primary; ask which questions each can answer.
- **Error patterns:** “Textbook is lying”; “primary is always true.”
- **Exit ticket:** “Textbook can answer . **Primary can answer .**”

SRC-05 Summary After Source

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 25–35 min
- **Materials:** One short primary; timer
- **Safety:** None special
- **The fun:** Earning the summary after the look
- **The skill:** Summary labelled as later telling
- **Steps:** Source card (5 min) → read excerpt (8 min) → learner writes a three-sentence summary labelled “My summary (later telling).”
- **Error patterns:** Summary first; summary that ignores attribution.
- **Exit ticket:** Summary with source line named in sentence 1.

SRC-06 Memoir Written Later

- **Band:** prefer 13–14; stretch 11–12 with scaffold

- **Time:** 25–40 min
- **Materials:** Short memoir excerpt about an earlier event; date of event vs date of writing visible
- **Safety:** Soft content
- **The fun:** Two dates on one card
- **The skill:** Useful for / weak for — without discarding memory as “useless bias”
- **Steps:** Two dates on the card; what changes when memory is written years later?; still useful — for different questions.
- **Error patterns:** Discarding memoirs as “biased therefore useless.”
- **Exit ticket:** “Useful for . *Weak for* .”

AS-03 Who-Made-This Ladder

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** Ladder worksheet: maker → audience → purpose → limit
- **Safety:** None special
- **The fun:** Climbing with evidence; blank OK if unknown
- **The skill:** Attribution ladder without inventing purpose
- **Steps:** Climb with evidence from the credit line and what little of the body you uncover; blank OK if unknown.
- **Error patterns:** Inventing purpose with no clue.
- **Exit ticket:** Ladder four rungs (unknown allowed).

AS-06 Attribution First Always

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **Materials:** Five short credit lines; habit timer
- **Safety:** Keep it calm — not speed trivia cruelty
- **The fun:** Micro-drill flash of who/when/type
- **The skill:** Habit speed with honesty about unknown
- **Steps:** Five items; attribution only; learner says who/when/type.
- **Error patterns:** Turning into a speed show with no care.
- **Exit ticket:** 4/5 named or honestly “unknown.”

AS-08 Model Summary Is Not a Source

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Materials:** Chatbot or textbook summary labelled “later telling” + one primary
- **Safety:** Parent holds/co-holds any tool account (see History Hour AI box)

- **The fun:** Side-by-side refuse — summary vs piece
- **The skill:** Model summary $\neq$ source on the table
- **Steps:** Compare; refuse filing the summary as primary.
- **Error patterns:** Using summary to skip the primary forever.
- **Exit ticket:** “Summary = later telling; primary = ____.”

Out-of-home try-its

OUT-01 Library Primary Hunt

- **Time:** 30–60 min including travel
- **Materials:** Library card; notebook; pencil
- **Safety:** Aisle courtesy; adult present as needed by family rule; no cold quiz of strangers
- **The fun:** Finding one credited piece in the wild
- **The skill:** Name maker/date before reading the story
- **Steps:** Find one credited letter, image, newspaper page, or document reproduction; copy the credit line; say who/when/type before reading the exhibit story or caption book.
- **Exit ticket:** Credit line copied; one thing known before the summary.

OUT-04 Archive Screen with Adult

- **Time:** 25–40 min
- **Materials:** Computer; adult beside the student; one named collection already bookmarked by the parent
- **Safety:** Parent in the room; no unsupervised deep wander; crop screenshots to the piece, not faces
- **The fun:** Attribution first on a screen
- **The skill:** Same source-before-summary habit on digital display
- **Steps:** Open one item; read credit/metadata first; honesty card (reproduction / excerpt / uncertain); then short look.
- **Exit ticket:** Honesty card ticked for the screen piece.

One incorrect example to diagnose

A student opens the textbook chapter, narrates “what happened,” then glances at a primary in the margin as decoration. Repair: cover the textbook body; source the textbook as a later account; open one primary; ask the locked opening; wait; uncover only after attribution is said. Do not scold. Do not replace the look with

your lecture.

Another incorrect pattern: a parent prints a chatbot “colonial letter,” files it as a primary, and asks for empathy. Repair: label it modern make-believe or remove it; find a credited excerpt from a library or public-domain collection; run Header Before Body on the real piece. Generated diaries are not primaries.

Blocked practice and mixed practice

Blocked (new move): Several days in a row of attribution-before-body on fresh short pieces — Header Before Body, Caption Last, Attribution First Always. Stay here until who-when-type is said without shame.

Mixed (when to use it): Once attribution holds, mix a textbook-as-account day with a library hunt and a summary-after-source day in the same week. Mixing too early returns summary-first. Mixing too late makes the habit brittle outside the kitchen.

Library and kitchen note

Library and kitchen *are* the practice. They do not replace the looking move. A beautiful outing with no credit line said is a field trip, not this chapter’s skill. Shared looking motivates. Attribution still has to be said.

Museum one-object days belong more fully in chapter 2; if you visit this week anyway, still say maker/date/type from the label before the placard story. A plaque on a courthouse lawn is a later telling about a place — credit it as such, then save deeper plaque work for later chapters.

For the student

History at your age is not “wait until high school.” It is not “memorize the chapter until the quiz.” It is looking at a **named source** before anyone tells you the tidy story.

What this idea is

A source has a maker, a time, and a job. A summary is a later telling — useful, but not the same as the piece. Your first job is to say who made this, when, and for whom, from the credit line. Then you look. Then you may summarize — and label your summary as yours.

You are not failing if you revise. Revising after you uncover the body is what looking looks like.

Tiny worked example

A letter sits on the table. The body is covered. You see: a name at the top, a date, “Dear Mother.” You say: “Someone wrote to their mother on this date.” You do not yet say what the war was “really about.” You uncover one paragraph. You revise what you thought the letter was for. That revise is success, not failure.

Second tiny example: a textbook paragraph and a short diary day about the same week. The textbook was written later for students. The diary was written closer to the day for a private or family audience. Ask: what can each answer? You do not need to crown a winner.

Two tries

1. Cover the body of today’s piece. Say maker, date, and type out loud. Then uncover.
2. Write one sentence that starts with the source name: “According to [maker / title], dated [year], ...” Before any big story.

Explain it back

Explain to a parent or sibling: what is the difference between a source and a summary? Use today’s piece as your example. Point at the credit line while you talk.

Challenge

Find one caption or textbook sentence that sounds like “the facts.” Name who wrote that sentence (author, publisher, or “later school book”) and what question a primary beside it might answer that the textbook cannot.

If someone offers you a “primary” that a computer just wrote, ask for the credit line. If there is no maker-from-then, it is not the day’s source.

A third try (optional stretch)

Take a caption you already uncovered once. Cover it again. Write three Observe notes with no guesses. Only then Reflect. Compare your Reflect to the caption. What did the credit add that your eyes alone could not know?

Band notes for you

If you are closer to eleven or twelve: saying who-when-type out loud is enough for many days. Writing it is practice, not a test.

If you are closer to thirteen or fourteen: write the attribution card yourself. Add one limitation: “This source cannot tell us ____.” Keep the limitation tied to the kind of text — a letter cannot show every person in a city; a textbook cannot show one person’s exact words that day.

You are allowed to wait. You may change your mind when you look. Point at the line.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1: Summary spills out before the credit line.

Next move: Physically cover the body. Ask the locked opening. Wait. Uncover only after who-when-type is said. Practice SRC-05 so the summary is earned. If archaic prose is the blocker, read the credit line aloud — access, not rescue of the thinking — then return the look to them.

Diagnostic 2: “The textbook is the truth / the primary is always true.”

Next move: Run SRC-03. Ask which question each can answer. Refuse both “textbook is lying” and “primary never errs” as first moves. Keep heat low; the skill is kinds of voice, not a fight about a favorite book.

Diagnostic 3: Freeze, year-hunt, or “I’m not a history kid.”

Next move: Soften the question to what they *see* on the credit line. Scaffold archaic words as access. Place by skill — stay on attribution until it holds after a night.

Screening a skill is not an identity label. A human tutor who will sit with a piece (not a percentile coach) helps if home hours stay stuck for weeks; shame does not.

When to slow down: attribution still collapses after a night. Stay here.

When to go ahead: fresh-piece who-when-type holds; one thing known before summary; parent can hear summary-first and return to the card.

When to get a human tutor: weeks of freeze despite covered-body practice and softer questions — look for someone who teaches looking, not only coverage.

Extra repairs for common mix-ups

Shine-equals-then leftover. A glossy reprint feels “more real” than a plain photocopy of a letter. Repair: honesty card. A labelled reproduction is fine when labelled. Gloss is not proof.

Unsigned piece panic. No maker on the page. Repair: say “unknown.” Ask what *kind* of text it still appears to be. Do not invent a famous author to rescue discomfort.

Sibling blurts the summary. Repair: thank them for waiting next time; return the question to the student whose turn it is; look at the credit line together. Shared looking is good. Stolen looking is not.

Parent anxiety fills the silence. You feel rude waiting. Repair: look at the piece, not at the adolescent. Count three again. The silence is part of the teaching.

Hearing a wrong reason, asking a better question, then naming a better move is teaching. Silence in the face of pure summary-first is not kindness. A scolding lecture is not teaching either. Correct a wrong reason without crushing the look.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers for you, the adult. Keep this short. The full allow/ban list lives in **the History Hour** AI box.

You may ask a tool, on your account (held at 11–12; co-held at 13–14, still in the room), to explain this week’s idea to *you* from a named page, to draft a PARENT KEY practice sheet of blank attribution cards, or to write a SCRIPT you will say *after* they try attribution. Unaided first on looking and sourcing. SCRIPT after the try.

You may not put a model summary on the table as the source, generate a diary as if it were real, photo-to-key a worksheet, write their claim for them, or leave an unsupervised chatbot as the only partner during the attempt. TTS may open access to a longer survey chapter; it does not replace eyes on today’s credited piece when looking is the lesson.

One crutch reminder, labelled OFF-AGE for literacy/history: in a high-school math trial, an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse with the window closed (Bastani et al., 2025). The kitchen rule: the model may prepare you; it may not do their looking or sourcing when that is the lesson. Detectors fail (Liang); do not detector-grade a sourcing sentence. Fabricated citations are parent-side (Walters and Wilder) — open the real LOC or C3 page yourself. Hermes 4 is not Hermes Agent. Grok is not Grok Bot. No Grok Bot education SKU. Agents are not chatbots. Not a secret friend.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on from this chapter’s spine:

- ☐ Student can say maker, date, and type from a credit line on a **fresh** piece before hearing the summary.
- ☐ Student can name one thing known from the source before the summary story.
- ☐ Parent can hear summary-first, textbook-as-primary, year-first, birthday gate, and model-summary-as-source — and return to the attribution card without a fight.
- ☐ At least one in-home and one out-of-home try-it completed this month.
- ☐ Notebook dated under **History** or **Social Studies** with a named source line — never a brand, never Young Minds History I.
- ☐ **11–12:** oral or one-sentence exit holds after a night. **13–14:** written attribution card plus one limitation holds after a night.
- ☐ Skill showable two ways when possible (oral + written, or two different pieces).

Place by skill, not birthday. A “grade 7 social studies workbook” is a publisher’s scope, not a legal grade, and not a transcript line. Revisit yesterday’s source card for two minutes next Tuesday. Mix one old credit line with a new piece. Stop while a look remains.

Then go to chapter 2 to deepen Observe→Reflect→Question — still with source before summary as the non-negotiable open.

Encouragement for this week (specific)

Parent: put the attribution card down before the story. Practice who-when-why alone for five minutes with tomorrow's piece. Hear summary-first without filling the silence with the year.

Student: cover the body until you can say who made this, when, and for whom. Name one thing you know before the summary story. You may revise when you uncover.

If Friday's diagnostic shows summary-first again, that is information, not failure. Return to the covered body Monday. Skill, not birthday.

Chapter 2 — Reading a source



Figure 4: An attribution card, a short excerpt, and Observe/Reflect/Question stickies — still-life, no people, no logos.

Why this matters

Chapter 1 put the credit line before the story. This chapter teaches the look itself: **Observe** → **Reflect** → **Question** on a document or image, with the credit line and honesty card as part of the look.

Objects, images, and short document excerpts are sources adolescents can look at. Observe→Reflect→Question is the young looker’s tool grown into purpose and audience. The honesty card — original / excerpt / translation / reproduction — keeps the look honest. These moves do not mint mini-historians by themselves. They make curiosity and evidence use practiceable on a real piece-from-then.

Without Observe, Reflect becomes a first-second vibe and Question becomes a quiz. Without the credit line, a caption does the thinking. Without an honesty card, a glossy reprint or a generated scene quietly files itself as “the real thing.”

Worth the struggle: once ORQ is a habit on short excerpts, two-account weeks, civic edges, and claim writing have a shared looking language. The Library of Congress Teaching with Primary Sources grain names primary sources as raw materials from the time under study and offers Observe–Reflect–Question as the portable tool. Use it. Do not claim it certifies a twelve-year-old as a professional historian.

This chapter ages up looking without reprinting younger than/now scripts. Coin Clues and kitchen memory games stay in the 5–10 book. Here the noun is a credited excerpt, an honesty card, and a sticky triad on purpose. Critical thinking and English sister books own present-tense judgment and literacy craft; this hour owns looking at a *past* piece with a maker. One pointer each, then teach history looking.

National inquiry frameworks for grades 6–8 ask students to detect limitations and explain how sources are useful for specific historical questions. That language can stay in the notes. On the table it sounds like: “What can’t this source tell us?” and “This helps answer ____ because ____.”

For the parent: understand it yourself

Everyday picture

You open a package. Before you decide what it “means,” you notice what is actually there: size, labels, damage, smell. That is Observe. Then you guess what it is

for — Reflect. Then you wonder what you still need to know — Question. Skip Observe and you invent a story from the shipping label alone. History looking on a letter or photo is the same discipline with the past.

Precise picture

Observe: only what you can point to on the page or object — words, dates, seals, clothing, masthead, smudges, layout.

Reflect: what those details might suggest about maker, audience, purpose, or setting — labelled as a thoughtful guess tied to what you saw.

Question: what you still wonder, and what another piece might need to show.

Primary sources are incomplete snippets. Successful use needs careful selection and planning. Your job is to choose one short excerpt or image the hour can actually hold, put the credit line in view, and keep Observe first.

Sourcing still comes before the body when meta-data is available. Sometimes you cover the meta on purpose (AS-02) so the student hunts authorship clues in the body, then revises when the credit is revealed. That is still source-before-summary in spirit: attribution is earned and checked, not skipped.

What counts as a source this chapter: newspaper voice with masthead; diary day (honest excerpt); soft political cartoon; speech excerpt; ship manifest or list kept soft; image pair of related scenes; museum postcard with reproduction honesty; short civic clause only if you already source it as a document (deeper civic edges live in chapter 5).

What does not: unmarked AI diary; generated painting filed as evidence; caption-only “looking”; five-document packets that drown the hour; live culture-war cartoons as the default piece.

Knowledge constraint, one plain sentence: a student cannot Reflect well about a world they have no picture of. Give the piece and a tiny story after Observe — not a forty-minute lecture before anyone has pointed at a line. Working memory likes one or two pieces, short excerpts, and an exit that fits on a sticky. An encyclopedia hour overloads and leaves few traces.

Translation honesty belongs here. A modernized spelling version is useful access. It is not the eighteenth-century voice itself. Flag it. Prefer the labelled pair (archaic + modernized) when the prose would otherwise block Observe.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **Caption-only guess.** Eyes never leave the placard or caption. Usually means Observe was skipped. Cover the caption; force three Observe notes.
2. **All sources equal / no maker.** “It’s just information.” Usually means attribution dissolved. Return to who/when/for whom from the credit line.
3. **Unmarked reproduction as “the real thing.”** Glossy reprint treated as the original artifact. Usually means honesty card was skipped. Tick reproduction / excerpt / translation.
4. **Generated primary filed as real.** A chatbot letter or scene used as evidence. Usually means convenience beat honesty. Label fiction or remove; find a credited piece.
5. **Skipping Observe.** Jumping to “I think they felt...” or “the point is...” Usually means Reflect stole the first minute. Stay in Observe for a full slow minute before any Reflect sentence.

Parent warm-up (5–8 minutes, alone)

Run Observe → Reflect → Question on tomorrow’s image or excerpt alone. Force yourself to stay in Observe for a full minute before any Reflect sentence. Check the honesty card. Cover the meta until who-when-why is said, then uncover. Write one wonder that could drive a next piece — not “google until true,” but a realistic next source type (another letter, a map, a roster, a later newspaper).

How to teach it this week

Session shape

History Hour five beats. Focus: **reading a source with ORQ + credit line.**

1. **Attribution / honesty card (4–8).** Who / when / type / for whom; original–excerpt–translation–reproduction.
2. **Short look — Observe first (5–12).** Sticky triad. No Reflect before Observe.
3. **Short background or talk (5–10).** Minimal context after Observe; one authentic question.
4. **One try (8–15).** DOC-01 One Question One Excerpt, or AS-01 Sticky Triad, or DOC-03 Diary Day.

5. **Exit ticket (2–4).** Three stickies placed; or starred line + “This helps answer ____ because ____.”

Exact wording you can say:

- “Who made this, when, and for whom — and what makes you say that from the credit line?”
- “What do you *see* or *read* — only what you can point to?”
- “Now Reflect: what might that suggest — tied to what you saw?”
- “What can’t this source tell us?”
- “What do you wonder that could drive a next piece?”

First try-it for the student

Sticky Triad (AS-01). Three stickies: Observe / Reflect / Question. Fill in order. No Reflect before Observe. Exit: three stickies placed on or beside the piece.

How to fade help

Start: You model one full Observe minute out loud (“I see a masthead date; I see a column titled...”).

Middle: They fill Observe; you hold Reflect until they have three concrete notes.

Later: They run the triad alone; you ask only the locked opening and one limitation question. At 13–14, they annotate one claim the author wants the reader to believe.

When to stop talking

During Observe. Your voice is the enemy of their pointing finger. After Question, wait before you supply the “right” wonder. If archaic prose blocks, read one sentence aloud as access — then return eyes and talk to them.

Age-band moves

11–12. Adult reads archaic lines. Prefer DOC-01, DOC-02, DOC-03, DOC-06, AS-01, AS-05. Soft cartoons only with heavy scaffold if at all. Oral exit OK.

13–14. Student annotates one claim the maker wants believed. DOC-04 Political Cartoon Soft (period, not live culture-war). DOC-07 Image Pair. AS-02 Cover

the Meta. AS-04 Further Investigation Mini with a realistic next source type. Still one or two pieces — not a packet dump.

Struggle before rescue (this chapter's timing)

Minute 0–2: Credit line and honesty card. Locked opening. Wait.

Minute 2–6: Observe only. You model one pointing sentence if needed, then stop. Sticky notes fill.

Minute 6–9: Reflect — each guess must point back at an Observe note. Hint = “which detail makes you say that?” not the finished interpretation.

Minute 9–12: Question — one wonder; optional next source type.

Minute 12–20: One DOC try or deepen the same piece with a central question card.

Minute 20–24: Exit ticket. Stop while a look remains.

If you dump context in minute one, Observe never happens. If you praise only clever Reflect lines, students skip pointing. Rescue that replaces looking with the adult's lecture teaches the wrong habit.

Materials checklist for the week

- One image or short excerpt with a visible credit line.
- Three stickies (Observe / Reflect / Question) or a notebook triad.
- Honesty cards.
- One central-question card for DOC-01 days.
- Optional: newspaper masthead page; diary excerpt; list/roster; speech paragraph; period cartoon (13–14); two related images; archaic + modernized pair.
- Museum or thrift plan for one out-of-home try; plaque walk as backup.

Sample week (illustration)

Labelled hypothetical — not a reported family and not a law.

- Monday: AS-01 Sticky Triad + talk box on one image or short excerpt.
- Tuesday: DOC-01 One Question, One Excerpt.

- Wednesday: SRC-04 Honesty Card Drill or AS-05 Reproduction Honesty Card + DOC-03 Diary Day.
- Thursday: OUT-02 Museum One Object (or OUT-05 thrift mystery soft; or OUT-03 plaque if weather wins).
- Friday: Diagnostic — caption-only guess repaired with covered caption; exit ticket Observe/Reflect/Question; done-enough.

Three-hour version: Monday Sticky Triad, Wednesday DOC-01, Friday honesty card + diagnostic.

Parent picture: fading help across two weeks

Week A: You model Observe out loud every day. They copy the triad with your pointing finger nearby.

Week B: You ask the locked opening only. They fill Observe alone. You intervene only if Reflect starts without a pointable detail, or if an honesty card is blank.

If Week B collapses, return to Week A grain for three days — skill, not birthday. A thirteen-year-old may need Week A scaffolds on archaic prose while still writing limitations on easier pieces. Split the try; keep the respect.

Safety and soft-entry reminder

Safe history objects only this chapter: credited excerpts, newspaper voice, diary day, soft cartoon, speech excerpt, list soft, image pair, civic clause with card, museum postcard, plaque as later telling. Soft entry on hard past. Graphic violence and atrocity images are not the default piece box. A thrift object is a mystery for Observe — not a lecture to a stranger's child and not a stolen "test" item.

Practice that actually builds learning

Talk box

Opening (locked): "Who made this, when, and for whom — and what makes you say that from the credit line?"

Follow-ups:

1. What do you *see* / *read*?
2. What was the maker trying to do?
3. What can't this source tell us?
4. What do you wonder that could drive a next piece?
5. How could we check with one more piece? (lean 13–14)

How to wait: Count three after the opening. During Observe, tolerate pointing silence. After Reflect, wait before correcting. Look at the piece if the silence is hard.

Stuck silence usually means: Observe was skipped and they fear a “wrong” Reflect; the question was year-first; the excerpt is too hard without a scaffold; they think looking means reading the caption; they offered a summary-only guess. Return to “what can you point to?” Fix the question. Scaffold one hard sentence, then wait again.

In-home try-its — DOC bank

DOC-01 One Question, One Excerpt

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 25–40 min
- **Materials:** Central historical question on a card; one scaffolded excerpt
- **Safety:** Low-heat question the document can actually speak to
- **The fun:** Starring lines that speak / do not speak to the question
- **The skill:** One question, one excerpt — not a five-document packet
- **Steps:** Pose question; source; read; mark lines that speak to the question; lines that do not.
- **Error patterns:** Question the document cannot answer; packet overload.
- **Exit ticket:** Starred line + “This helps answer ____ because ____.”

DOC-02 Newspaper Voice

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 25–35 min
- **Materials:** Short historical newspaper excerpt with masthead/date
- **Safety:** Soft topic; no live culture-war pair
- **The fun:** Masthead as a voice with readers
- **The skill:** Claim the paper makes + missing voice
- **Steps:** Source masthead; who might readers have been?; one claim; one missing voice.

- **Error patterns:** “Newspapers then were neutral”; mocking old ads as the whole past.
- **Exit ticket:** Claim + missing voice.

DOC-03 Diary Day (honest excerpt)

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 25–35 min
- **Materials:** Real diary excerpt (library / LOC printout) or labelled reproduction — never unmarked AI
- **Safety:** Soft day; no forced trauma narrative
- **The fun:** One day as a narrow window
- **The skill:** Can tell / cannot tell
- **Steps:** Source; what can one day tell?; what can it not?
- **Error patterns:** Completing a whole life from one day; AI diary.
- **Exit ticket:** Can tell / cannot tell two-column.

DOC-04 Political Cartoon Soft

- **Band:** prefer 13–14; careful 11–12
- **Time:** 25–40 min
- **Materials:** Period cartoon with analysis prompts; avoid live culture-war cartoons
- **Safety:** Soft symbols; adult supplies minimal context after Observe
- **The fun:** Symbol hunt without a modern party dump
- **The skill:** Observe symbols → Reflect audience/purpose → Question
- **Steps:** Observe symbols; Reflect; Question; then tiny context.
- **Error patterns:** Jumping to modern party labels; inflammatory modern cartoons.
- **Exit ticket:** “Symbol ____ seems to stand for ____ (guess).”

DOC-05 Speech Excerpt

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 25–40 min
- **Materials:** One famous speech paragraph with date/place/audience card
- **Safety:** No present-politics dump
- **The fun:** Audience first, then words
- **The skill:** Then-problem the speaker addressed
- **Steps:** Source audience first; then words; what problem *then*?
- **Error patterns:** Quoting out of context as a meme.
- **Exit ticket:** Audience + one then-problem.

DOC-06 Ship Manifest / List Soft

- **Band:** both

- **Time:** 20–35 min
- **Materials:** Passenger list / roster excerpt (names, ages, places)
- **Safety:** Keep soft; no trauma deep-dive without readiness
- **The fun:** A list as a made thing with a job
- **The skill:** Purpose of list + one limit
- **Steps:** What was this list for?; what does a list hide?; one human question we cannot answer from the list alone.
- **Error patterns:** Forced family trauma narrative; treating list as a novel.
- **Exit ticket:** Purpose of list + one limit.

DOC-07 Image Pair Same Event

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 25–40 min
- **Materials:** Two images of related scenes; captions covered then revealed
- **Safety:** Soft images
- **The fun:** What each includes / leaves out
- **The skill:** Image as account (bridge toward corroboration in ch03)
- **Steps:** Source each; includes/leaves out; captions last.
- **Error patterns:** “Camera never lies.”
- **Exit ticket:** Included / left out for each image.

In-home try-its — AS bank and honesty

AS-01 Sticky Triad — see first try-it above.

AS-02 Cover the Meta

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Materials:** Document with attribution covered then revealed
- **Safety:** No shame for wrong guess
- **The fun:** Guess → reveal → revise
- **The skill:** Body clues checked against credit
- **Exit ticket:** Guess → reveal → revise note.

AS-05 Reproduction Honesty Card

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 10–15 min
- **Materials:** Honesty card template
- **Safety:** None special
- **The fun:** Ticking truth about the piece

- **The skill:** Original / excerpt / translation / reproduction / illustration / uncertain
- **Exit ticket:** Card completed for today's piece.

SRC-04 Honesty Card Drill

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 15–20 min
- **Materials:** Three items: original scan printout, labelled reproduction, unmarked modern “aged” image (parent-made for teaching)
- **Safety:** Teaching prop clearly owned by parent — not a gotcha on the learner
- **The fun:** Sort real primary / labelled reproduction / not honest as primary
- **The skill:** One honesty rule stated aloud
- **Exit ticket:** One honesty rule.

SRC-07 Translation / Modernization Flag

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** Short archaic excerpt + modernized version side by side (labelled)
- **Safety:** None special
- **The fun:** Spotting what modernization might change
- **The skill:** Prefer marking “modernized spelling” when used
- **Exit ticket:** Circle one word that changed meaning risk.

AS-03 Who-Made-This Ladder (carry from chapter 1 when attribution is thin)

- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** Ladder: maker → audience → purpose → limit
- **The skill:** Climb with evidence; blank OK
- **Exit ticket:** Four rungs (unknown allowed)

AS-06 Attribution First Always (micro-drill warm-up before a hard DOC day)

- **Time:** 10–20 min
- **The skill:** Who/when/type flash with honesty about unknown
- **Exit ticket:** 4/5 named or “unknown”

AS-08 Model Summary Is Not a Source (when a tool or textbook summary sneaks onto the table)

- **Time:** 15–25 min
- **Materials:** Labelled later telling + one primary
- **The skill:** Refuse filing the summary as primary
- **Exit ticket:** “Summary = later telling; primary = ____.”

AS-04 Further Investigation Mini

- **Band:** both
- **Time:** 20–30 min
- **Materials:** “What more do you want to know / how find out?” card
- **Safety:** No “AI as next source without label”
- **The fun:** One realistic next source type
- **The skill:** Question + next source type (not infinite questions)
- **Exit ticket:** Question + next source type.

Out-of-home try-its

OUT-02 Museum One Object

- **Time:** 30–60 min including travel
- **Materials:** Ticket if needed; notebook; pencil
- **Safety:** Hands-off rules; aisle courtesy; no photographing strangers without care
- **The fun:** One object, eyes first
- **The skill:** Observe before placard; then who wrote the placard
- **Steps:** Choose one object; Observe before reading placard; then placard; credit the label as a later telling.
- **Exit ticket:** Three Observe notes + one placard credit fact.

OUT-03 Courthouse / Plaque Read

- **Time:** 20–40 min
- **Materials:** Notebook
- **Safety:** Public sidewalk norms; plaque is not a sermon about a city
- **The fun:** Reading a place’s later telling
- **The skill:** Credit the plaque as print about a place
- **Steps:** Read plaque; who made this plaque / when if said; what job is it doing; what can’t it tell.
- **Exit ticket:** Maker/date if known + one limit.

OUT-05 Thrift / Antique Mystery Soft

- **Time:** 20–40 min
- **Materials:** Small budget optional; notebook
- **Safety:** Aisle courtesy; no tasting; no shoplifting a “test”; no cold oral-history quiz of strangers
- **The fun:** One object’s clues
- **The skill:** Observe → Reflect → Question on a made thing
- **Exit ticket:** Observe three + one Question.

One incorrect example to diagnose

A student reads the museum placard first, then glances at the object to confirm the placard's story. Repair: back up; cover or ignore the placard for two minutes; three Observe notes; then placard; ask what the placard adds and who wrote it. Do not scold. Do not turn the gallery into a lecture.

Another incorrect pattern: skipping Observe on a diary day and performing empathy ("they must have felt exactly like me"). Repair: can-tell / cannot-tell columns; their-world prompt saved for chapter 4 if judgmental language appears; keep today's win on what the day can and cannot show.

Composite incorrect hour (illustration)

Labelled hypothetical. A parent opens three documents, asks "what do you think happened," accepts a summary, skips the credit lines, and ends with a chatbot paragraph "for enrichment." Repair for tomorrow: one excerpt only; honesty card; locked opening; Observe minute; exit sticky triad; chatbot paragraph labelled later telling or removed. Coverage itch is the enemy of looking. One real piece beats a medley.

Blocked and mixed

Blocked: Several ORQ days on single pieces (Sticky Triad, One Question One Excerpt, Diary Day).

Mixed: Once Observe holds, mix newspaper voice, list soft, and museum one object in one week. Mixing before Observe holds returns caption-only guessing.

For the student

A source is something made then that you can look at now — a letter, a photo, a newspaper page, a list, a speech paragraph, a cartoon from then. Your tool is simple: **Observe, Reflect, Question.**

What this idea is

Observe means point to what is there. Words. Dates. Hats. Mastheads. Smudges.

Reflect means say what those details might suggest — and tie the guess to what

you saw.

Question means name what you still wonder, and what another piece might need to show.

The credit line is part of the look. The honesty card is part of the look. A summary is still a later telling.

Tiny worked example

A newspaper page: you Observe the masthead date and a headline. You do not yet say “the whole city believed X.” You Reflect that the paper was written for readers that day. You Question who is missing from the story. Then you may read a short body paragraph and revise.

Two tries

1. Put three stickies on today’s piece: Observe / Reflect / Question. Fill Observe first with at least three pointable details.
2. Point to the credit line. Say maker, date, and type before you hear the summary. Tick the honesty card.

Explain it back

Explain ORQ to someone at home using today’s piece. Point while you talk. If you skip Observe in your explanation, try again.

Challenge

Cover a caption. Write three Observe notes. Uncover. What did the credit add that your eyes alone could not know? If you are ready for a stretch (closer to 13–14), mark one sentence or symbol that seems to push a claim — what does the maker want you to believe?

A third try

On a list or ship manifest excerpt: write the purpose of the list in one line, then one thing the list hides. Lists feel “objective.” They still have makers and jobs.

Band notes for you

Closer to eleven or twelve: three Observe notes and a spoken credit line are a full win many days.

Closer to thirteen or fourteen: add what the source cannot tell, and one realistic next piece (another letter, a map, a later newspaper — not “ask a chatbot until it agrees”).

If a tool offers you a “primary diary” with no credit from then, ask for the maker and date. No maker-from-then means it is not today’s source.

You are allowed to wait. You may change your mind when you look. Point at the line.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1: Caption-only or summary-only looking.

Next move: Cover caption and body meta. Force a full Observe minute. Sticky Triad in order. Uncover credit after Observe notes exist.

Diagnostic 2: All sources treated as equal / no maker / unmarked reproduction as original.

Next move: Honesty card every day this week. SRC-04 drill once. AS-05 on the museum postcard. Say “labelled reproduction is OK when labelled.”

Diagnostic 3: Skipping Observe into feelings or generated “primary.”

Next move: Return to pointable details. Remove unmarked AI letters. Find a credited excerpt. If freeze persists because prose is hard, scaffold one sentence as access, then resume their Observe. If weeks stay stuck, a human who will sit with a piece helps; a percentile coach does not.

When to slow down: Observe still collapses into vibe. Stay on Sticky Triad.

When to go ahead: credit line said; Observe notes before Reflect; honesty card ticked; one wonder that names a next source type.

When to get help: persistent freeze or shame spirals despite scaffolds — seek a calm human partner for looking, not a coverage tutor only.

Extra repairs

Reflect as mind-reading. “She felt exactly...” with no line to point to. Repair: “Which words on the page make you say that?” If none, return to Observe.

Question as infinite scroll. Twenty wonders, no next source type. Repair: pick one wonder; name one realistic next piece kind.

Museum freeze. Too many objects. Repair: one object rule. Observe before placard. Leave the rest for another visit.

Sibling reads the placard aloud first. Repair: thank them; restart with eyes on the object; placard second.

Parent fills Reflect because silence feels rude. Repair: look at the piece; count three; ask only “what else do you see?”

Correct a wrong reason without crushing the look. “Never correct the adolescent” is not this book’s rule. Shame is not the method either.

Tools, including AI

Point back to the History Hour AI box.

You may ask a tool (parent account held at 11–12; co-held at 13–14, still in the room) for a SCRIPT after they try ORQ, for PARENT KEY practice with blank sticky frames, or for discussion questions you will vet. Unaided first on the look.

You may not generate a diary as if real, file a model summary as the source, replace looking with TTS for today’s piece, detector-grade their triad, or hand them an agent as a history partner. Looking together at a generated scene labelled as modern make-believe can be a two-minute honesty lesson — then remove it and put a named reproduction on the table.

Bastani’s high-school math caution stays OFF-AGE for this literacy/history band — one reminder only: the model may prepare you; it may not finish their Observe or invent a diary. Liang: do not detector-grade a sticky triad. Walters and Wilder: fluent fake citations are a parent-side hazard — open the real LOC page. Hermes Agent and Grok Bot are not partners for the attempt. Not a secret friend.

What “done enough” looks like

- ☐ Student says who / when / for whom from the credit line and points to what makes them say that.
- ☐ Observe notes exist before Reflect sentences on a fresh piece.
- ☐ Honesty card ticked (original / excerpt / translation / reproduction / uncertain).
- ☐ Student can name what the source cannot tell.
- ☐ One in-home DOC or AS try-it and one out-of-home try-it done this month.
- ☐ Notebook dated under **History** or **Social Studies** with named source + ORQ crumb.
- ☐ **11–12:** oral triad or starred-line exit holds after a night. **13–14:** written limitation or “claim the maker wants” annotation holds after a night.
- ☐ Parent can hear caption-only, unmarked reproduction, and generated-primary patterns — and repair without a fight.

Place by skill, not birthday. Revisit one sticky triad next week on a new piece. Then move to chapter 3 for two accounts — still opening with a credit line on each.

Encouragement for this week (specific)

Parent: cover the meta until who-when-why is said. Practice the honesty card alone. Stay in Observe for a full minute on tomorrow’s piece before any Reflect sentence of your own.

Student: point to the credit line; say maker, date, and type; fill Observe before Reflect. You may revise when the caption is uncovered.

More on what “done enough” feels like in the room

You will hear fewer caption-first answers. You will see fingers on lines. You will hear “I don’t know — the credit doesn’t say” without panic. You will see an honesty card get ticks even on busy days. Friday’s fresh piece will still get Observe notes before a clever story. That is done enough to open chapter 3’s two accounts — each with its own credit line.

If Observe holds but attribution from chapter 1 has slipped, spend one day back on Header Before Body, then return. Source before summary remains the open of

every hour; ORQ is the look that follows.

Connection forward (one paragraph)

Chapter 3 will ask what matches across two accounts. That only works if each account has been read as a source — credit line, Observe, limitation. Chapter 4's their-world prompt repairs presentism after a judgmental sentence; it does not replace Observe. Chapter 5's civic clause still wants an honesty card and then-words. Keep this chapter's triad alive as the shared looking language.

Sibling and multilingual notes

Share the piece; split the try. A younger sibling may still run a shorter who-made-this look on the same object. Your 11–14 student runs the full triad and honesty card. Looking works in the family's talk language; when archaic English blocks, the adult reads one hard sentence — access — then returns the Observe to the student.

What this chapter refuses

Skipping Observe; unmarked AI image or diary as primary; treating a caption as the whole look; claiming TPS certifies a historian; five-document packet as the weekly spine; live controversy as the cartoon default; reprinting Little Thinkers activity banks with longer words.

Keep the focus lock visible: source before summary still opens the hour; early civic texts wait for their own gentle chapter unless you are only practicing honesty cards on a short public-domain clause. Depth beats coverage. Stop while a look remains.

Chapter 3 — Two sources and corroboration



Figure 5: Two short credited accounts side by side with match and differ sticky notes — still-life, no faces, no logos.

Why this matters

One source can feel like the whole past. Put a second short account of the same small event beside it, and the past gets thicker. Details match. Details differ. Each maker seems to be answering a slightly different question. That thickness is not a problem to erase. It is the work.

This chapter owns light corroboration for ages 11–14. Corroboration here means: look at two short accounts of one event, name what matches, name what differs, and say which question each account seems to answer. It does not mean a weekly Document-Based Lesson packet. It does not mean a hunt for who is lying. It does not mean merging both voices into one tidy paragraph with the makers rubbed out.

Adolescents this age can do this. Spontaneous evidence use is not the default. Many will treat both pieces as equal “facts,” or rush to declare one wrong. Classroom research on younger students found that children could talk about reliability when asked, yet still treated sources as roughly equal unless looking stayed explicit. A later progression of how students think about accounts moves from “one story must be wrong” toward “accounts answer different questions.” Your kitchen translation is ordinary: pose match and differ before “who wins,” and keep the event low-heat so the looking can land.

Classroom materials that print two excerpts and a central question supply a useful shape — short background, looking moves, talk. Materials alone do not get a student talking. Facilitation still matters. You pose. You wait. You point back at the sourced lines. That warning comes from high-school classrooms with carefully designed packets. It is a useful study of how discussion fails, not a promise that every home will see the same result, and not a coefficient you must match at the kitchen table.

Chapter 1 put the source before the summary. Chapter 2 taught Observe → Reflect → Question on a credit line. This chapter adds a second voice. The habit is light and repeatable. Two short accounts. Same / different / still wonder. Then stop before the encyclopedia hour returns.

Coverage pressure will whisper that two accounts are “slow.” Depth is the hour. A light tour of twenty events leaves few traces; a pattern built slowly on a few pieces is what the mind can keep. Two short accounts of one small event are not a delay. They are the pattern.

If you used *History for Little Thinkers*, you practiced piece-from-then and who-

made-this with younger children. This book ages that work up. Do not reprint Coin Clues with longer words. If you used *History for Homeschooling*, you may have seen a broader grade map. One pointer, then teach this 11–14 corroboration hour. Critical Thinking for Young Minds owns two-source judgment on ordinary present stakes. This hour keeps the pieces in the past, on the table, with makers named.

The locked question for this chapter is the whole move in one line:

“What matches across these two accounts — and what does each leave out or answer differently?”

If they can answer that, with sticky notes and a finger on each piece, the week did its job.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Everyday picture. Two neighbors describe the same street fair. Both say the music started late. One remembers the pie contest. One remembers the lost dog. Neither is “lying” about the fair. Each noticed what their seat and their job made easy to notice. Corroboration starts there: match, differ, and what each account is *for*.

Precise picture. Historians corroborate by checking one account against another — not to crown a winner, but to see where the record thickens and where it thins. At 11–14, the portable version is three columns or three stickies: **Same, Different, Still wonder.** Add one more move when they are ready: “Which question is Account A answering? Which question is Account B answering?” A diary day and a newspaper paragraph about the same local flood can both be honest and still not answer the same question. A later textbook paragraph is a different *kind* of voice again — often a school telling written long after. Keep kinds of voice visible on the source cards.

Lee’s plain teaching point helps here: accounts are not only right or wrong; they answer different questions from different standpoints. Barton’s classroom work reminds you that equal treatment of sources is a habit unless you keep looking explicit. Wineburg’s corroboration heuristic is the grown-up name for checking across pieces. You do not need the lab jargon at the table. You need the sticky notes.

C3 History pathways for grades 6–8 ask students to explain how perspectives shape the kinds of information available, and to organize evidence for a claim. Your kitchen version this week is smaller: two perspectives on the table, evidence starred with names attached. The claim paragraph grows more fully in Chapter 7. Here the load-bearing win is refusing the liar hunt and keeping makers visible.

A second account is not automatically “balance.” Sometimes both pieces share a blind spot. Sometimes a map corrects a narrative’s scale. Sometimes a later historian can see a pattern no single witness could. Usefulness depends on the question you are asking. Write the question. Then ask which piece helps.

Default to **low-heat** events: a ship arrival, a market day, a weather disaster told softly, a school opening, a parade, a local bridge dedication, a soft headline-versus-body on a historical newspaper reprint. Save culture-war pairs for never-as-the-default. Soft entry on hard past still applies: everyday life, tools, tickets, streets and work. Graphic violence is not the week’s piece box.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **“One must be lying.”**

The first move becomes a villain hunt.

What it usually means: accounts are being treated as a single true story with one fake narrator.

What you say: “Which question is each answering? Let’s write those questions before we judge.”

2. **Merge into one tidy story with no attribution.**

They blend details and erase who said what.

What it usually means: corroboration became summary.

What you say: “Keep two columns. Star which piece each detail came from.”

3. **Treat textbook and primary as the same kind of voice.**

The survey paragraph and the diary sit as twin “facts.”

What it usually means: kinds of source were never named.

What you say: “Who made each, when, for whom? Which is a later school telling?”

4. **Pick the piece that matches prior belief.**

Image vs text, and they keep whichever already felt true.

What it usually means: looking stopped at comfort.

What you say: “What can each show that the other cannot?”

5. **Eyewitness always wins / secondary always loses.**

A soft witness-vs-later-historian pair collapses into a slogan.

What it usually means: usefulness was not tied to a named question.

What you say: “For *this* question — who was there that hour — which is stronger? For *this* other question — what pattern emerged years later — which helps?”

Five-to-eight-minute parent warm-up

Choose two short accounts of one small, low-heat event. Fill a source card for each: maker, date, type, audience if known, honesty flag (excerpt / later printing / translation / labelled secondary).

Cover the bodies. Say the cards aloud.

Uncover. Write your own **match** list and **differ** list. Write the question each account seems to answer. Delete any “liar” language from the talk you plan to use tomorrow.

Practice the locked opening to the empty chair. Count a slow three. Do not answer yourself with the “right” merge.

If you want a SCRIPT later for *you* to say, draft four question lines now — not their finished paragraph. Point back to the History Hour AI box for the full allow-and-ban list. The student looks first. The tool does not sit as their only partner during the attempt.

How to teach it this week

The History Hour shape stays (~25–45 minutes). Corroboration is the try, not a second subject.

Session shape

1. **Source cards first (4–8 min).** Attribution for Account A, then Account B — who / when / what kind / for whom — before either body owns the table. Honesty cards if needed.
2. **Short look (5–12 min).** Observe → Reflect → Question lightly on each, or Observe on A, then B, then a joint Reflect. Do not drown them in back-

ground yet.

3. **Short background or talk (5–10 min).** Two minutes of story that both pieces need — not a chapter dump. Then the locked question.
4. **One try (8–15 min).** Same / different / still wonder. Sticky stars. Name each account’s question when they are ready.
5. **Exit ticket (2–4 min).** Spoken or written: one match, one difference, one wonder — with makers still named.

Exact wording you can say

- “What matches across these two accounts — and what does each leave out or answer differently?”
- “What do you *see* / *read* on Account A that also shows up on Account B?”
- “What does each maker want you to notice?”
- “Which question is each answering?”
- “What would a third piece need to show?”
- “You may revise without calling either a liar.”
- “Keep the names on the columns. Do not erase who said what.”

First try-it for the student

Put CORR-01 on the table: Same Event, Two Voices. Two very short excerpts. Source both. Star one matching detail. List one difference. Say one thing you still wonder. That is enough for the first day.

Fade help

Early week: you read archaic lines; you model one match sticky. Midweek: they source the second card with less prompting; they draft the differ list. Late week: they name each account’s question before you do; at 13–14 they say what a third piece would need. Fade the adult merge. Keep the two source cards visible.

When to stop talking

After the locked question. After they attempt a match sticky — wait before you fill the board with your historian voice. Do not turn the try into a lecture on “bias” as a scare word. Point at lines. Stop while a look remains.

Age-band moves

11–12. Two very short excerpts. Oral exit is honest: same / different / still wonder said aloud. Adult scaffolds hard prose. Prefer CORR-01, CORR-02 (image vs

text), CORR-05 (headline vs body on a historical reprint), CORR-04 only with family consent and care. Keep the event small and low-heat.

13–14. Add CORR-03 Witness vs Later Historian Soft (label the secondary). Add CORR-06 Map vs Narrative. Ask what a third piece would need to show. Compare accounts that answer different questions out loud. Still not a full AP DBQ. Still not a culture-war pair as the default.

Place by skill, not birthday. A fourteen-year-old stuck on “one must be lying” does the sticky-question repair without apology. An eleven-year-old ready for image-vs-text should not wait for a birthday.

Struggle before rescue (this week’s honesty).

After the locked question, wait. If silence is empty because the question was mushy, fix the question: make it about match and differ on *these* two pieces. If silence is empty because the prose is hard, scaffold one sentence aloud — that is access, not rescue of the thinking. If they jump to a tidy merge, return to the source cards and the two columns. A hint is a question (“What does Account B say about the weather that Account A never mentions?”), not your finished historian paragraph.

Knowledge first. A student cannot corroborate accounts of a world they have no picture of. Give the tiny story both pieces need — two minutes, not forty. Do not demand multi-perspective analysis of an unfamiliar world with no background at all. Order stays: source cards → short look → short background → try → exit.

Working-memory design. Prefer two pieces on the table this week, not five. Short excerpts. Exit as a few spoken or written lines. An encyclopedia hour overloads and leaves few traces. If a day only holds twenty-five minutes, run source cards + one Observe pass on each + same/different sticky + exit ticket.

Hypothetical week (illustration only — not a calendar)

Focus move: two-account corroboration on one local or soft historical event.

- **Mon:** CORR-01 Same Event, Two Voices. Exit: same / different / still wonder.
- **Tue:** CTX crumb if presentism appears — one their-world prompt — then return to the two accounts. Or AS-07 Two Pieces, One Question with a fresh pair.
- **Wed:** CORR-02 Image vs Text on a related soft topic.

- **Thu:** OUT-01 Library Primary Hunt — find a second short telling of the same local event (or OUT-07 Newsroom History Soft on a historical newspaper reprint).
- **Fri:** Diagnostic wrong: “one must be lying.” Repair with question stickies. Done-enough checklist.

Practice that actually builds learning

Library, archive screen, museum, and kitchen *are* the practice. They do not replace the looking move. Name time, materials, safety, the fun, and the skill.

In-home try-it — CORR-01 Same Event, Two Voices

- **Time:** 30–45 minutes (or split across two shorter Hours).
- **Materials:** Two short excerpts on one event; source cards for each; sticky notes or a three-column sheet (Same / Different / Still wonder).
- **Safety:** Ordinary kitchen courtesies. Choose low-heat content. No culture-war pair as the default piece box.
- **The fun:** Detective table without a villain hunt — two voices, one event, sticky stars.
- **The skill:** Match / differ / which question each answers; refuse “one must be lying” as the first move.

How: Source A. Source B. Short look. Locked opening. Star matches. List differs. Name each account’s question when ready. Exit ticket: Same / different / still wonder.

In-home try-it — CORR-02 Image vs Text

- **Time:** 25–40 minutes.
- **Materials:** One image + one short text on a related topic; credit lines visible; honesty card if the image is a reproduction.
- **Safety:** Soft images only. No atrocity pictures as the default. Museum hands-off rules if you printed a postcard of an object.
- **The fun:** Two media, one puzzle — what can a picture show that a paragraph cannot?

- **The skill:** What each can show; what each cannot; where they agree; refuse preferring whichever matches prior belief.

How: Source both. Observe the image for a full minute before the caption lecture. Read the short text. Ask where they agree and what cannot be compared. Exit: Agree / cannot compare — with a reason tied to the pieces.

In-home try-it — CORR-03 Witness vs Later Historian Soft (13–14; stretch 11–12 with heavy scaffold)

- **Time:** 30–45 minutes.
- **Materials:** Short eyewitness excerpt + short later secondary paragraph **labelled secondary**; source cards.
- **Safety:** Soft topic. Label kinds of voice honestly. Keep quotations sourced from the pieces on the table.
- **The fun:** Time gap on the table — who was there, who wrote later, what each is good for.
- **The skill:** Strength of each for a named question; refuse “secondary always worse” and “eyewitness always wins.”

How: Source both. Ask what “later” can add (pattern, archives, distance) and what it risks (thesis, missing the hour). Exit: Strength of each for a named question.

In-home try-it — CORR-04 Family Story + Outside Piece

- **Time:** 25–40 minutes.
- **Materials:** Consented family oral detail + one outside primary or secondary piece on the same soft theme (work, school, migration soft, a town fair).
- **Safety:** Family consent first. Thank the teller. No cold-quizzing relatives. No treating family as “the only past.” No cold public quiz of strangers for “oral history.”
- **The fun:** Living memory beside an outside piece — overlap without a fight.
- **The skill:** Compare without declaring family “wrong”; exit Family detail / outside detail / overlap.

How: Hear the family detail with thanks. Source the outside piece. Ask what overlaps and what each uniquely holds. Exit ticket as above.

In-home try-it — CORR-05 Headline vs Body

- **Time:** 20–30 minutes.
- **Materials:** Historical newspaper reprint or historical-topic article with a headline (keep low-stakes; not a live partisan gotcha).
- **Safety:** No live culture-war news as the week’s only content. Ordinary courtesy if you print at a library.
- **The fun:** Predict from the headline, then check the body like a gentle fact-check.
- **The skill:** Corroborate headline against body; exit Headline fair / stretched / unsupported (pick one with reason).

How: Source. Predict from headline. Read body. Compare. Locked follow-up: “How do you know from *this* line?”

In-home try-it — CORR-06 Map vs Narrative

- **Time:** 25–40 minutes.
- **Materials:** Period or modern map of a then-place + short travel, migration, or soft journey narrative.
- **Safety:** Ordinary map use. No adventure-movie travel times as “fact.”
- **The fun:** Distances argue with the story’s scale.
- **The skill:** What the map forces you to notice; where the narrative simplifies; one map correction to the story’s scale.

How: Source both. Trace a route or span with a finger. Ask what time or distance the map makes hard to ignore. Exit: One map correction to the story’s scale.

In-home crumb — AS-07 Two Pieces, One Question

Put one authentic question on a sticky above both pieces. Answer only from the pieces. If the question cannot be answered, say so. That is looking, not failure.

Out-of-home try-it — OUT-01 Library Primary Hunt (second telling)

- **Time:** 30–60 minutes including travel buffer; the looking crumb can be 15–25 minutes on site.
- **Materials:** Library card; notebook; two sticky colors; adult along.

- **Safety:** Roads; aisle courtesy; library rules; no photographing strangers; no lecturing another family's child; return materials.
- **The fun:** Hunt for a second short telling of the same local or soft historical event — plaque text in a local-history book, a newspaper microfilm/print, a short letter excerpt.
- **The skill:** Source before summary on a found piece; then match/differ with the piece you already own at home.

How: Before you leave, name the event and the question. At the library, find one credited second telling. Fill a source card before reading for “the answer.” At home or at a table, run Same / Different / Still wonder with your first account.

Out-of-home try-it — OUT-07 Newsroom History Soft

- **Time:** 20–40 minutes at library or with a public-domain historical newspaper reprint at home after a library printout.
- **Materials:** Historical newspaper page (reprint or database print with adult); notebook.
- **Safety:** Parent-mediated screens at 11–12; co-hold at 13–14 if an account is involved. Not a live culture-war pair. Soft headlines only.
- **The fun:** Old newsroom voice — headline vs body from then.
- **The skill:** CORR-05 in the wild; credit the reprint as a later printing of a then-paper.

How: Source the paper (title, date, place). Predict from headline. Read the body. Exit: fair / stretched / unsupported with a starred line.

Talk box

Exact opening (locked): “What matches across these two accounts — and what does each leave out or answer differently?”

Follow-ups:

1. Observe: “What do you *see* / *read* that shows up in both?”
2. Maker/audience: “What does each maker want you to notice — and for whom was each made?”
3. Reason tied to the piece: “How do you know that from *this* line, not from a guess?”

4. Check / alternative: “Which question is each answering? What else could be true?”
5. Revise: “You may revise without calling either a liar. Try another line.”

How to wait: Ask. Slow three (think-time; classroom-origin pause — useful, not a sacrament). Eyes on the two accounts, not on the adolescent, if the silence is hard. After they stop, wait again before you evaluate. If they are mid-look, do not cut them off. Science-class wait studies are origin labels for the pause — useful craft, not a kitchen history experiment you are failing.

Stuck silence usually means: the question was vague; wait-time after your question was zero; they are hunting a year because someone asked year-first; they are guessing what you want; the pieces never landed (too long, too hard, no source cards); they offered a summary-only merge; they think history means “repeat the parent’s story”; they think looking means “the textbook is the facts”; archaic prose needs a scaffold before talk. Fix the question. Scaffold one hard sentence as access. Return to the sourced lines. Do not fill the silence with the right merge.

Blocked for a new move: When “same / different” is brand-new, stay on two short soft excerpts. Do not stack map-vs-narrative and witness-vs-historian the same day.

Mixed for when to use it: Later in the month, mix last week’s two accounts with a fresh third piece, or revisit Tuesday’s pair on Friday without re-teaching the whole lecture.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration, not a reported family):

A student hears two short accounts of a town bridge opening. Account A (a local paper) mentions the mayor’s speech and the crowd. Account B (a worker’s letter) mentions the cold wind and the unfinished railing. The student says, “Someone is lying about the bridge.”

Repair: Write two sticky questions — “What did the ceremony look like to the paper’s readers?” and “What did the work feel like to someone on the job?” Then star matches (there was a bridge opening) and differs (ceremony vs labor detail). No liar label required.

Practice notes that keep the bank honest

You will not assign every CORR item this month. Banks are a menu. A chapter week picks one or two CORR try-its, one talk box, one exit ticket, and optionally

one OUT. Coverage itch is the enemy of looking.

When DIG or *Reading Like a Historian* materials show up in your house, label classroom origin. Steal the shape: central question, short background, two excerpts, looking moves, talk. Leave high-school classroom effect sizes upstairs; steal the shape as craft, not as a kitchen promise. Materials without facilitation still sit quiet.

Composite examples in this chapter are illustrations, not reported families. No portraits of real adolescents. No brand logos on the still-life in your mind: two pages, two cards, sticky notes.

This week's exit-ticket shapes (pick one per day)

- Spoken: "From A and B, one match is . **One difference is** . I still wonder ____."
- Written sticky triad: Same / Different / Still wonder — each with a maker initial.
- Question stickies: "A answers . **B answers** ."
- (13–14) Third-piece need: "To check , **I would want a** because ____."
- Headline check: fair / stretched / unsupported + starred line.

Right, or wrong-with-a-reason you can use tomorrow, is enough. You are not building a homemade high-stakes battery. Short kitchen skill checks live fully in Chapter 8; this chapter plants the corroboration object those checks will reuse.

Safety reminder for outings (say once, then teach)

Roads. Aisle courtesy. Library and museum rules. Hands off objects behind lines. No tasting unknown things. No shoplifting a "test." No lecture to a stranger's child. No cold public quiz of strangers for oral history. No photographing strangers without care. A plaque is print about a place — it is a later telling, often with a commissioner. Source the plaque too when you use it as a second voice.

For the student

You already know how to look at one source. This chapter adds a second voice.

History gets more interesting — not more broken — when two accounts of the same small event do not say exactly the same thing. Your job is not to crown a winner. Your job is to notice what matches, what differs, and what each account seems to be answering.

Tiny worked example (illustration).

Account A is a short newspaper note about a school opening in 1912. Account B is a short diary line from a student that day. Both mention the new building. The paper mentions speeches. The diary mentions cold hands and a long wait. Matching detail: new school building, that day. Difference: ceremony vs personal wait. Questions: the paper answers “What should town readers know about the opening?” The diary answers “What did standing there feel like for me?” You do not need a liar.

Try 1. Cover both bodies. Read both credit lines. Say maker, date, and type for each. Then uncover. Star one match. Write one difference.

Try 2. Under each account, finish: “This account seems to be answering: ____.” You may change your mind when you look again.

Explain it back. In your own words, tell someone: what corroboration means at this table (match, differ, questions — not a villain hunt).

Challenge. What would a third piece need to show to help with one wonder you still have? Name the *kind* of piece (another letter? a map? a later history paragraph labelled secondary?). You do not have to find it today. Naming the need is part of the skill.

One more try when you are ready. Take a headline and a body from a historical newspaper reprint (soft topic). Predict from the headline. Check the body. Say whether the headline was fair, stretched, or unsupported — and point to the line that makes you say that.

At 11–12, saying the exit ticket aloud is real work. At 13–14, write the same / different / still wonder in a short dated note, and add what a third piece would need. You are allowed to wait. You are allowed to revise. Point at the line.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Instant “one must be lying.”

Next move: Stop the judgment language. Put two sticky notes above the pieces: Question A / Question B. Help them draft the questions from what each maker seems to care about. Only then return to match/differ. Correct the wrong reason kindly: accounts can differ without a fake narrator.

Diagnostic 2 — Everything merges; makers vanish.

Next move: Two-color highlighters or two columns that *must* keep the source names. Every starred detail gets a letter (A or B). If they cannot say which piece a detail came from, look again. Slow down. Shorter excerpts.

Diagnostic 3 — Freeze, shrug, or “just tell me the real story.”

Next move: Check load first. Are the excerpts too long or too archaic? Read one sentence aloud as access. Re-ask the locked opening. Wait. If wait-time was zero, that was the leak. If they only know your summary, put the bodies down and cover your story notes. If presentism hijacked the hour (“they were dumb”), use one their-world prompt, then return — Chapter 4 owns that move more fully.

Diagnostic 4 — Prefers whichever matches prior belief (image vs text).

Next move: Force a “cannot show” column for each piece before any agree column. Ask: “What can the image show that the paragraph cannot — and the reverse?” Only then ask where they agree. Correct the comfort-pick without crushing the look.

Diagnostic 5 — Textbook and primary treated as twin facts.

Next move: Put the survey paragraph beside one short primary. Ask who made each, when, for whom. Label the textbook a later school telling. Corroboration across kinds of voice is allowed; erasing kinds of voice is not.

When to slow down: Match/differ still collapses into liar hunt after several tries; excerpts never land; silence is decoding load every day. Stay on CORR-01 with softer, shorter pieces. Oral exits only.

When to go ahead: They source both cards, star matches, name a difference, and revise a question sticky without prompting. Add image-vs-text or (13–14) witness-vs-later soft.

When to get a human tutor: Persistent freeze that is really reading access; language support needs beyond what you can scaffold; or you want a second adult to

model talk-box facilitation. A tutor helps with access and facilitation. A chatbot is not a tutor during the attempt. Point back to the History Hour AI box.

Hearing a wrong reason, asking a better question, then naming a better move if needed, is teaching. Silence forever in the face of a pure liar hunt is not kindness. A scolding lecture is not teaching either.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers for the adult. Keep this short. Point back to the History Hour AI box for the full allow-and-ban list for ages 11–14.

You may, on your account, after the student has tried (or before, for parent prep): find a second **named** public-domain or library excerpt on the same soft event; ask a tool to explain *to you* the difference between primary and later secondary for tonight's pair; print a blank Same / Different / Still wonder sheet with the answer key held by you; request a labelled SCRIPT of questions for you to say after the try; ask for revision questions after their draft note — not a rewrite of their paragraph.

You may not: generate a fake “eyewitness letter” and file it as a primary; put a model summary on the table as one of the two “sources”; ask a window to merge the two accounts into the student's exit ticket; park an unsupervised chatbot as their partner during the attempt; photo-to-key a worksheet; invent who made a piece.

At 11–12, you hold the account (under-13 rules apply). At 13–14, co-hold; you stay in the room; turning 13 is not a licence for a secret history friend. Unaided first on looking. SCRIPT after the try. A fluent merge from a machine is performance, not their corroboration.

One off-age caution, said once for the house: in a high-school math trial, an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse on the test with the window closed. That is not an 11–14 history experiment. The kitchen rule it supports: the model may prepare the adult and the next looking page; it may not do the student's looking when looking is the lesson.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on from this chapter's focus weeks, you should be able to check most of these without a percentile story:

- ☐ Two source cards filled before the bodies own the talk.
- ☐ Student can star at least one matching detail and name one difference tied to lines.
- ☐ Student can attempt “which question each answers” (oral at 11–12; written sticky at 13–14).
- ☐ “One must be lying” is interrupted and repaired without shame.
- ☐ Kinds of voice stay visible (diary vs paper vs later secondary vs textbook).
- ☐ At least one in-home CORR try-it and one out-of-home hunt or newsroom soft completed this month.
- ☐ Exit ticket left a durable trace: same / different / still wonder with makers named.
- ☐ Placement by skill: if the liar hunt still owns the table, stay; if match/differ is fluent, add image-vs-text or (13–14) witness-vs-later — not a full DBQ battery.
- ☐ Work files under **History** or **Social Studies**, not under a curriculum brand, and never as “Young Minds History I.”

Done enough is right, or wrong-with-a-reason you can use tomorrow — not a percentage. Revisit next Tuesday: mix last week’s two accounts for three minutes before a new pair. Life of the habit is the rhythm, not a ninth teaching chapter.

Band fork reminder. At 11–12, done enough can be oral. At 13–14, expect a short dated note and a “third piece need” line. Neither band owes you a Document-Based Lesson every Friday.

Transfer check. Next week, hand a fresh soft pair without re-teaching the whole lecture. If match/differ returns, the habit is starting. If the liar hunt returns, that is information — repair again, shorter excerpts, louder question stickies.

A path through middle-grades history looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A culture-war win is not. Two short accounts, honestly looked at, are enough for this week.

Chapter 4 — Context without drowning



Figure 6: One credited excerpt with a “their world” sticky note beside it — still-life, no faces, no partisan poster.

Why this matters

A piece from then can look foolish, cruel, or oddly slow when you read it with today's tools in your pocket. That snap judgment is normal. Presentism is the mind at rest. The repair is not a scolding lecture about how “they weren't stupid.” The repair is a better question: what would have to be true in *their* world for this to make sense?

This chapter owns contextualization for ages 11–14 — without drowning the piece in a forty-minute encyclopedia hour. Context here means enough of then's world for the source to breathe: tools and constraints, a word that may have shifted, place and season, who else was in the room, and processes that took years rather than one dramatic day. It does not mean a chapter dump. It does not mean cynicism (“everyone lied”) as the only repair. It does not mean approving harm because “it was normal then.” Understanding is not approving. The prompt is enough to start.

Adolescents this age can interrupt presentism when the move is named and practiced. They will not become fair-minded because a parent bought a timeline poster. They will not become historians because a binder finished Unit 4. They need a piece on the table, a tiny story so the world is not blank, and one authentic question that points back at then's conditions.

Historical thinking goes against the grain of ordinary thought. Familiar pasts feel easy; strange pasts take work. Knowledge constrains thinking: a student cannot source a clause about kings and written limits if she has no picture of that world at all. Give the piece and a tiny story. Do not demand a historiography seminar in week one of age eleven. Coverage is a map. Depth is the hour. Light tours leave few traces; a pattern built slowly is what the mind can keep. This is a useful shape of study, not a promise that every home will see the same result.

Classroom materials that print a “contextualization” box can help — or they can become another worksheet that never touches the piece. Facilitation still matters. You pose the their-world question. You wait. You point back at the sourced line. Materials alone do not get a student talking. That warning travels from classrooms where packets sat quiet; bring it home as ordinary craft, not as a coefficient to chase.

Soft entry on hard past still applies. Everyday life, tools, tickets, streets and work, remembrance with family consent. Graphic violence and atrocity images are not the default piece box. When a soft excerpt brushes against harm, keep the their-

world prompt, name understanding-versus-approving once, and do not turn the History Hour into a campaign speech from either pole.

Chapter 1 put source before summary. Chapter 2 taught looking on a credit line. Chapter 3 added a second voice. This chapter keeps the piece from floating in a modern judgment with no air. Chapter 5 will use the same care on early civic texts. Maps and timelines deepen place in Chapter 6. Do not steal those chapters' whole banks today. Steal the their-world prompt, and stop before the lecture returns.

If you used *History for Little Thinkers*, you may have practiced then/now with pictures and soft talk. This book ages that work up into then's *world* — constraints, words, processes — without reprinting Kitchen Memory scripts. One pointer to sister books, then teach this hour.

The locked question for this chapter is the whole repair in one line:

“What would have to be true in *their* world for this to make sense?”

If they can answer that once after a judgmental sentence, with a finger still on the piece, the week did its job.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Everyday picture. Someone laughs at a paper ticket because “we just use a phone.” You could scold. Or you could ask what would have to be true for a paper ticket to be the sensible tool — printers, conductors, no pocket computer, a system built around punched cardstock. The laugh softens into curiosity. The ticket stays the object. That is contextualization without a sermon.

Precise picture. Contextualization places a source in time and space: what people could know, what tools they had, what words meant, who was present, what institutions moved slowly. Wineburg's presentism line is plain: presentism is our psychological condition at rest. The repair question — what would have to be true in *their* world — interrupts the rest state without pretending the past was wise in every choice. Lee's “deficit past” names the habit of treating earlier people as simply behind. Barton's work on how students tell change often centers individuals and snap events; institutions and long processes need an explicit invitation. Your kitchen translation: one prompt, one word-that-shifted, one “who else was in the room,” one “took years because ____,” and a hard stop before the binder becomes the hour.

Cut background to what the piece needs. Two minutes of story that makes the excerpt intelligible beats twenty minutes of survey. If you feel the coverage itch, put the year-map on the wall and return to the piece. The year is a map. The hour is depth.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. Deficit past.

“They were just dumb / behind / uncivilized.”

What it usually means: present tools became a moral scorecard.

What you say: “What would have to be true in *their* world for this to make sense?” Wait. Point at a line.

2. Cynicism as the only repair.

“Everyone lied; nothing means anything.”

What it usually means: distrust replaced looking.

What you say: “What can this piece still show — and what can’t it? Let’s stay with the lines.”

3. Individuals-only change.

One speech or one hero “fixed” a multi-year process.

What it usually means: institutions and time collapsed into a snap.

What you say: “What took years, not one day? Who else was in the room?”

4. Forty-minute context dump.

The piece never returns; the hour becomes a lecture.

What it usually means: coverage pressure won.

What you say — to yourself: cut to two minutes; return to the excerpt; save the rest for another day.

5. Understanding twisted into approving.

“It was normal then, so it was fine.”

What it usually means: the their-world prompt was misheard as a moral free pass.

What you say: “Understanding how it made sense to them is not the same as saying we approve. What does the piece show people doing — and what questions does that open?”

Five-to-eight-minute parent warm-up

Read tomorrow’s piece alone. Write three “their world” conditions that would have to be true for the piece to make sense. Write one word that might have shifted

(liberty, friend, citizen, news, machine — whatever is actually on the page). Write one person or role mentioned lightly or not at all.

Cut your planned background talk to two minutes. Practice the locked opening to the empty chair. Count a slow three. Do not answer with a sermon.

If you want a SCRIPT of questions for *you* later, draft it now. Point back to the History Hour AI box for allows and bans. The student looks first. A model summary is not the source. A generated “period diary” is not a primary.

C3 History pathways for middle grades ask students to detect limitations in sources and to explain how context shapes interpretation. Your kitchen version this week is smaller and kinder: one piece, one prompt, one limitation named lightly (“this letter cannot tell us how the recipient felt”). Limitation talk belongs beside their-world talk. Both keep the past from becoming either a cartoon of fools or a cartoon of villains.

What fluency sounds like for you this week.

You hear “they were dumb” and you do not panic or preach. You ask the locked question. You can cut a binder chapter to two minutes of needed story. You can name one shifted word and one missing role without inventing evidence. You can stop talking while curiosity is still alive. Those are adult fluency targets — not a quiz for the adolescent.

Parent checklist before tomorrow’s Hour

- ☐ Piece chosen; credit line visible; honesty flag ready.
- ☐ Three their-world conditions written privately.
- ☐ One possible shifted word noted.
- ☐ Background cut to two minutes.
- ☐ Locked opening practiced once aloud.
- ☐ Exit ticket shape chosen (one sentence is enough).
- ☐ Low-heat topic confirmed; no culture-war pamphlet planned.
- ☐ If using a tool for prep, account rules for 11–12 / 13–14 remembered; student will look unaided first.

You do not need to be a historian. You do need to put a named source on the table, ask what would have to be true in their world, and stop before the encyclopedia hour returns.

How to teach it this week

The History Hour shape stays (~25–45 minutes). Context is a short breathe around the piece, not a second subject.

Session shape

1. **Source card first (4–8 min).** Who / when / what kind / for whom — before the body and before your tidy story.
2. **Short look (5–12 min).** Observe → Reflect → Question. Let a judgmental sentence appear if it will; do not panic.
3. **Short background (5–10 min).** Two minutes max of story the piece needs. Then the locked their-world question.
4. **One try (8–15 min).** Their-world prompt; or technology gap without deficit; or word-that-shifted; or process-not-snap — one focus, not all six CTX items.
5. **Exit ticket (2–4 min).** One “would have to be true” sentence, or word + starred context line, or “took years because ____.”

Exact wording you can say

- “What would have to be true in *their* world for this to make sense?”
- “What word might mean something different then?”
- “Who else was in the room?”
- “What took years, not one day?”
- “What would a scolding ‘they were dumb’ miss?”
- “You may revise your first judgment.”
- “Understanding is not the same as approving.”

First try-it for the student

CTX-01 on whatever sourced excerpt is already on the table. When a presentist jab appears — or after you invite one soft judgment (“What seems strange here?”) — ask the locked opening. Wait. Point at a line. Exit: one “would have to be true” sentence.

Fade help

Early week: you model one their-world condition aloud. Midweek: they draft the sentence; you ask which line supports it. Late week: they catch their own deficit-past jab and run the prompt before you do. At 13–14, add word-that-shifted and who-is-missing. Fade the adult lecture. Keep the piece visible.

When to stop talking

After the locked question. After they attempt one condition — wait before you deliver three more. Do not stack a technology sermon, a vocabulary lecture, and a process timeline in one sitting. One move. Stop while curiosity remains.

Age-band moves

11–12. One prompt routine (CTX-01) until it is fluent. CTX-02 Technology Gap Without Deficit with soft tool photos. CTX-04 Place and Season with a simple map. Adult reads archaic lines. Oral exit OK. Keep background tiny.

13–14. Add CTX-03 Word That Shifted with evidence from surrounding lines. Add CTX-05 Who Else Was in the Room. Add CTX-06 Process Not Snap with a light multi-year card strip. Ask what a scolding deficit jab would miss. Still not a historiography seminar. Still not a culture-war pamphlet hour.

Place by skill, not birthday. A fourteen-year-old who only sneers at past tools does CTX-02 without apology. An eleven-year-old ready for word-that-shifted should not wait.

Struggle before rescue.

If silence is empty because the question was mushy, fix it: tie it to *this* piece. If silence is decoding load, scaffold one sentence as access. If they answer with a modern rant, return to the line on the page. A hint is a named idea (“Think about travel time before engines”), not your finished essay.

Knowledge first; working memory honest.

One–three pieces preferred; this week often one piece plus a map or tool photo. Short excerpts. If the day only holds twenty-five minutes, run source card + Observe + one their-world sentence + exit.

Exact anti-drown rule.

If your background talk needs more than about two minutes for the piece to make sense, the piece is too thin for today *or* your talk is trying to teach the whole year. Choose: longer excerpt another day, or shorter talk today. Do not solve the itch by talking faster.

Pairing with other chapters without stealing them.

If two accounts triggered presentism, run CTX-01 for five minutes, then return to match/differ (Chapter 3). If a civic clause triggers a modern rant, run then-words and their-world lightly, then return to the document edge (Chapter 5). Context is

a breathe, not a takeover.

Hypothetical week (illustration only — not a calendar)

Focus move: their-world prompt after looking.

- **Mon:** CTX-01 on this week's excerpt. Exit: one "would have to be true" sentence.
- **Tue:** CTX-02 Technology Gap Without Deficit (same job, different tools).
- **Wed:** CTX-03 Word That Shifted *or* CTX-04 Place and Season.
- **Thu:** OUT-03 Plaque Read with "what would have to be true then" after looking — or museum label walk noticing what the label assumes, then return to one piece.
- **Fri:** Diagnostic: deficit-past job. Repair with locked prompt. Done-enough checklist. Optional CTX-06 Process Not Snap if the week's story was a snap-change myth.

Practice that actually builds learning

Named try-its in the home and outside it. Time, materials, safety, the fun, the skill. Banks are a menu — pick, do not assign all six CTX items every week.

In-home try-it — CTX-01 Their World Prompt

- **Time:** 15–25 minutes (often inside a longer Hour).
- **Materials:** Any sourced excerpt already on the table.
- **Safety:** Soft topics as default. Distinguish understanding from approving when harm appears in a soft way; do not turn the hour into a pamphlet from either pole.
- **The fun:** The "they were dumb" reflex becomes a puzzle about then's conditions.
- **The skill:** Interrupt presentism with one authentic question; wait; point at a line.

How: Source and short look first. When presentism appears — or after "What seems strange?" — ask the locked opening. Wait. Exit: one "would have to be true" sentence.

In-home try-it — CTX-02 Technology Gap Without Deficit

- **Time:** 20–30 minutes.
- **Materials:** Then-tool vs now-tool photos or objects (wash board / washer; oil lamp / bulb; letter / message app — whatever matches the piece’s world).
- **Safety:** No mocking past hardship as entertainment. No romanticizing suffering. Ordinary courtesy with borrowed objects.
- **The fun:** Same job, different constraint — tools as clues, not punch lines.
- **The skill:** Refuse “they were behind”; exit Same job / different constraint.

How: Name the job both tools serve. Ask what would have to be true for the then-tool to be the sensible choice. Return to the week’s piece if one mentions the work.

In-home try-it — CTX-03 Word That Shifted

- **Time:** 20–35 minutes.
- **Materials:** One word in a primary that may have shifted (*liberty, citizen, friend, news, machine* — use what is on the page); surrounding lines visible.
- **Safety:** Skip invented dictionary pages. Use context + an adult reference if needed. No lecturing the teen for using a now-sense at first.
- **The fun:** One word becomes a time machine.
- **The skill:** Possible then-senses from surrounding lines; exit Word + starred context line.

How: Two columns: possible then-sense / common now-sense. Evidence from surrounding lines. Wait. Revise allowed.

In-home try-it — CTX-04 Place and Season

- **Time:** 20–30 minutes.
- **Materials:** Simple map matching the piece; calendar or season clue in the text if present.
- **Safety:** Ordinary map use. No adventure-movie travel times.
- **The fun:** Weather and distance argue with modern assumptions.
- **The skill:** Spatio-temporal context; exit Place + season/time constraint named.

How: After sourcing, mark where. Ask travel time then. Ask season if the text

invites it. Tie one constraint back to why a choice in the piece made sense.

In-home try-it — CTX-05 Who Else Was in the Room

- **Time:** 20–30 minutes.
- **Materials:** A narrative that centers one hero or one speaker; notebook.
- **Safety:** No guilt lecture. Wonder about people the text leaves thin; skip fabricating names the piece never supports.
- **The fun:** The edges of the story light up — roles half-seen in the text.
- **The skill:** List people mentioned lightly or not at all; what questions open?; exit Three roles/people to wonder about next.

How: After the story and the piece, ask who else was present or affected. Star evidence vs wonder. Plan one next piece that could answer a wonder (library hunt later).

In-home try-it — CTX-06 Process Not Snap

- **Time:** 20–35 minutes.
- **Materials:** Light timeline of a multi-year change related to this month’s owned stories (cards on a string are enough).
- **Safety:** Soft topics. Refuse single-speech-as-whole-change myths without turning the hour into a fight.
- **The fun:** Time stretches — “not one day” becomes visible.
- **The skill:** Mark “not one day”; exit “Took years because ____.”

How: Lay cards before / during / after. Ask what an individual speech or day cannot finish alone. Return to the piece: what moment does it catch inside a longer process?

In-home crumb — TALK-04 Strange Past Soft

When something feels strange, name the strangeness without scorn. Then run CTX-01. Strange is a doorway. Scorn is a closed door.

Out-of-home try-it — OUT-03 Plaque Read with then’s world

- **Time:** 20–40 minutes on site including travel buffer.

- **Materials:** Notebook; pencil; adult along.
- **Safety:** Roads; public courtesy; hands off monuments as required; no lecture to strangers' children; no cold quiz of passersby; plaque is print about a place — not a sermon about a city.
- **The fun:** Bronze or stone letters become a source with a later maker.
- **The skill:** Source the plaque (who put it up, when, if known); then ask what would have to be true in the *remembered* world's time for the event to make sense — without treating the plaque as the event itself.

How: Read one sentence aloud. Credit the plaque as a later telling. Ask the locked opening about the *then* the plaque points to. Exit: plaque transcription of one sentence + one their-world condition.

Out-of-home crumb — Museum label walk

Notice what one label assumes about then's world (tools, ranks, travel). Then return to **one** object or image. One annotation. Not a continent wall. Museum hands-off rules.

Talk box

Exact opening (locked): "What would have to be true in *their* world for this to make sense?"

Follow-ups:

1. Observe: "What do you *see* / *read* that feels strange at first?"
2. Maker/audience: "Who made this, for whom — and what world did they assume their reader already knew?"
3. Reason tied to the piece: "How do you know that condition from *this* line or detail?"
4. Check / alternative: "What word might mean something different then? Who else was in the room? What took years?"
5. Revise: "You may revise your first judgment. Try another condition."

How to wait: Ask. Slow three. Eyes on the piece. Second wait after they finish. Do not supply your three-paragraph context essay at one second. Think-time is a classroom-origin pause — useful at the table, not a history RCT you are failing.

Stuck silence usually means: vague question; zero wait-time; year-first hunt;

guessing what you want; piece never landed; summary-only guess; textbook-as-facts habit; archaic prose load; or they fear a “wrong” moral answer. Fix the question. Scaffold access. Separate understanding from approving in one plain sentence. Return to the line.

Blocked for a new move: When their-world is brand-new, stay on CTX-01. Do not stack word-shift, process timeline, and who-else the same day.

Mixed for when to use it: Later, mix last week’s their-world sticky with a fresh piece. Or run CTX-01 live for three minutes whenever presentism appears in any chapter — the prompt travels.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration):

A student reads a short excerpt about a long journey by wagon and says, “They were stupid not to just drive.”

Repair: “What would have to be true in *their* world for a wagon journey to make sense?” Wait. Name constraints (engines not available, roads, cost, season). Point at a line about time or weather if present. Understanding the constraint is not mocking the traveler and not romanticizing hardship.

This week’s exit-ticket shapes (pick one)

- One “would have to be true” sentence tied to the piece.
- Same job / different constraint (CTX-02).
- Word + starred context line (CTX-03).
- Place + season/time constraint (CTX-04).
- Three roles to wonder about next (CTX-05).
- “Took years because ____” (CTX-06).

Practice notes

You will not run the whole CTX bank every week. Pick one focus. Library and museum outings motivate; they do not replace the looking move. Composite examples are illustrations. No adolescent portraits. No partisan posters as the still-life.

Safety reminder for outings

Roads. Aisle and gallery courtesy. Hands-off rules. No tasting unknown things. No shoplifting a “test.” No cold public quiz of strangers. No photographing

strangers without care. Cemetery soft only with family consent (not this chapter's default). A plaque is a later telling about a place.

Hypothetical composite sitting (illustration — not a transcript)

Parent and student sit with a short credited letter about waiting for a reply. Source card first. Observe: paper, date line, mention of days. Student: "Why didn't they just message?" Parent asks the locked opening. Silence. Slow three. Student: "Maybe messages cost a lot of time." Parent: "How do you know from *this* letter?" Student stars "I have waited five days." Exit ticket spoken. Two minutes of background after: mail then moved with horses, coaches, or trains depending on place and year. Stop. The binder chapter on transportation waits for another day. That is context without drowning.

For the student

Past people used different tools, words, and calendars than you do. That does not automatically make them foolish. It also does not automatically make every choice good. Your job this week is to ask a better question when something feels strange.

The move. After you look at a sourced piece, if you catch yourself thinking "they were dumb," pause. Ask: what would have to be true in *their* world for this to make sense? Point at a detail on the page while you answer.

Tiny worked example (illustration).

A letter mentions waiting days for a reply. You might think, "Just text." Then-world conditions: no pocket phones, letters travel by horse or rail, a reply has a cost in time. The letter's patience makes a different kind of sense. You still might not want to wait days. Understanding is not the same as wishing you lived then.

Try 1. On today's piece, write or say one "would have to be true" sentence. Star the line or detail that pushed you.

Try 2. Pick one word on the page that might mean something slightly different then. Guess a then-sense from surrounding lines. You may change your mind.

Explain it back. Tell someone what presentism means in ordinary language (judging then only with now's habits), and what the their-world question does.

Challenge. Who else was in the room — named lightly, or not named at all? List three roles or people to wonder about next. Skip names the piece never supports. Wonder with evidence and with honest gaps.

One more try when you are ready.

Look at two tool pictures that do the same job (then and now). Write: same job / different constraint. Refuse the sentence “they were behind.” Use “they worked under different constraints” — and say one constraint out loud.

Band note.

If writing is heavy today, speak your exit ticket. History looking does not wait for perfect handwriting. If reading is heavy, let an adult read one sentence, then you Observe again. Access is not cheating when looking is the lesson.

At 11–12, one oral their-world sentence is real work. At 13–14, add a word-that-shifted note and a process-not-snap line when the story tempts you to think change happened in a single day. You are allowed to wait. You are allowed to revise your first judgment.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Deficit-past loop.

Next move: Replace any scolding lecture with one locked prompt. Wait. Require a sentence tied to the piece. Correct the wrong reason: different tools are not a moral scorecard.

Diagnostic 2 — Cynicism-only repair.

Next move: Ask what the piece *can* show and what it *cannot*. Return to Observe. Cynicism feels smart; looking is harder and more useful.

Diagnostic 3 — Context dump / piece disappears.

Next move: Set a two-minute timer on background. When it rings, return to the excerpt. Put extra survey notes in a “later” pile. Coverage itch is real; drown is optional.

Diagnostic 4 — Snap-change story owns the week.

Next move: CTX-06 light timeline. Mark “not one day.” Ask what institutions or many people would have to move. Keep soft topics.

Diagnostic 5 — Understanding heard as approving.

Next move: Say the limit once in plain language: understanding how something made sense then is not the same as approving it. Then return to what the piece shows and what questions it opens. Do not turn the hour into a pamphlet.

Diagnostic 6 — Year-first freeze.

Next move: They are hunting a date because someone asked for the year first. Cover the year. Ask what would have to be true in their world. Attach the date only after the story and the piece are owned (Chapter 6 deepens this). Context before wallpaper dates.

When to slow down: Presentism returns every day with scorn; background always eats the piece; archaic prose never lands. Stay on CTX-01 with shorter excerpts and tinier stories.

When to go ahead: They run the prompt with little prompting; they can name a shifted word from context; they notice who is missing without a guilt spiral. Add process-not-snap and (13–14) gentler pairing with civic edges in Chapter 5.

When to get a human tutor: Persistent reading access needs; language support; or facilitation coaching for talk-box wait. A window is not the tutor during the attempt.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers for the adult. Point back to the History Hour AI box for the full 11–14 allow-and-ban list.

You may, on your account: ask a tool to explain *to you* a then-tool or a travel-time constraint for tonight’s piece; find a named public-domain map or glossary note; request a PARENT KEY blank for “would have to be true” practice; get a SCRIPT of questions after the student tries; ask for revision questions on their draft sentence — not a rewrite.

You may not: generate a period diary and file it as real; put a model summary on the table as the source; ask a chatbot to “explain why they weren’t stupid” as a paragraph the student copies; park an unsupervised companion during the attempt; invent facts about whether a shop or road existed.

At 11–12, parent holds the account. At 13–14, co-hold; still in the room. Unaided first. SCRIPT after the try. Bastani’s high-school math trial is off-age for liter-

acy/history — one house caution: fluent practice with a window open is not the same as learning that holds when the window closes. The model prepares you; it does not do their looking.

What “done enough” looks like

- ☐ Source card before body and before long background.
- ☐ Student can answer the locked their-world prompt once, tied to the piece.
- ☐ Deficit-past jab is interrupted without a shame lecture.
- ☐ Background stays short enough that the piece returns the same day.
- ☐ At least one CTX try-it and one plaque/museum then-world crumb this month.
- ☐ Understanding vs approving named when needed, in one plain sentence.
- ☐ 11–12: oral exit OK. 13–14: word-shift or process-not-snap appears in a dated note.
- ☐ Placement by skill, not birthday — stay if scorn owns the table; go ahead if the prompt is fluent.
- ☐ Files under **History** / **Social Studies**, never a brand, never “Young Minds History I.”

Friday diagnostic wrong (illustration).

Wrong: “They were dumb not to ____.”

Repair heard: locked prompt + one condition + star on the piece.

If the repair happened, check the box. If not, stay another week on CTX-01. Skill, not birthday.

Done enough is right, or wrong-with-a-reason for tomorrow. Revisit next Tuesday: three minutes on last week’s their-world sticky before a new piece. Life of the habit lives in the rhythm — not in a ninth teaching chapter.

Transfer check.

Next week, use a fresh piece. If the their-world prompt returns with little coaching, the habit is starting. If scorn returns, shorten the excerpt, soften the topic, and model one condition aloud again.

Connection in one sentence each (then teach history).

Critical Thinking for Young Minds owns reasons on present stakes — this hour keeps the piece in the past. English for Young Minds owns vocabulary and claim craft — when a shifted word is really a reading load, scaffold, then return to then’s

world. *History for Homeschooling* owns wider civics survey — point once if needed, keep a Constitution chain for sister civics — not this hour.

A path through middle-grades history looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A culture-war win is not. One piece, their world, and a stop before drowning are enough for this week.

When you are ready for civic documents, keep this chapter's breathe. A Magna Carta clause, a Declaration sentence, or a Preamble phrase still needs then's world — and still needs a stop before the Constitution-chain dump. Chapter 5 picks up there gently.

Chapter 5 — Early civic texts gently



Figure 7: One short civic clause on the table with an honesty card — original / later printing / modernized spelling — still-life, no faces, no campaign poster.

Why this matters

Magna Carta, the Declaration of Independence, and the Constitution — plus compact, charter, and amendment edges — are documents people wrote for purposes. They have makers, dates, audiences, and jobs. They are not sacred slogans. They are not enemies. They are not campaign speeches. At ages 11–14, the honest kitchen object is one clause or short sentence: source card, then-meaning of key words, a paraphrase of the job the line is trying to do, and a stop before the week becomes a Constitution-chain forced march.

Gently means edges, not a Government course. Gently means one text family this week, not six founding texts by Friday. Gently means then-words before now-lectures. Gently means refusing a virtue machine: one Preamble reading will not mint a citizen. Historical inquiry skills can move without overall democratic-disposition transfer. Teach looking because it is how history works. If citizenship moves are the aim, teach civics separately and point once to sister civics / *Publius* / the wider Homeschooling civics chapter — do not make this Hour the understudy for virtue.

Adolescents this age can treat a civic line as a document. They can stumble into year-first quizzes, meme paraphrases without a source card, morality-play Founders-only stories, or modern policy rants that never return to the words on the page. Your job is to hear those turns and ask a better question: what job is this civic line trying to do — and for whom — as a document, not as a slogan?

State frameworks sometimes place Magna Carta, Declaration, and Constitution language in middle grades as historic documents and influences. California's history-social science framework and Texas TEKS language about historic documents are texture for placement — not kitchen pamphlets and not a statute dump. C3 Civics pathways for grades 6–8 touch powers and limits when the excerpt on the table carries them. LOC's primary-source definition still applies to founding texts: raw materials from the time under study, incomplete, to be observed and questioned. Nystrand's warning about recitation still applies: a Magna Carta year quiz is not the civics move.

Knowledge constrains thinking. A student cannot source a Magna Carta clause about written limits if she has no tiny picture of kings, barons, and complaints. Give the piece and a two-minute story. Federalist 10 and 51 stay off the weekly spine. Keep quotations sourced; use public-domain excerpts; name which text and which year on the honesty card.

Chapter 1 put source before summary. Chapter 2 taught credit-line looking. Chapter 3 added corroboration. Chapter 4 taught their world without drowning. This chapter keeps civic lines inside that same looking craft. Maps deepen place next. Claims grow in Chapter 7. Short checks reuse these objects in Chapter 8.

If you used *History for Little Thinkers*, you did not march a Constitution chain with five-year-olds — and you should not reprint holiday scripts here as civics. If you used *History for Homeschooling*, you may have seen a fuller civics survey. One pointer, then teach document edges for 11–14. This book is not *Publius*. Point once if a parent wants a deeper Federalist week.

The locked question for this chapter is the whole edge in one line:

“What job is this civic line trying to do — and for whom — as a document, not as a slogan?”

If they can paraphrase the job with a finger on the words, the week did its job.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Everyday picture. Someone quotes a famous line on a shirt. It feels true. Nobody can say who wrote it, when, for whom, or what the next sentence was. A civic meme without a source card is a slogan wearing history’s coat. At the table you put the coat back on the document: honesty card first, then the clause, then the job.

Precise picture. Early civic texts in this book are **document edges**:

Text family	Gentle kitchen object	Refuse
Magna Carta	A written limit on a ruler’s power; one concrete clause (period language you gloss)	Medieval theme park; “invented democracy in 1215” slogan; year quiz as the civics move
Declaration	Rights sentence or one grievance cluster; who wrote for whom	Morality-play Founders only; pamphlet from either pole; whole grievance catalog in one hour

Text family	Gentle kitchen object	Refuse
Constitution	Preamble aims or one short structural idea (e.g., separated powers as a <i>limit</i> shape)	Full Article-by-Article dump; Federalist 10/51 deep dive as weekly spine
Compact / charter / one amendment	One sentence; source card; then-words	Campaign speech; virtue machine
Pairing (13–14)	One grievance <i>shape</i> beside one constitutional <i>limit</i> that answers a similar problem type	Forced “proof” that 1787 solved 1776 completely; Constitution-chain forced march

Fill an honesty card every time: which text, which year, original / later printing / translation / modernized spelling. Gloss two hard words before the student drowns. Write one authentic question that is not a year quiz.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. Year-first civic quiz.

“What year was the Magna Carta?” as the main move.

What it usually means: recitation replaced looking.

What you say: “What job is this *line* trying to do — for whom?”

2. Campaign speech.

The clause becomes a platform for today’s fight.

What it usually means: document edge became pamphlet.

What you say: “Back to maker, audience, purpose. What do the words on the page try to limit or name?”

3. Constitution-chain forced march.

Six texts in five days; fatigue; no looking.

What it usually means: coverage pressure.

What you say: stop after one; put the chain on a wall as a *map*, not as the hour’s work.

4. Virtue-machine hope.

“If we read the Preamble, they’ll become good citizens.”

What it usually means: looking was asked to do civics-disposition work it may not transfer.

What you say: teach the document as evidence; point to civics / *Publius* if citizenship moves are the aim. Inquiry skills can move without overall disposition transfer — a useful limit, not a reason to skip looking.

5. Civic meme without source card / morality-play Founders only / erasing limits without looking.

Modern paraphrase filed as the document; heroes-only story; or a gotcha that never returns to the clause.

What it usually means: slogan, romance, or pamphlet replaced the piece.

What you say: honesty card; then-words; what the line can and cannot settle — without a pamphlet from either pole.

Five-to-eight-minute parent warm-up

Cut tomorrow's civic text to **one clause or short sentence**. Fill the honesty card (which text, which year, translation?). Gloss two hard words in plain language. Write one authentic question that is not a year quiz — aim at job, audience, or a then-word.

Practice the locked opening to the empty chair. Count a slow three. Draft a SCRIPT of follow-ups for yourself if you like. Point back to the History Hour AI box: no generate-primary-as-real, no model summary as the source, unaided first, 11–12 parent holds account, 13–14 co-hold in the room.

Parent checklist before tomorrow's Hour

- ☐ One clause only; rest of the chain parked as a map.
- ☐ Honesty card filled.
- ☐ Two hard words glossed.
- ☐ Locked opening practiced.
- ☐ Exit ticket shape chosen (paraphrase + then-word, or job + audience).
- ☐ No campaign speech planned; no virtue promise announced.
- ☐ Public-domain excerpt; no invented quotation.

You do not need to be a constitutional lawyer. You do need to put a named civic line on the table before the slogan, and to ask what job it is trying to do for whom.

What fluency sounds like for you this week.

You can cut any founding packet to one clause. You hear a year quiz and switch to job/audience. You hear a campaign speech and return to the words on the page. You can gloss two hard words without delivering a semester. You can say, in one

plain sentence, that looking at a document is not a promise of citizenship — then teach the line anyway. Those are adult fluency targets, not a quiz for the adolescent.

Wilke and colleagues found that historical inquiry skills can improve without overall gains in democratic skills and dispositions. Keep that limit in the body once: teach looking because history works that way. Point elsewhere for citizenship moves. Do not make this Hour a virtue machine.

How to teach it this week

The History Hour shape stays (~25–45 minutes). Civic text is today's piece — still source before summary.

Session shape

1. **Source / honesty card first (4–8 min).** Which text, who/when/for whom as far as you can tell, original vs later printing vs translation vs modernized spelling.
2. **Short look (5–12 min).** Observe words. Reflect then-purpose guess. Question. Gloss archaic load as access.
3. **Short background (5–10 min).** Two-minute story the clause needs (kings and barons; colonies and king; convention and ratification era — tiny, not a semester).
4. **One try (8–15 min).** Preamble phrase walk **or** one amendment **or** Declaration sentence **or** Magna Carta clause soft **or** compact sentence — one CIV item.
5. **Exit ticket (2–4 min).** Phrase/clause + “In the document this seems to aim at ” / *paraphrase* + *then-word* / “*This sentence was trying to* for audience ____.”

Exact wording you can say

- “What job is this civic line trying to do — and for whom — as a document, not as a slogan?”
- “Who drafted or approved this, as far as we can tell?”
- “What does this word mean *then*?”
- “What power does this line try to limit or name?”
- “What can’t this one line settle?”

- (13–14) “How does this grievance *shape* rhyme with this limit *shape* — without claiming 1787 solved 1776 completely?”
- “You may revise your paraphrase when we look at the words again.”

First try-it for the student

CIV-01 Preamble Phrase Walk: source the Constitution as a whole lightly, then pick **one** phrase (“We the People,” “establish Justice,” etc.). Observe words. Guess then-purpose. Exit: Phrase + “In the document this seems to aim at ____.”

Fade help

Early week: you gloss; you model one paraphrase. Midweek: they draft the paraphrase; you ask which words support it. Late week: they fill the honesty card; they name one limit of what the line can settle. At 13–14, gentle pairing of grievance shape beside limit shape — still not *Publius*. Fade the adult speech. Keep the clause visible.

When to stop talking

After the locked question. After they attempt a paraphrase — wait. Do not deliver Article I–VII. Do not rescue with a campaign speech. Stop while a look remains.

Age-band moves

11–12. One text family per week. Heavy scaffold on archaic prose. Prefer CIV-01, CIV-02 (one amendment), CIV-03 (one Declaration sentence), CIV-05 (compact/charter), CIV-06 (rights word then/now), CIV-07 (misuse repair). Oral exit OK. Magna Carta (CIV-04) only with heavy scaffold if at all.

13–14. CIV-04 Magna Carta Clause Soft in translation with confirmation/year named. CIV-07 misuse repair with a sourced rewrite. Gentle pairing: one grievance shape beside one constitutional limit shape — without forced proof that 1787 finished 1776. Still not Federalist deep dive. Still not a full Government course.

Place by skill, not birthday. A fourteen-year-old stuck on year-quiz recitation does phrase-walk looking without apology. An eleven-year-old ready for one amendment should not wait.

Struggle before rescue.

Mushy question → fix toward job/audience on *this* line. Hard prose → adult reads one sentence as access. Modern rant → return to maker/audience/purpose and

then-words. Hint = question or named idea (“What does *establish* suggest the makers thought was missing?”), not the finished essay.

Anti-chain rule.

One document this week. The chain may hang on the wall as a map of names. The hour works one edge.

Knowledge first; working memory honest.

One clause on the table. Tiny story. Exit as paraphrase or job sentence. If only twenty-five minutes, honesty card + Observe + locked question + exit.

Hypothetical week (illustration only — not a calendar)

Focus move: one civic phrase as sourced text.

- **Mon:** CIV-01 Preamble Phrase Walk (one phrase).
- **Tue:** CIV-06 Rights Word Then/Now on a word from Monday.
- **Wed:** CIV-07 Civic Text Is Still a Source (name a misuse; repair by returning to source card) or WRITE-03-shaped paraphrase (civic clause paraphrase).
- **Thu:** OUT-03 Courthouse / Plaque Read when a plaque cites a founding idea — treat plaque as later telling; or library public-domain civic excerpt printout with honesty card.
- **Fri:** Diagnostic: civic meme without source card or campaign speech. Repair. Done-enough checklist.

A second week might focus CIV-03 Declaration Sentence; a third CIV-02 One Amendment; a fourth CIV-04 Magna Carta soft for 13–14. The map of chapters is the skill path; the week picks one focus.

Practice that actually builds learning

In-home try-it — CIV-01 Preamble Phrase Walk

- **Time:** 25–40 minutes.
- **Materials:** U.S. Constitution Preamble text (public domain); phrase cards for one phrase at a time.
- **Safety:** No campaign speech. No virtue promise. Ordinary courtesy if siblings join talk.

- **The fun:** One famous phrase slows down enough to become a document again.
- **The skill:** Source before phrase work; Observe words; then-purpose guess; exit Phrase + aim.

How: Source the Constitution lightly as a whole (who/when/for whom). Pick **one** phrase. Locked opening. Exit ticket as above.

In-home try-it — CIV-02 One Amendment, One Hour

- **Time:** 25–45 minutes.
- **Materials:** One Bill of Rights amendment text; honesty card (ratification era).
- **Safety:** Soft classroom tone; do not expand the amendment into a modern platform as the lesson.
- **The fun:** One short limit/protect line, whole hour, no march.
- **The skill:** Paraphrase as written; who/what the text restrains or protects; one then-word vs casual now-use.

How: Source; paraphrase; name restrain/protect *as written*; note one then-word. Exit: Paraphrase + one then-word note.

In-home try-it — CIV-03 Declaration Sentence

- **Time:** 25–40 minutes.
- **Materials:** One Declaration sentence (rights sentence **or** one grievance — not all).
- **Safety:** No culture-war examples as the default. No morality-play-only story.
- **The fun:** One sentence goes to work for its 1776 audience.
- **The skill:** Source audience (King / “candid world”); what work was this sentence doing in 1776?; separate then-claim from now-feelings.

How: Honesty card. Locked opening. Exit: “This sentence was trying to ____ for audience ____.”

In-home try-it — CIV-04 Magna Carta Clause Soft (13–14; stretch 11–12 with heavy scaffold)

- **Time:** 25–45 minutes.
- **Materials:** One short clause in translation; card naming which text/year/confirmation.
- **Safety:** Honesty about translation. No fake quotations. No “invented democracy that day” myth.
- **The fun:** A written limit on power becomes concrete, not a theme-park slogan.
- **The skill:** Who constrained whom?; what question can this clause answer?; exit Who constrained + one limit of the clause.

How: Tiny story of kings/barons/complaints (two minutes). Source. Gloss. Locked opening. Name what one clause cannot settle.

In-home try-it — CIV-05 Compact / Charter Sentence

- **Time:** 20–35 minutes.
- **Materials:** Mayflower Compact sentence or a local charter line (public domain / credited).
- **Safety:** Not a nation-origin myth dump. Care about who was not at the table — wonder without a guilt lecture and without inventing.
- **The fun:** Problem-of-the-week for the signers, not a fireworks show.
- **The skill:** Source voyage/place; what problem were signers solving *that week*?; exit Problem-that-week + makers.

How: Source. Ask the problem that week. Locked opening adapted to the line’s job. Stop before origin-story romance.

In-home try-it — CIV-06 Rights Word Then/Now

- **Time:** 20–30 minutes.
- **Materials:** One civic excerpt containing *rights*, *liberty*, or *people*.
- **Safety:** No lecturing the teen for a first now-sense. Dictionary is a helper, not the only historical method.
- **The fun:** One charged word gets two columns.
- **The skill:** Possible then-sense / common now-sense; evidence from surrounding lines; exit Then-sense guess with a starred line.

How: Two columns. Wait. Star a supporting line. Revise allowed.

In-home try-it — CIV-07 Civic Text Is Still a Source

- **Time:** 15–25 minutes.
- **Materials:** A printed civic excerpt already used this week.
- **Safety:** Avoid cynicism (“all civic talk is fake”) and purity lectures. Soft examples of misuse (meme, slogan, out-of-context shirt quote) — not a live fight.
- **The fun:** Catch a slogan wearing history’s coat; put the coat back on the document.
- **The skill:** Name a misuse; rewrite as a sourced claim; exit One misuse named + one repair (return to source card).

How: List ways people misuse founding lines. Pick one. Repair by returning to honesty card and paraphrase tied to words.

In-home crumb — WRITE-03-shaped Civic Clause Paraphrase

Write the clause’s job in your own words. Point to the words that support the paraphrase. At 13–14, add one sentence: what this line cannot settle alone.

Out-of-home try-it — OUT-03 Courthouse / Plaque Read (founding idea cited)

- **Time:** 20–40 minutes on site including travel buffer.
- **Materials:** Notebook; adult along.
- **Safety:** Roads; public courtesy; courthouse visit means looking at a building and a plaque or public display — not a protest and not a campaign. No cold quiz of strangers. No photographing strangers without care.
- **The fun:** A founding phrase in bronze or stone — later telling about a place.
- **The skill:** Treat the plaque as a later telling; source who put it up if known; compare plaque wording to a home excerpt of the civic line if you brought one.

How: Transcribe one sentence. Honesty about the plaque’s date. Ask what job the *cited* idea was doing in its document — and what job the *plaque* is doing now as remembrance. Keep soft.

Out-of-home try-it — Library public-domain civic excerpt

- **Time:** 20–40 minutes.
- **Materials:** Library access; printer if available; honesty card template.
- **Safety:** Library rules; parent-mediated screens at 11–12; co-hold at 13–14 if accounts involved.
- **The fun:** Fetch a real public-domain text; leave with a credited printout.
- **The skill:** Which text, which year; honesty card before any slogan talk.

How: Find Preamble, one amendment, or one Declaration sentence in a credited edition. Fill honesty card on site or at the table. Home Hour uses that printout — not a chatbot paraphrase.

Talk box

Exact opening (locked): “What job is this civic line trying to do — and for whom — as a document, not as a slogan?”

Follow-ups:

1. Observe: “What words do you *see* that seem to do the heaviest work?”
2. Maker/audience: “Who drafted or approved this, as far as we can tell — and who was meant to hear it?”
3. Reason tied to the piece: “What does this word mean *then*, from surrounding lines?”
4. Check / alternative: “What power does this line try to limit or name? What can’t this one line settle?”
5. Revise / (13–14) gentle pairing: “You may revise. How does this grievance *shape* rhyme with this limit *shape* — without claiming one finished the other?”

How to wait: Ask. Slow three. Eyes on the clause. Second wait after they finish. Do not fill with a year or a speech. Think-time is classroom-origin craft — useful, not a kitchen RCT.

Stuck silence usually means: vague question; zero wait-time; year-first hunt; guessing the “patriotic” answer; piece never landed; archaic prose load; they think civics means recite; they think looking means agree with a slogan. Fix the question. Gloss one word. Return to the line. Do not turn silence into a campaign.

Blocked for a new move: New to civic edges → one phrase or one amendment

only. Do not stack Magna Carta + Declaration + Constitution the same week.

Mixed for when to use it: Later, mix last week’s paraphrase with CIV-07 misuse repair. Or run then-words for three minutes whenever a meme appears in any chapter.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration):

A student says, “Freedom of speech means I can say anything online with no rules,” after glancing at a modern paraphrase of an amendment, with no honesty card and no text on the table.

Repair: Put the amendment text down. Honesty card. Paraphrase *as written*. Ask what the line tries to limit or protect in its document setting, what a then-word might mean, and what one line cannot settle alone. No pamphlet. No purity lecture. Looking.

This week’s exit-ticket shapes (pick one)

- Phrase + “In the document this seems to aim at ____.”
- Paraphrase + one then-word note.
- “This sentence was trying to ____ for audience ____.”
- Who constrained + one limit of the clause (Magna Carta soft).
- Problem-that-week + makers (compact/charter).
- Misuse named + repair (return to source card).

Practice notes

Banks are a menu. One CIV focus per week beats a chain. DIG / Reading Like a Historian shapes may print civic excerpts — label classroom origin; steal looking moves; leave high-school coefficients upstairs. Composite examples are illustrations. No adolescent portraits. No brand logos. No invented quotations. Access date for this manuscript’s research lock: **13 September 2026**.

Safety reminder for outings

Roads. Courtesy. Hands-off rules. No tasting unknown things. No shoplifting a “test.” No lecture to a stranger’s child. No cold public quiz. No photographing strangers without care. A plaque is print about a place. A courthouse is a building and a display — not a campaign stop.

Pairing without a chain (13–14 illustration)

Week A: one Declaration grievance about a problem type (for example, a complaint about distant rule or unfair process — soft, short).

Week B: one constitutional limit that addresses a similar *problem type* (a structural check, an amendment limit — one line).

Ask how the shapes rhyme. Do not force a story that 1787 solved 1776 completely. Do not march the whole Constitution between them. Two edges. One question. Stop.

For the student

Civic lines are documents. Someone wrote them for a job, for an audience, at a time. Famous words can turn into slogans on shirts. Your job this week is to put the words back on the page and ask what work they were trying to do.

The move. Honesty card first (which text, which year, original or later printing or translation). Then read one short line. Then answer: what job is this line trying to do — and for whom — as a document, not as a slogan?

Tiny worked example (illustration).

You look at one Preamble phrase: “establish Justice.” You do not recite the whole Preamble. You guess: the makers are naming justice as something they want the new system to set up — for “We the People” as the opening audience on the page. You know one phrase cannot settle every modern argument about courts. That limit is part of honest looking.

Try 1. Fill an honesty card for today’s civic excerpt. Point to the clause you will work. Say maker/date/type as far as you can tell.

Try 2. Paraphrase the job of the line in your own words. Underline the words that support your paraphrase. Add one then-word note if a charged word appears (*rights, liberty, people, justice*).

Explain it back. Tell someone how a civic line on the table is different from a slogan on a shirt.

Challenge. Name one thing this single line **cannot** settle by itself. (13–14 stretch: place one grievance *shape* beside one constitutional *limit* shape and say how they rhyme as problem-types — without claiming one year finished the other.)

One more try when you are ready. Catch a misuse (a meme or out-of-context quote). Repair it: return to a sourced card and a paraphrase tied to words.

At 11–12, oral paraphrase is real work. At 13–14, write the paraphrase and the limit sentence in a dated note. You are allowed to wait. You are allowed to revise. Point at the line. You are not a chatbot operator, and you do not need a secret “history friend” account to do this.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Year-first freeze or recitation.

Next move: Cover the year. Ask the locked opening about the line’s job. Attach the year after the job is said. Correct kindly: dates are tools under owned lines, not the civics move.

Diagnostic 2 — Campaign speech / modern rant.

Next move: Return to maker, audience, purpose. Ask what the words on the page try to limit or name. Park the modern argument for another subject time if needed. This Hour stays on the document edge.

Diagnostic 3 — Constitution-chain fatigue.

Next move: Stop after one text. Put other names on a wall map. Resume next week with a different single edge if you want breadth over a month — not six edges in five days.

Diagnostic 4 — Civic meme without source card.

Next move: Honesty card. Original / later printing / modernized spelling. Then-words of one charged word. Paraphrase from the page.

Diagnostic 5 — Virtue-machine disappointment.

Next move: Say the limit once: looking at a document teaches looking; it does not automatically mint civic dispositions. Point to civics / *Publius* if that is the aim. Keep teaching the clause as evidence.

Diagnostic 6 — Archaic prose freeze.

Next move: Adult reads one sentence. Glossary sticky. Return to Observe. Access, not rescue of the claim. If English load is the real wall, scaffold reading, then return to the civic looking move.

Diagnostic 7 — Morality-play Founders only or gotcha erase without looking.

Next move: Both poles skip the line. Put the clause down. Ask what it can show and what it cannot. Wonder about who was not at the table with care — evidenced gaps, not invented people, not a pamphlet.

When to slow down: Slogans own the talk; chain fatigue; prose never lands. Stay on one phrase (CIV-01) with heavy gloss.

When to go ahead: Honesty card fluent; paraphrase tied to words; then-word note appears; (13–14) gentle pairing without forced finish-line claims. Still not Federalist weekly.

When to get a human tutor: Reading access; language support; or facilitation coaching. Not an unsupervised chatbot during the attempt.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers for the adult. Point back to the History Hour AI box for the full allow-and-ban list for ages 11–14.

You may, on your account: find a **named** LOC or other public-domain civic excerpt; ask a tool to explain *to you* a hard word’s then-sense with a caution to verify; print a blank honesty card / paraphrase frame with PARENT KEY; request a SCRIPT of questions after the student tries; ask for revision questions on their draft paraphrase — not a rewrite of their paragraph; diagnose cropped work they already produced.

You may not: generate a “colonial diary” or fake founding letter as a primary; ask a window to “summarize the Constitution” as the whole hour; put a model summary on the table as the source; write the student’s civic paragraph; invent quotations; park an unsupervised companion during the attempt; detector-grade a paraphrase; hand them an agent as a pocket history partner; treat a generated painting of the signing as a primary.

At 11–12, you hold the account (under-13 rules apply; the April 2026 compliance date has passed). At 13–14, co-hold; still in the room; turning 13 is not a licence. Unaided first on looking. SCRIPT after the try. One off-age caution: a high-school math trial showed unguarded chat practice can look good and leave unaided performance worse — that is not an 11–14 history RCT. The kitchen rule: the model prepares the adult; it does not do the student’s looking when looking is the

lesson. Detectors fail; fabricated citations are a parent-side risk — open the real LOC or public-domain page.

TTS or a parent read-aloud can open access to a longer survey chapter while today's looking stays on a short credited clause. Using audio so they never look at today's piece is a substitute, not an accommodation, when looking is the lesson.

What “done enough” looks like

- ☐ One clause or short sentence on the table — not a chain dump.
- ☐ Honesty card filled before slogan talk.
- ☐ Student can attempt the locked opening with a paraphrase tied to words.
- ☐ Then-word note attempted when a charged word appears.
- ☐ Campaign speech and virtue-machine hope interrupted without shame.
- ☐ At least one in-home CIV try-it and one plaque/library civic crumb this month.
- ☐ 11–12: oral exit OK. 13–14: written paraphrase + what the line cannot settle; optional gentle pairing.
- ☐ No invented quotations; public-domain / credited excerpts only.
- ☐ Placement by skill, not birthday.
- ☐ Files under **History** / **Social Studies** (or **Civics** only when the work is actually that) — never a brand, never “Young Minds History I.”

Friday diagnostic wrong (illustration).

Wrong: meme paraphrase with no source card.

Repair heard: honesty card + paraphrase from the page + one then-word.

If the repair happened, check the box. If not, stay on CIV-01.

Transfer check.

Next week, a fresh clause. If job/audience returns with little coaching, the habit is starting. If the campaign speech returns, shorten to one phrase and rebuild.

Band fork reminder.

One text family per week at 11–12. Gentle pairing as edge at 13–14 — still not *Publius*, still not a Government course.

Done enough is right, or wrong-with-a-reason for tomorrow. Revisit next Tuesday: three minutes on last week's paraphrase before a new clause. Life of the habit lives in the History Hour rhythm and in records — not in a ninth teaching chapter.

A path through middle-grades history looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A culture-war win is not. One civic line, sourced and paraphrased, is enough for this week.

When you move to maps and timelines, keep documents as documents. Place and date are tools under stories and lines already owned — not wallpaper over a slogan.

Chapter 6

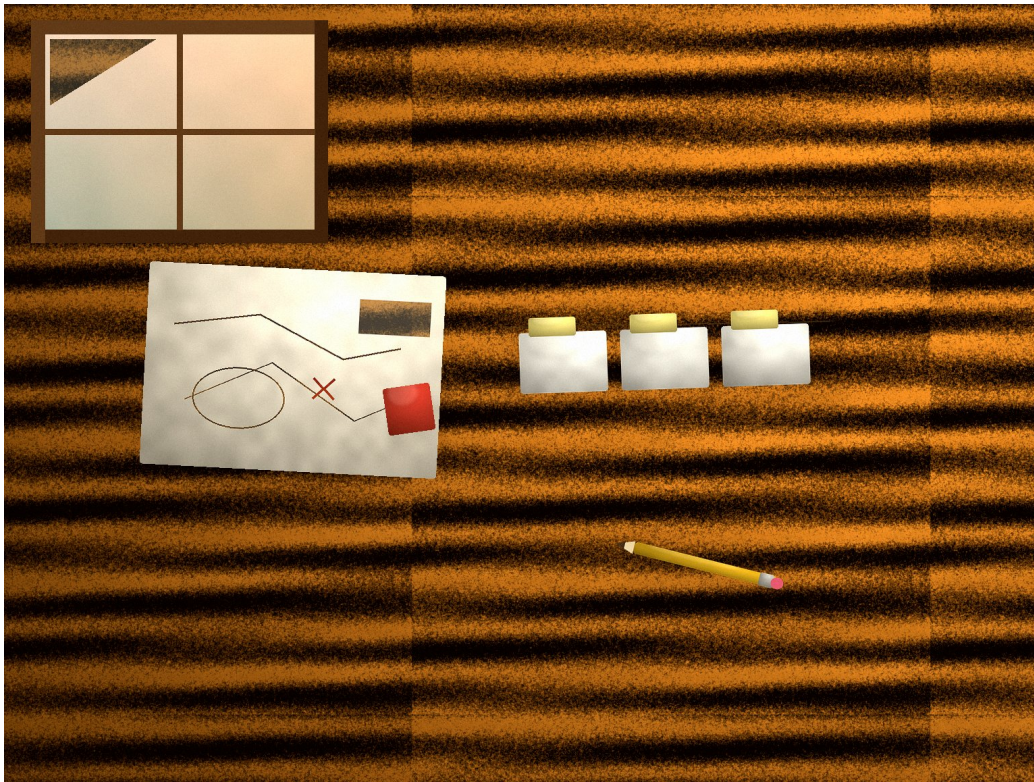


Figure 8: A period map excerpt with one pencil annotation, and a short string of owned-story timeline cards with optional date tags. Still-life. No people. No brand logos.

Maps, timelines, and place at middle grades

Why this matters

Where and when does this belong — and how does the map or timeline help you say that?

That is not a capitals quiz. It is not a chant of centuries. It is the question that turns a wall of pretty maps and a strip of years into tools under a story the student already owns. A letter from a port only makes sense if you can point at the water. A speech about a journey only makes sense if you can feel how long the road took *then*. A date only helps after the story has a face.

Younger children in this house first met place as a picture and time as a clothesline of owned days. *History for Little Thinkers* holds that 5–10 grain. This chapter ages the same idea up. At 11–14 a map is a source with a maker. A timeline is three to seven cards from stories already looked at, not a generated “complete world timeline” pretending to be a year. Dates attach after the story is owned. Simultaneous elsewhere and route-time-cost deepen place without drowning the hour.

What this idea unlocks is spatial and temporal context — the half of looking that asks *where* and *when* without turning History Hour into a geography course or a memorize-all-capitals slog. Wineburg’s contextualization includes both space and time.¹ Barton and Levstik found that younger students often need pictures before dates; by middle grades dates connect to knowledge more readily — and still, a timeline of owned stories beats a wallpaper of centuries.² Wineburg’s later warning still holds: light tours of everything leave few traces. Selective memory is the honest adult job.³

¹Wineburg’s contextualization heuristic (spatial and temporal context) is restated from the 1991 Lexington study in Sam Wineburg, “Historical Thinking and Other Unnatural Acts,” *Phi Delta Kappan* 80, no. 7 (1999), and in earlier sourcing work. Access date for this book’s research: 13 September 2026.

²Keith C. Barton and Linda S. Levstik, “‘Back When God Was Around and Everything’: Elementary Children’s Understanding of Historical Time,” *American Educational Research Journal* 33, no. 2 (1996): 419–454. Pictures-before-dates for younger students; dates connect more readily once knowledge is owned.

³Sam Wineburg, “Crazy for History,” *Journal of American History* 90, no. 4 (2004): 1401–1414. Light coverage leaves few traces; fact-test jeremiads are an old story.

You do not need to be a cartographer. You do need to put one map that belongs to this week's piece on the table, ask who might have made it, and add one date only under a story already owned. Hearing an atlas slog with no story, a century chant, or a map treated as "truth from nowhere" is teaching. Filling the silence with the right year is not.

This week you can learn to annotate one place that belongs to the piece and to add one date only after the story is owned. Today the student can place one sticker or card and say the reason tied to the piece.

Picture two Fridays. In one, a poster of the world hangs over the table and no one has pointed at a harbor that the letter actually names. In the other, a simple map of one coast sits under a credited excerpt; one sticky marks "near here"; the student says why from the line. Both rooms look like history. Only one built a tool the student can reuse next Tuesday.

This remains a history Hour book. Geography appears as maps under stories. The C3 Framework folds Geography under its inquiry map; this chapter borrows the tool, not a full course.⁴ Many middle-grades homeschool families already fold place into history rather than ticking geography as its own line — a 2016 parent survey found geography taught that year to 41 percent of homeschooled sixth-through-eighth-graders, while social science, history, or social studies sat at 82 percent.⁵ Quote those as flags, not as minutes. Fold place honestly. Do not invent a separate continent wall to "catch up."

For the parent: understand it yourself

Many adults remember maps as a Friday quiz and timelines as a strip of names they were supposed to keep forever. Rust on capitals is normal. It is not a character flaw. Five to eight minutes of this section, then the warm-up, is enough for tomorrow. The student still places the sticker.

⁴National Council for the Social Studies, *The College, Career, and Civic Life (C3) Framework for Social Studies State Standards* (Silver Spring, MD: NCSS, 2013). Geography sits under Dimension 2 as a tools neighbor; this chapter remains a history Hour.

⁵Meghan McQuiggan, Mahi Megra, and Sarah Grady, *Parent and Family Involvement in Education: Results from the National Household Education Surveys Program of 2016*, NCES 2017-102 (Washington, DC: National Center for Education Statistics, 2017), Table 9, grades 6–8: social science/history/social studies 82 percent; geography 41 percent. Do not mash elementary rows.

Everyday picture. You have a short excerpt about a ship leaving a named port. Before anyone retells the voyage, you put a simple map of that coast on the table. You ask: “Where does this belong — and how does the map help you say that?” The student finds the water, marks a sticky, and says “near this harbor, because the letter names it.” Then — and only then — you flip a date card and talk about how long the crossing might have taken *then*. The map did a job. The date did a job. Neither replaced the piece.

Precise picture. A *map* in this chapter is a looking tool and, when it is a period map, a source. Someone made it, in a time, for a purpose. What it includes and leaves out is part of the look. A *timeline* is a short line of stories already owned this month — three to seven cards — with dates attached after the story is known. *Periodization* (words like “medieval” or “early modern”) is a label people made. Ask what the label does. Do not treat it as a law of nature. *Route time cost* is the honest gap between then-travel and now-travel, labelled as an estimate, without airplane presentism and without romance. *Simultaneous elsewhere* is one pair — same year, two places — not an encyclopedia of the planet.

Wineburg’s contextualization is the adult name for “put this in its world.” Space and time are two handles on the same move.⁶ Barton and Levstik’s pictures-before-dates finding licenses starting with a place you can see; it does not license skipping dates forever once the student can hold a story.⁷ Wineburg 2004 licenses triage: you choose a few traces that will last.⁸ This is a useful study pattern, not a promise that every home will see the same result. Then teach.

C3 History 6–8 asks students to analyze connections among events in broader contexts and to classify change and continuity.⁹ The kitchen translation is one neighboring card on an owned timeline, and one “this took years” mark on a process

⁶Wineburg’s contextualization heuristic (spatial and temporal context) is restated from the 1991 Lexington study in Sam Wineburg, “Historical Thinking and Other Unnatural Acts,” *Phi Delta Kappan* 80, no. 7 (1999), and in earlier sourcing work. Access date for this book’s research: 13 September 2026.

⁷Keith C. Barton and Linda S. Levstik, “‘Back When God Was Around and Everything’: Elementary Children’s Understanding of Historical Time,” *American Educational Research Journal* 33, no. 2 (1996): 419–454. Pictures-before-dates for younger students; dates connect more readily once knowledge is owned.

⁸Sam Wineburg, “Crazy for History,” *Journal of American History* 90, no. 4 (2004): 1401–1414. Light coverage leaves few traces; fact-test jeremiads are an old story.

⁹NCSS, *C3 Framework*, D2.His.1.6-8 (connections in broader contexts) and D2.His.2.6-8 (change and continuity). Kitchen translation: one neighboring owned card; one process marked “years.”

— not a wall of centuries. Lee’s work on second-order ideas treats a century as a convention people use, not as a personality (“the 1800s were...”).¹⁰ Keep the century as a shelf label. Do not let it become a sermon.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. *Atlas slog with no owned story.* The student colors a continent or recites capitals while the week’s piece sits closed. The map became wallpaper. Repair: close the atlas. Open the piece. Mark one place the piece actually names.
2. *Century chanting.* “What century is this?” asked before anyone owns the story, or “the 1700s were...” as a personality. Repair: tell the small story first; place the piece on a century line after; name one limit of century labels.
3. *Generated “complete world timeline” as curriculum.* A machine or a poster offers every year as the year’s work. Repair: three to seven owned cards. One new date under a story already looked at. The rest is a map of the year, not the hour.
4. *Map as “truth from nowhere.”* The student treats the lines as nature, with no maker. Repair: “Who might have made this map, and for whom?” Even a modern school map has a publisher and a purpose. A period map is a source with inclusions and silences.
5. *Airplane presentism.* “Why didn’t they just fly?” or a yarn route treated as a weekend drive. Repair: a labelled estimate of then-speed; estimated then-time versus now-time; one their-world sentence about weather, water, or season.

A sixth, quieter miss: *date flashcards first, then shame for the wrong year.* Dates help after the story is owned. A wrong year is information. It is not a character.

Five-to-eight-minute parent warm-up

Do this alone, with tomorrow’s piece, before anyone sits down.

Minute 1. Find one map that belongs to this week’s piece — a period map if you have a credited image, or a simple modern map of a then-place. Note the maker if known.

¹⁰Peter Lee, “Putting Principles into Practice: Understanding History,” in *How Students Learn: History, Mathematics, and Science in the Classroom*, ed. M. Suzanne Donovan and John D. Bransford (Washington, DC: National Academies Press, 2005). Century as a convention, not a personality.

Minute 2. Cover any date on the piece. Say the small story in two sentences without the year.

Minute 3. Place one timeline card only under a story already owned this month. If nothing is owned yet, the card waits.

Minute 4. Write one authentic question that is not a year quiz: “Where does this belong, and how does the map help you say that?”

Minute 5. Sketch a rough travel-speed note if a journey is in the piece. Label it *estimate*.

Minute 6. Decide the exit ticket: sticker plus “near ____ / far from us,” or ordered cards plus “the date helped because ____.”

Minute 7. Practice the wait. Ask the question aloud. Count three. Do not answer yourself.

Minute 8. Put the pencil down. You are ready. The student places the sticker.

How to teach it this week

The History Hour chapter holds the full session shape. Here is the same five beats scaled to maps and timelines. Keep the hour at about twenty-five to forty-five minutes. If a day only holds twenty-five, run the source card, one annotation or one ordered line, and the exit ticket.

1. Source before summary (4–8 min). Put the piece and the map (or the timeline cards) in view. Attribution first: who made the *piece*, and — if it is a period map — who made the *map*. Honesty card: original / excerpt / reproduction / modern map of a then-place. The student names what they notice about the source and the map’s credit line before anyone tells the voyage story.

2. Short look at the body (5–12 min). Read a short excerpt. Observe → Reflect → Question. One historical question the map or the cards can actually speak to: where, when, how long, what else was nearby.

3. Short background or talk (5–10 min). Two minutes of place names and one neighboring story already owned. Not a continent lecture. If a date will matter, preview that dates help *after* the story has a face.

4. One try (8–15 min). One named try-it from the MAP or TIME list below. One try. Not a packet of blank maps.

5. Exit ticket (2–4 min). Sticker plus reason, or ordered line plus “the date helped because ____,” or one inclusion then / one inclusion now on a period map. Done-enough is right, or wrong-with-a-reason you can use tomorrow — not a percentage.

Exact wording you can say:

- “Where and when does this belong — and how does the map or timeline help you say that?”
- “Who might have made this map — and for whom?”
- “What would travel cost in time *then*?”
- “What else was happening elsewhere — one pair only?”
- “Where could a date go only if we already own the story?”
- “You may move one card.”
- “Near ____ / far from us — what in the piece makes you say that?”

First try-it for the student. After the source card, put a simple map matching the week’s piece on the table and a few sticky dots. Ask the locked opening. Wait. The student marks where and labels *guess* versus *known from the piece*. That is MAP-01, Annotate Where. It is enough for the first sitting.

How to fade help. First you point at the harbor with your finger while you wait. Then you point at the map and stay quiet. Then you sit back and let them choose the sticky. Stop talking when they are mid-look. Look at the map, not at the adolescent, if the silence is hard.

When to stop talking. After you ask. After they stop, wait again. If they are hunting a year because you asked year-first, fix the question. If they offer a summary-only guess, return to the piece and the map. Do not fill the silence with the right year.

Age-band moves

11–12. One sticker with a reason tied to the piece. Adult scaffolds hard place-names. Dates used as labels once the story is owned. Oral exit is honest: “Near this river, because the letter names it.” Century as a shelf, not a personality. One commemorative day, handled softly, is enough.

13–14. Border-line soft: what a line on a map did to people, without nationalist cheerleading and without a despair lecture. Living memory versus beyond: one

family-consented card beside one document from before anyone at the table was alive. Simultaneous elsewhere: same year, two places, one connecting question. Still one pair. Still not a continent wall.

Place by skill, not birthday. If a thirteen-year-old still treats the atlas as the hour, stay on one sticker and a reason. If an eleven-year-old already asks who made the old map and what it leaves out, grow the period-map look.

A sample week (illustration, not a calendar)

Labelled hypothetical. Focus move: map and timeline as tools under this month's owned stories.

- Monday: MAP-01 Annotate Where on the week's piece.
- Tuesday: TIME-01 Date After Story with three event cards.
- Wednesday: MAP-03 Route Time Cost or TIME-02 Century as Tool.
- Thursday: MAP-04 Local Marker Spot or OUT-03 Plaque Read with place talk — one annotation, not a scavenger hunt.
- Friday: one diagnostic (atlas slog or year-first) repaired; done-enough checklist on “sticker plus reason” and “date after story.”

A second week might focus MAP-02 Period Map as Source. A third, TIME-05 Simultaneous Elsewhere for a student ready for one pair. The chapter is the skill path. The week picks one focus.

Practice that actually builds learning

Named try-its below carry **time, materials, safety, the fun, the skill**. Library, museum, courthouse plaque, and kitchen table *are* the practice. They do not replace the looking move. Pick one in-home and one out-of-home this week. Coverage itch is the enemy of looking.

Safety is ordinary on every outing: roads; aisle courtesy; museum hands-off rules; no tasting unknown things; no shoplifting a “test”; no lecture to a stranger's child; no cold public quiz of strangers; no photographing strangers without care. A plaque is print about a place. It is not a sermon about a city.

In-home try-its — maps

MAP-01 Annotate Where - **Time:** 20–30 minutes. - **Materials:** A simple map matching the week’s piece; sticky dots; the credited excerpt. - **Safety:** Table only. No outdoor navigation homework. - **The fun:** Choosing a color and planting a flag on a real harbor the letter names. - **The skill:** After sourcing, mark where; label *guess* versus *known*. - **Steps:** Source card first. Ask the locked opening. Student places one sticky. Writes “Near ____ / far from us.” Stars the line that licensed the sticky. - **Error pattern:** Perfect accuracy demand; map as wallpaper. - **Exit ticket:** Sticker + “Near ____ / far from us.”

MAP-02 Period Map as Source - **Time:** 25–40 minutes. - **Materials:** A credited period map image and a modern map of the same region; honesty cards. - **Safety:** Screen with an adult if the image is online. No generated “old map” filed as a period source. - **The fun:** Spotting what the old map bothers to draw — and what it skips. - **The skill:** Sourcing a map: who made it, for whom; what is included or left out. - **Steps:** Attribution on the old map first. Then look. Then set the modern map beside it. One inclusion then; one inclusion now. - **Error pattern:** “Old maps wrong, new maps true” as a morality play. - **Exit ticket:** One inclusion then / one inclusion now.

MAP-03 Route Time Cost - **Time:** 25–35 minutes. - **Materials:** Map; yarn or string; a rough travel-speed card the adult provides, labelled *estimate*. - **Safety:** Yarn stays on the table. Do not send a twelve-year-old to walk a historic route as homework. - **The fun:** Stretching a journey you can see. - **The skill:** Time cost without romance; then-time versus now-time. - **Steps:** Yarn the journey the text names. Talk weather, water, season if the piece supports it. Write estimated then-time versus now-time. - **Error pattern:** Airplane presentism; unsafe outdoor navigation as homework. - **Exit ticket:** Estimated then-time vs now-time.

MAP-05 Border Line Soft (13–14 grain; stretch only if the younger student already owns the place) - **Time:** 25–40 minutes. - **Materials:** A map showing a historical boundary change that belongs to a story already owned. - **Safety:** Keep the example soft. Everyday movement, work, and streets — not trauma tourism, not a live border fight. - **The fun:** Noticing that a line on paper changed someone’s walk to market. - **The skill:** A line on a map is a human decision with consequences. - **Steps:** Source the map. Ask what the line did to people in one ordinary way (a road, a river crossing, a market town). Write one human-consequence question for a later hour. - **Error pattern:** Nationalist cheerleading; despair lecture. - **Exit**

ticket: One human-consequence question for later.

MAP-06 Water / Land Constraint - Time: 20–30 minutes. - **Materials:** A map with water; a short text about trade or travel. - **Safety:** No forced-migration deep-dive. No graphic harm as the default piece. - **The fun:** Deciding walk, ride, or sail from evidence. - **The skill:** Constraint from map plus text, not from a modern hunch. - **Steps:** Source both. Circle a path type. Star the map feature and the line that support it. - **Error pattern:** Guessing from now-roads; trauma deep-dive without readiness. - **Exit ticket:** Circle path type + reason.

In-home try-its — time

TIME-01 Date After Story - Time: 20–30 minutes. - **Materials:** Three event cards without dates on the face; dates on the reverse; stories already owned this month. - **Safety:** Table only. No shame for a wrong year. - **The fun:** Playing detective with the story logic first, then flipping. - **The skill:** Dates attach after the story is owned; dates then help you revise. - **Steps:** Order by story logic. Flip dates. Revise. Talk why the date helped once you knew the story. - **Error pattern:** Date flashcards first; shame for the wrong year. - **Exit ticket:** Ordered line + one “date helped because ____.”

TIME-02 Century as Tool - Time: 15–25 minutes. - **Materials:** A century number line; this week’s piece. - **Safety:** None special. - **The fun:** Parking one piece on a long shelf and noticing how little the shelf says. - **The skill:** What a century does and does not tell. - **Steps:** Place the piece. Name one thing the century label helps. Name one thing it cannot tell (a season, a person’s age, a local street). - **Error pattern:** Century as personality. - **Exit ticket:** Piece placed + one limit of century labels.

TIME-03 Before / After Chain - Time: 20–35 minutes. - **Materials:** Five cards for a process already owned (a crossing, a harvest, a charter’s long argument — one process). - **Safety:** Keep the process ordinary. No atrocity sequence as the default chain. - **The fun:** Seeing that “an event” was often years. - **The skill:** Change and continuity; process, not snap. - **Steps:** Build before/after. Mark which cards are actually long processes. Circle one “years” card. - **Error pattern:** Snap-change (“and then it was a country”). - **Exit ticket:** One process marked “years.”

TIME-04 Living Memory vs Beyond - Time: 20–30 minutes. - **Materials:** One family-consented living-memory card (a relative’s dated story, used with permission) and one piece from beyond living memory. - **Safety:** Family consent first.

No trapping a relative. No cold stranger “oral history.” - **The fun:** Noticing what a voice in the room can do that a page from 1600 cannot — and the reverse. - **The skill:** Oral history and documents do different jobs. - **Steps:** Source both. What can living memory tell? What needs a document? One example each. - **Error pattern:** Declaring oral history worthless; declaring documents cold. - **Exit ticket:** Living memory / beyond — one example each.

TIME-05 Simultaneous Elsewhere (13–14 grain) - **Time:** 25–40 minutes. - **Materials:** Two short, credited traces from the same year in two places already touched this term. - **Safety:** One pair only. Fight the coverage itch. - **The fun:** The click that “the same year” was not one street. - **The skill:** Broader context without an encyclopedia dump. - **Steps:** Place both. Ask one connecting question the two pieces can actually support. Stop. - **Error pattern:** Encyclopedia dump; a generated world-year list. - **Exit ticket:** Same year / two places / one connecting question.

TIME-06 Calendar Commemoration Soft - **Time:** 20–30 minutes. - **Materials:** A calendar; one commemorative day that belongs to a story already owned. - **Safety:** No forced observance. No mocking anyone’s remembrance. Soft entry: tickets, streets, work, a named day. - **The fun:** Asking who put the day on the calendar. - **The skill:** Commemoration is a later choice; simplification is normal; looking stays honest. - **Steps:** Who put this day on calendars? What is remembered? What is simplified? Source card if a founding text is nearby — still a document, not a slogan. - **Error pattern:** Forced observance; mockery; turning the hour into a campaign. - **Exit ticket:** “This day marks ; *a simplification is* .”

Out-of-home try-its

MAP-04 Local Marker Spot - **Time:** 25–45 minutes, outing hybrid. - **Materials:** A local plaque, courthouse stone, or named public building; phone photo of the *plaque* is fine; later, a home map and a sticky. - **Safety:** Public sidewalks and public buildings only. No trespassing. No filming people. No cold-quizzing passersby. Roads and courtesy. - **The fun:** Finding a line about *this* street, then parking it on the kitchen map. - **The skill:** Commissioning is sourcing. A plaque has a maker. - **Steps:** Read with an adult. Who commissioned the plaque, if the line says? Photo the words, not strangers. At home, one map sticker. - **Error pattern:** Trespassing; treating the plaque as “the city speaking from nowhere.” - **Exit ticket:** Photo + “Plaque says ; *put up by* (if known).”

OUT-03 Courthouse / Plaque Read, with place talk - **Time:** 25–40 minutes. - **Materials:** A local civic-building plaque; notebook. - **Safety:** Same as MAP-04. A courthouse visit is looking at a building and a public display — not a protest and not a campaign. - **The fun:** Copying one sentence in your own hand on the steps, then finding the place on a map at the table later. - **The skill:** Plaque as print about a place; light civic language still gets a source card. - **Steps:** Transcribe one sentence. Commissioner if known. At home: where does this building sit, and what older map of the same town includes or leaves out? - **Error pattern:** Filming people; turning rights language into a rally. - **Exit ticket:** One transcribed sentence + commissioner if known + home-map sticky.

Museum map gallery — one annotation - **Time:** 30–45 minutes inside a visit you were already taking, or a virtual gallery with an adult. - **Materials:** One map on the wall or screen; notebook; later, a kitchen reprint or postcard if the museum allows. - **Safety:** Hands off. No racing rooms. No photographing visitors. - **The fun:** Being the person who looks at *one* map while everyone else walks past. - **The skill:** Observe before the placard; then who wrote the placard; one annotation, not a continent wall. - **Steps:** One map. Observe a full minute. Then the placard. Who made the map, if said? One sticky-note annotation you can bring home in words. - **Error pattern:** Scavenger hunt that replaces looking; treating the placard as the primary without noticing. - **Exit ticket:** Object (the map) + placard author if known + one wonder.

Library and museum visits are ordinary in this pond — a recent federal survey found 53 percent of homeschool families reporting a library visit in the past month and 43 percent an art gallery, museum, or historical site.¹¹ Those rows license the invitation. They do not replace the sticker-plus-reason move.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “Where and when does this belong — and how does the map or timeline help you say that?”

Follow-ups (use three to five):

1. Observe: “What do you see on the map — water, a road, a name, a blank?”

¹¹National Center for Education Statistics, *Homeschooling in the United States: Results from the 2022–23 Parent and Family Involvement in Education Survey*, NCES 2024-113 (Washington, DC: NCES, 2024), Table A-5, Homeschool row: library visit in the past month 53 percent; art gallery, museum, or historical site 43 percent. Access date 13 September 2026.

2. Maker: “Who might have made this map, and for whom?”
3. Reason tied to the piece: “How do you know from *this* line, not from a guess about now?”
4. Check or alternative: “What would travel cost in time? What else was happening elsewhere? Where could a date go only if we already own the story?”
5. Revise: “You may move one card. You may change your mind.”

How to wait. After you ask, a slow three is a convention, not a sacrament. Classroom wait-time research is mostly science-class in origin (Rowe) and later discussion craft (Stahl); borrow the pause; do not treat those studies as a kitchen history trial.¹² After they stop, wait again. If they are mid-look, do not cut them off. Look at the map or the cards, not at the adolescent, if the silence is hard.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague (“tell me about the map”). Wait-time was zero. They are hunting a year because you asked year-first. They are guessing what you want. The piece never landed. They offered a summary-only guess. They think history means “repeat the parent’s story” or “the textbook is the facts.” Archaic place-names need a scaffold before talk. Your job is to pose, wait, and point back at the sourced line and the map — not to fill the silence with the right year, and not to turn the table into a fight.

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked (new move). One map *or* one short card line. MAP-01 or TIME-01 alone. No second continent. No extra century chant “for enrichment.”

Mixed (when the move is stable). Pair MAP-02 with a short narrative of the same place (the CORR-06 neighbor: map versus narrative — which question does each answer?). Pair TIME-03 with a process already owned from Chapter 4. Pair a plaque outing with a home sticky the same week.

¹²Mary Budd Rowe, “Wait-Time and Rewards as Instructional Variables, Their Influence on Language, Logic, and Fate Control,” *Journal of Research in Science Teaching* 11, no. 2 (1974; work dated 1972 in the tradition): elementary *science* classes. Robert J. Stahl, “Using ‘Think-Time’ and ‘Wait-Time’ Skillfully in the Classroom” (ERIC Digest, 1994). Borrow the pause. Do not mash as a kitchen history trial.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration)

Labelled illustration, not a reported family. A parent prints a generated “complete world timeline, 4000 BCE–present,” colors the 1700s, and asks, “What century is the Boston letter?” The student chants “eighteenth” and cannot point at the harbor the letter names. The map on the wall is decoration. The year is a performance.

Repair. Put the letter down. Cover the year. Ask the locked opening over a simple coast map. One sticky. One reason from the line. Flip the date after the story is said. Recycle the generated poster as wallpaper in another room if you must — it is not this week’s curriculum.

Other misses to hear this month, repaired in one move: airplane presentism (yarn plus labelled estimate); “old maps wrong, new maps true” (one inclusion then / one inclusion now); date flashcards first (story order, then flip).

For the student

A map is a tool, not a poster you are supposed to memorize. A timeline is a short line of stories you already know, not a test of every year. Your job today is to put one mark that belongs to the piece in front of you, and to say why from that piece.

What this idea is. History happened somewhere. It happened in a when. The map helps you say *where* without guessing from the street you live on now. The timeline helps you say *when* after you already know the story. Some maps are sources — a person made them, for a reason, and left things out. Some dates help only after the story has a face.

Tiny worked example (illustration). You have a short letter that names a harbor and a crossing. A simple map of that coast is on the table. You cover the year. You ask yourself: where does this belong? You put a sticky on the water near the named harbor. You write: “Near this harbor, because the letter names it. Far from my kitchen.” Then you flip the date. The date helps you say the crossing was a season, not an afternoon. That is enough for one sitting.

Try 1. On this week’s piece, place one sticky. Label *guess* or *known*. Write “Near ____ / far from us.” Star the line that licensed the sticky.

Try 2. Order three story cards you already know *before* you look at the years. Flip.

Move one card if the date makes you change your mind. Finish the sentence: “The date helped because ____.”

Explain it back. In your own words, tell someone at the table what a map can do that a summary cannot, and what a date can do only after you own the story.

Challenge. If you are ready: look at an old map of the same place and a new one. Name one thing the old map includes that the new one does not — or the reverse. Or take a walk with an adult to a local plaque. Copy one sentence. Who put the plaque up, if it says? Park that sentence on the kitchen map later.

You may change your mind when you look. You may write “I don’t know yet” on a maker line. You do not have to chant centuries. You do not have to finish a wall of the world.

If it isn’t clicking

Three diagnostics. No shame. A wrong reason is information.

1. The atlas ate the hour. Symptom: coloring, capitals, or a generated world timeline, and no one has pointed at the piece. Next move: close the extra maps. Run MAP-01 only. One sticky. One reason. If the student cannot yet read the place-name, you say the name and they still place the sticky. Slow down here. Do not add TIME-05 to “enrich” a stuck Monday.

2. Year-first freeze or year-first performance. Symptom: silence while they hunt a year, or a fluent century with no story. Next move: cover every date. Run TIME-01. Order by story logic. Flip last. If they are guessing what you want, say: “I do not have a year I am waiting for. I want a place or a story order you can show.”

3. Map as truth from nowhere, or airplane presentism. Symptom: “The map just shows it” with no maker; or “they should have driven.” Next move: MAP-02 for maker talk, or MAP-03 with a labelled estimate. Ask one their-world question from Chapter 4: what would have to be true in *their* world for this crossing to make sense? Then stop. Do not scold “they weren’t stupid.”

When to slow down. One sticker and a reason are not stable. Archaic place-names are the blocker — scaffold the reading, then return to the looking move. Living-memory work needs consent you do not yet have — skip TIME-04 until

you do.

When to go ahead. They place a sticky with a reason from the line, attach a date after the story, and can name one limit of a century label. Then MAP-02, MAP-03, or TIME-03 is fair. Border-line soft and simultaneous elsewhere wait until that floor is honest.

When to get a human tutor. Place-name reading is so heavy that every hour becomes decoding, and a reading teacher would help access. Or a family wants a geography *course* — that is a different title. Point at a Geography year if the work is actually that. This chapter will not become that course.

Hearing a wrong reason, then asking a better question, then naming a better move if needed, is teaching. Silence in the face of a wallpaper map is not kindness. A lecture about every capital is not teaching either.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers for you, the adult. Keep this short. The History Hour chapter already holds the full AI box for ages 11–14. Point back there.

You may, on *your* account, after the student has tried — or before, for your own prep — ask a tool to explain this week’s map idea from a *named* lesson or credited map; to make a blank map with empty labels or a blank timeline with a **parent key** the student never sees; to give you a short SCRIPT of questions to say after they look; or to suggest revision questions after they have placed a sticker (“What in the piece licenses that mark?”). Crop a photo to the paper or the map if you ask for a diagnosis. You hear the diagnosis. You talk to the student.

You may not paste tonight’s map and take the answers. You may not ask the tool to generate a period map or a “complete world timeline” and file it as a source or as the year’s curriculum. You may not treat a generated painting of a harbor as a primary. You may not park an unsupervised chatbot as the student’s only partner. You may not invent a maker or a year. Look. At 11–12 you hold the account. At 13–14 you still co-hold and stay in the room. Turning 13 is not a licence.

A fluent filled blank from a machine is performance, not the student’s looking. In a high-school *math* trial, an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse on the test with the window closed.¹³ That is not an 11–14

¹³Hamsa Bastani et al., “Generative AI Can Harm Learning,” *Proceedings of the National*

history study. The kitchen rule it supports: the model may prepare you and the next looking page; it may not place the sticker or flip the date when those are the lesson.

Paper tools that earn their keep: sticky dots; yarn; index cards with dates on the reverse; a century number line you drew; a library map reprint; a museum postcard of a map. A wall timeline of owned cards is a tool. A brand-name poster is furniture until someone points.

What “done enough” looks like

Not a perfect Tuesday. Not a finished binder. Not a capitals score.

This week’s checklist (place by skill, not birthday)

- ☐ The student can put one sticky on a map that belongs to this week’s piece and say a reason tied to the piece.
- ☐ Attribution was said before the voyage story — on the piece, and on a period map if you used one.
- ☐ At least one date was attached *after* an owned story, not as a cold flashcard.
- ☐ One limit was named: a century cannot tell a season; a map cannot show a kitchen; a plaque has a commissioner.
- ☐ One try lived at home; one try lived outside, or a walk-sized instance if you are homebound (a window-sill map of the street plus a photo of a plaque you already have).
- ☐ The exit ticket is in the dated notebook under **History** or **Social Studies** — never a brand, never Young Minds History I.
- ☐ You heard one wrong turn (atlas slog, year-first, map-from-nowhere, airplane presentism) and asked a better question.

Band exits

- 11–12: “Near ___, because this line names it.” One sticker. One date after the story. Oral is honest.
- 13–14: A period-map inclusion then/now, or a same-year pair with one connecting question, or a border-line human-consequence question — still one focus, still not a continent wall.

Academy of Sciences 122 (2025). Turkish high-school *math*; labelled off-age for this literacy/history band. One crutch sentence, then teach.

When to move on. The sticker-plus-reason holds after a night. The student can show the same skill two ways — oral and a card, or a kitchen map and a plaque photo. A “grade 7 social studies workbook” map packet is a publisher’s scope, not a legal grade, and not a transcript line. If they only repeat your summary of the voyage, the map was decoration. Rerun with the body covered and the sticky in their hand.

You are not running a geography diploma. You are teaching a tool under a story. Next Tuesday, revisit yesterday’s sticky. Mix last week’s harbor with a new card only when the first harbor is owned. Stop while a look remains.

Chapter 7



Figure 9: A dated notebook page with three labelled boxes — claim, evidence, limit — beside a short credited excerpt and a pencil. Still-life. No people. No brand logos.

Talking and writing history

Why this matters

What do you claim — and which named source shows it?

That is not a timed essay. It is not a request for a fluent paragraph a machine could have written. It is the question that turns looking into a sentence another person can check. A claim without a source is a vibe. A source named with no claim is a caption. History talk at this age is a claim that points. History writing at this age is the same claim, slower, on a dated page.

Younger children in this house told back a piece-from-then and pointed at who made it. *History for Little Thinkers* holds that oral grain. *English for Young Minds* holds sentence craft and literacy claim-and-evidence. *Critical Thinking for Young Minds* holds two-source judgment on ordinary *present* stakes. This chapter is the history lane: a spoken or written claim about a *past* piece, with the maker in the sentence. One pointer each, then teach.

What this idea unlocks is the middle-grades writing exit the C3 Framework names in ordinary language: organize evidence to develop a claim.¹⁴ Digital Inquiry Group's classroom materials put the same spine in teacher language — back up claims with evidence from original documents.¹⁵ Copy the shape. Label the classroom origin. Do not import a high-school packet as the weekly spine.

Regular writing alone does not install those features. Monte-Sano and Thomson found that students who wrote regularly still needed instruction aimed at argument and historical thinking — reading, evidence analysis, and claim development taught together, not a stack of summaries hoped into discipline.¹⁶ That is a useful study, not a promise that every home will see the same result. Then teach. The parent models one claim sentence that names the source, waits, and asks for a revision

¹⁴National Council for the Social Studies, *The College, Career, and Civic Life (C3) Framework for Social Studies State Standards* (Silver Spring, MD: NCSS, 2013), D2.His.16.6-8: organize evidence from multiple sources to develop a claim. Access date 13 September 2026.

¹⁵Digital Inquiry Group (formerly Stanford History Education Group), *Reading Like a Historian* teacher materials: claims backed by evidence from original documents. Classroom origin. Copy shape; do not import a grade-11 effect size as a home promise.

¹⁶Chauncey Monte-Sano and Amanda Thomson, work collected as Monte-Sano and Thomson (2022) on regular writing versus instructed historical argument. Regular writing alone was not enough; teach reading, evidence analysis, and claim development together.

that targets evidence, not polish.

You do not need to be a historian. You do need to hear a claim with no source, a source with no claim, a chatbot paragraph filed as the student's, and a disagreement that never points at a line — and to ask the locked question, then wait. Hearing those wrong turns is teaching. Filling the silence with your own perfect paragraph is not.

This week you can learn to model one claim sentence that names the source and to ask one revision question that targets evidence. Today the student can write: "I claim ____ because [source name / maker] shows ____." At 13–14 they add one limitation sentence.

Picture two Fridays. In one, the notebook holds a tidy summary that could have come from any textbook page — or from a window. In the other, three sentences name a letter, point at a starred line, and admit what the letter cannot tell. Both pages look like writing. Only one is history looking on paper.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Many adults remember history writing as "five paragraphs about causes" or as a worksheet blank. Others remember no writing at all — only talk that drifted. Rust on essay formulas is normal. It is not a character flaw. Five to eight minutes of this section, then the warm-up, is enough for tomorrow. The student still writes the blanks.

Everyday picture. A short credited excerpt is on the table. You have already done the source card. You ask: "What do you claim — and which named source shows it?" You wait. The student says, "I claim the shop was closed that Monday because the shopkeeper's notice, dated that week, lists the hours and the closing." They point. If they say "because shops close on Mondays" with no piece, you send them back: "Which named source shows it?" That pointing is the move.

Precise picture. A *claim* here is a sentence about the past that could be wrong and that the piece can speak to. *Evidence* is a starred line, a caption detail, or a map mark — something another person can find. A *limit* is one honest sentence about what this source cannot tell (a motive we were not given; a street we cannot see; a person missing from the record). At 11–12 the exit may be one sentence, maybe one quote scrap. At 13–14 it is a short paragraph: claim, evidence with attribution,

one limitation. Still not a Document-Based Question from an Advanced Placement sitting. Still not a five-chapter thesis.

Talk is not a luxury before writing. Nystrand's work on authentic questions — questions where the asker has not already scripted the answer — is the spirit of the talk box.¹⁷ Materials do not discuss themselves; even well-designed document lessons produced almost no whole-class text-based discussion in one closely watched high-school set.¹⁸ Accountable Talk, from a professional-development checklist, names three debts: to the people at the table (turn-taking), to knowledge (how do you know?), and to rigorous thinking (a reason, not a vibe).¹⁹ Borrow the three as craft. Do not treat the checklist as a history trial. Stahl's think-time is a convention for waiting after a question and after an answer; Rowe's original wait-time work is science class.²⁰ Borrow the pause. Do not mash those names as a kitchen RCT.

Monte-Sano and De La Paz's middle-school disciplinary-literacy work is the writing neighbor: cognitive apprenticeship (I do / we do / you do); choose evidence that would matter to a skeptic; name who and where the evidence comes from.²¹ Copy the shape. Do not paste a classroom coefficient onto the kitchen table.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. *Claim with no source.* "They were hungry." No letter, no list, no maker. Repair: "Which named source shows it?" Star a line or return to the source card.
2. *Source named but no claim.* A perfect attribution paragraph and then "so that's the document." Repair: "What do you claim *about the past* from this

¹⁷Martin Nystrand and colleagues: an authentic question is one whose asker has not pre-specified the answer. Recitation ("what year...") is the contrast.

¹⁸Avishag Reisman, "Reading Like a Historian: A Document-Based History Curriculum Intervention in Urban High Schools," *Cognition and Instruction* 30, no. 1 (2012): 86–112. Grade 11; materials ≠ discussion. Label origin.

¹⁹Sarah Michaels, Catherine O'Connor, Megan Hall, and Lauren B. Resnick, Accountable Talk sourcebook: accountability to community, knowledge, and rigorous thinking. Professional-development checklist, not a history trial.

²⁰Mary Budd Rowe, wait-time in elementary *science* (1972 tradition). Robert J. Stahl, "Using 'Think-Time' and 'Wait-Time' Skillfully in the Classroom" (ERIC Digest, 1994). Borrow the pause.

²¹Monte-Sano / De La Paz middle-school disciplinary literacy: cognitive apprenticeship; evidence that would speak to a skeptic; name the source. Classroom neighbor, not a kitchen coefficient.

piece?” One sentence.

3. *Chatbot claim.* The exit ticket reads like a fluent encyclopedia. Repair: close the window. Student writes from the piece in view. Tool only after a real draft, on your account, as revision questions — not a rewrite.
4. *Disagreement that never points at a line.* Two voices, then a winner picked by vibe. Repair: “A emphasizes ; **B emphasizes** ; I still need ____.” No forced good-guys ending.
5. *Filling the silence with the parent’s paragraph.* You asked, counted one, and narrated the claim. Repair: wait. If the excerpt is too hard, scaffold one sentence of *access* (read a line aloud). Do not rescue the *claim*.

A sixth: *quote dump* — three copied lines and no sentence of their own. Repair: sentence 1 names writer, date, type; then one claim; then one support.

Five-to-eight-minute parent warm-up

Do this alone, with tomorrow’s piece.

Minute 1. Write one model claim sentence that names the source. Put it in your pocket. You will not read it first.

Minute 2. Star the line that would support that claim. Star one thing the piece cannot tell.

Minute 3. Write one revision question that targets evidence, not polish: “Where is the claim in your sentence? Point to the evidence in the piece.”

Minute 4. Plan the wait after the locked opening. Count three aloud once, now, so you remember.

Minute 5. Decide the band exit: one sentence (11–12) or short paragraph plus limitation (13–14).

Minute 6. If two learners will sit, plan one uptake prompt: “Add one idea to what ____ said, tied to the text.”

Minute 7. Cut any second excerpt you do not need. One piece is enough for a first claim.

Minute 8. Put the model sentence away. You are ready. They write the blanks.

How to teach it this week

The History Hour chapter holds the full session shape. Here is the same five beats scaled to talk and a short claim. Keep twenty-five to forty-five minutes. If a day only holds twenty-five, run the source card, one because-the-line talk, and a three-sentence exit.

- 1. Source before summary (4–8 min).** Attribution card first. The student names maker, date, type, audience if known, honesty flag. No claim yet. No summary yet.
- 2. Short look at the body (5–12 min).** Observe → Reflect → Question. Adult reads archaic lines if needed. One question the piece can actually answer.
- 3. Short background or talk (5–10 min).** Two minutes of story the piece can carry. Then the talk box — not a lecture that writes the claim for them.
- 4. One try (8–15 min).** One TALK try-it or one WRITE try-it. One. A spoken claim can be the whole try on Monday. A written triple box can be Wednesday.
- 5. Exit ticket (2–4 min).** “I claim ____ because [named source] shows.” **At 13–14, add “A limitation is .”** Date the page. File under **History** or **Social Studies**.

Exact wording you can say:

- “What do you claim — and which named source shows it?”
- “Where is the claim in your sentence?”
- “Point to the evidence in the piece.”
- “What can’t this source tell us?”
- “Whose turn to add one idea tied to a line?”
- “You may revise the claim without erasing the look.”
- “Because the line says...”
- “I do not need a pretty paragraph. I need a named source.”

First try-it for the student. After the source card and a short look, ask the locked opening. Wait. Every claim must point to a starred line. That is TALK-02, Because the Line. If they are new to writing a claim, let the first sitting stay oral. WRITE-01, Source Sentence First, can be tomorrow.

How to fade help. You model one claim sentence *after* they have tried, or you write yours on a card they see only if they are stuck after a real attempt. Then a frame: “I claim ____ because [name] shows ____.” Then the frame goes away. Stop

talking when they are mid-sentence. Do not finish it for them.

When to stop talking. After you ask. After they answer, wait again before you evaluate. If they are hunting the sentence they think you want, say so: “I do not have a hidden claim. I want one you can show from this piece.” If they jump to a summary, return to the source card.

Age-band moves

11–12. One sentence. Maybe one quote scrap. Caption-to-paragraph ladder if an image is the piece: one-sentence caption, then a because-sentence, then four or five lines. Oral exit is honest. Adult holds the account if a tool is used at all; no live open chat as partner.

13–14. Short paragraph with a limitation. Two-source paragraph when corroboration from Chapter 3 is stable. Disagreement soft on paper: no winner required. Still unaided first. Still no unsupervised companion. Revision questions after a draft — not a rewrite to an A.

Place by skill, not birthday. If a fourteen-year-old still writes a summary with no maker, stay on WRITE-01. If a twelve-year-old already names a limit and asks what a third piece would need, grow WRITE-04.

A sample week (illustration, not a calendar)

Labelled hypothetical. Focus move: claim + named source.

- Monday: TALK-01 Three-Second Source (wait practice) + TALK-02 Because the Line.
- Tuesday: WRITE-01 Source Sentence First.
- Wednesday: WRITE-02 Claim / Evidence / Limit, or WRITE-06 Caption to Paragraph Ladder.
- Thursday: OUT-01 Library Primary Hunt ending in one claim sentence on a dated card — or museum one object → a spoken claim that could only come from *this* object.
- Friday: WRITE-05 one revision target (evidence only); diagnostic (claim with no source, or chatbot smoothness) repaired; done-enough checklist.

A second week might focus TALK-05 Two Questions Only. A third, WRITE-04 Two-Source Paragraph. Do not assign every talk and write try-it in one week.

Practice that actually builds learning

Named try-its carry **time, materials, safety, the fun, the skill**. Pick one talk-heavy sitting and one write-heavy sitting this week, plus one outing if you can. Shared looking and kitchen talk motivate. They do not replace the sourced claim.

Safety is ordinary: roads; aisle courtesies; museum hands-off; no lecture to a stranger's child; no cold public quiz; no photographing strangers without care. A library hunt is research and a claim, not a checkout binge.

In-home try-its — talk

TALK-01 Three-Second Source - Time: 10–15 minutes. - **Materials:** Source card only; the piece's credit line visible; body covered if you need the habit. - **Safety:** None special. Do not turn the count into a mock. - **The fun:** The small dare of not rushing. - **The skill:** Wait after an attribution question; the learner speaks first. - **Steps:** Ask one attribution question. Count three (aloud if you must). Do not fill. Learner states one attribution fact. - **Error pattern:** Answering your own question at second one. - **Exit ticket:** One attribution fact after a real wait.

TALK-02 Because the Line - Time: 15–25 minutes. - **Materials:** Excerpt; pencil for stars. - **Safety:** None special. - **The fun:** Being able to point and win the sentence. - **The skill:** Every claim points to a starred line. - **Steps:** Locked opening. "Because the piece says..." Star the phrase. If the claim floats, send them back to the paper. - **Error pattern:** Vibes-only claims. - **Exit ticket:** Claim + starred line number or phrase.

TALK-03 Sibling / Partner Uptake - Time: 15–25 minutes. - **Materials:** Two learners, or you as partner; the same excerpt. - **Safety:** No debate-as-combat. No talking over. Soft tone. - **The fun:** Building on someone else's look without stealing it. - **The skill:** Post-response wait; uptake tied to the text. - **Steps:** After one claim, wait. "Add one idea to what ___ said, tied to the text." Hear one uptake sentence. - **Error pattern:** Combat; a second speech that ignores the first. - **Exit ticket:** One uptake sentence heard.

TALK-05 Two Questions Only - Time: 15–20 minutes. - **Materials:** Two question cards you wrote in the warm-up; the piece. - **Safety:** None special. - **The fun:** Noticing how much talk appears when you stop quizzing. - **The skill:** Authentic questions, not a recitation flood. - **Steps:** You ask only two questions in the hour. The rest is wait and uptake. At the end, the learner names the better question and

why. - **Error pattern:** Quiz barrage dressed as discussion. - **Exit ticket:** “The better question was ____ because ____.”

TALK-06 Learner Asks - Time: 15–25 minutes. - **Materials:** Sticky notes; the piece. - **Safety:** None special. - **The fun:** Being the person who sets tomorrow’s hunt. - **The skill:** Questions the *source* raises; one realistic next source type (Library of Congress “what more do you want to know / how would you find out?” grain).²² - **Steps:** Learner writes two questions the piece raises. Pick one for a later hour. Not “google until true.” Not “ask the window.” - **Error pattern:** Questions that ignore the source entirely. - **Exit ticket:** One investigation question kept.

TALK-07 Accountable Three Soft - Time: 15–20 minutes. - **Materials:** A small checklist card: community / knowledge / reason. - **Safety:** Do not turn the card into a grade sheet. - **The fun:** Ticking three boxes with real examples, then putting the card away. - **The skill:** Talk that takes turns, points at the piece, and gives a reason. - **Steps:** After a short talk, name one example for each box. Then stop. Craft, not a score. - **Error pattern:** Rubric theater. - **Exit ticket:** Three boxes ticked with examples.

TALK-04 (Strange Past Soft) lives in Chapter 4 as a their-world talk. If presentism walks into a claim week, run that prompt once and return to the claim. Do not let a sermon replace the starred line.

In-home try-its — write

WRITE-01 Source Sentence First - Time: 20–30 minutes. - **Materials:** Lined paper; excerpt. - **Safety:** None special. - **The fun:** A three-sentence page that already looks like a real notebook. - **The skill:** Name the source before the claim; then one support. - **Steps:** Sentence 1 names writer, date, type. Sentence 2 is the claim. Sentence 3 quotes or paraphrases support. - **Error pattern:** Summary with no source; quote dump. - **Exit ticket:** Three-sentence page.

WRITE-02 Claim / Evidence / Limit - Time: 25–40 minutes. - **Materials:** A triple-box organizer you drew; excerpt. - **Safety:** None special. - **The fun:** The third box — permission to say what the piece cannot do. - **The skill:** A claim that does not overreach one excerpt. - **Steps:** Claim. Evidence (starred). Limit (“this

²²Library of Congress, Teaching with Primary Sources, Getting Started / analysis tool: observe, reflect, question; what more do you want to know, and how might you find out. Opened for this book’s research 13 September 2026.

source cannot tell us...”). - **Error pattern:** Overclaim from one excerpt. - **Exit ticket:** Completed triple box.

WRITE-04 Two-Source Paragraph (*13–14; stretch 11–12 if the floor is honest*) - **Time:** 30–45 minutes. - **Materials:** Two short excerpts already sourced (Chapter 3 grain). - **Safety:** Low-heat event. No culture-war pair as the default. - **The fun:** Making the two names visible in one short paragraph. - **The skill:** Both sources used, both named, one difference noted. - **Steps:** One paragraph. Not two stacked summaries. Not DBQ length. - **Error pattern:** Parallel summaries with no relation; a packet of documents. - **Exit ticket:** Paragraph with two source names visible.

WRITE-05 Revision Target: Evidence - **Time:** 25–40 minutes. - **Materials:** Yesterday’s draft; a different-color pencil. - **Safety:** None special. No red-pen everything. - **The fun:** One job only — the sentence gets stronger without a rewrite-to-pretty. - **The skill:** Revision as a better tie to the piece, or a clearer source name. - **Steps:** One target. Before/after the evidence sentence. Neatness is not the target. Grammar belongs to the English hour unless a sentence is unreadable. - **Error pattern:** Fix-everything; neatness-as-revision. - **Exit ticket:** Before/after evidence sentence.

WRITE-06 Caption to Paragraph Ladder (*especially 11–12*) - **Time:** 20–30 minutes. - **Materials:** Image with credit line; lined paper. - **Safety:** No generated “period scene” filed as a primary. Honesty card on reproductions. - **The fun:** Watching one caption grow without jumping to an essay. - **The skill:** Control at each stage. - **Steps:** Caption (1 sentence) → because-caption (2) → short paragraph (4–5). - **Error pattern:** Skipping to essay with no caption control. - **Exit ticket:** Ladder three stages shown.

WRITE-07 Disagreement Soft on Paper - **Time:** 25–40 minutes. - **Materials:** Two short accounts of one small event. - **Safety:** Soft event. No villain hunt. - **The fun:** Not having to crown a winner. - **The skill:** Accounts can emphasize different things and still both be useful. - **Steps:** Write “A emphasizes ; B emphasizes ; I still need ____.” - **Error pattern:** Forced pick-the-good-guys ending. - **Exit ticket:** That three-clause sentence.

WRITE-03 (Civic Clause Paraphrase) lives in Chapter 5. If this week’s piece is a civic line, paraphrase without a rant, then one sentence on then-audience, then return to the claim frame. The civic text is still a source.

Out-of-home try-its

OUT-01 Library Primary Hunt → **one claim sentence** - **Time:** 30–45 minutes.
 - **Materials:** Library card; adult; a dated index card. - **Safety:** Aisle courtesy. No photographing other patrons. No ten-book coverage itch. - **The fun:** Finding one photo book or local-history item *you* chose, then writing a sentence only that item can support. - **The skill:** Source at a table; claim on a dated card. - **Steps:** Find one item. Source card. Write: “I claim ____ because [title / maker] shows ____.” Photo of *notes*, not of people. - **Error pattern:** Checking out a pile and writing nothing; treating a children’s encyclopedia blurb as the primary. - **Exit ticket:** Dated card with named source + claim.

Museum one object → **spoken claim** - **Time:** 30–45 minutes. - **Materials:** One object; notebook; adult. - **Safety:** Hands off. No racing rooms. No photographing visitors. - **The fun:** A sentence that would fail if you had stayed in the gift shop. - **The skill:** A claim that could only come from looking at *this* object; then the placard; who wrote the placard? - **Steps:** Observe before the placard. Then read it. Spoken claim at the object. Write it on a bench or at home. - **Error pattern:** Placard-only looking; a claim that fits any object in the room. - **Exit ticket:** Object + claim that points + placard author if known.

A library or museum hour motivates. It does not replace the because-the-line move. If you are homebound this week, OUT-04 (archive screen with an adult) can supply one credited item and the same dated-card exit. Parent-mediated at 11–12; co-held at 13–14.

Talk box

Opening (locked): “What do you claim — and which named source shows it?”

Follow-ups (use three to five):

1. Observe: “What do you *see* or *read* that you might claim from?”
2. Maker: “Who made this, and for whom — is that in your sentence yet?”
3. Reason tied to the piece: “Point to the evidence in the piece. Because which line?”
4. Check or alternative: “What can’t this source tell us? Which question is this account answering?”
5. Revise / uptake: “You may revise the claim without erasing the look. Whose turn to add one idea tied to a line?”

How to wait. After you ask, a slow three. After they stop, wait again. If they are mid-claim, do not cut them off. Look at the piece, not at the adolescent, if the silence is hard. Classroom wait-time is labelled science-class and discussion-craft origin. Borrow the pause.²³

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague (“so what do you think?”). Wait-time was zero. They are hunting the answer they think you want. The piece never landed. They offered a summary-only guess. They think history means repeating your story. Archaic prose needs a scaffold before talk. Your job is to pose, wait, and point at the sourced line — not to fill the silence with your paragraph, and not to turn the table into a fight.

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked (new move). One piece. TALK-02 or WRITE-01 only. No second source. No “now write a five-paragraph essay because we talked so well.”

Mixed (when the sentence is stable). Pair TALK-02 with WRITE-02. Pair WRITE-04 with Chapter 3’s two voices. Pair TALK-06 with a Thursday library hunt that tries to answer the student’s own question.

One incorrect example to diagnose (illustration)

Labelled illustration, not a reported family. The exit ticket is a smooth paragraph: “Life in the colony was difficult but hopeful, as people sought freedom and built communities.” No maker. No date. No line. A window could have written it. The parent praises voice.

Repair. Close the window if it was open. Put the credited notice or letter down. Ask the locked opening. Wait. Require a name in sentence 1. Star a line. Add one limit. Keep any vivid word that still points. File the smooth paragraph as a later telling, not as the student’s look.

Other misses this month: source named, no claim (ask for the *about-the-past* sentence); disagreement as combat (WRITE-07 frame); quote dump (three-sentence cap); parent-filled silence (TALK-01 tomorrow).

²³Mary Budd Rowe, wait-time in elementary *science* (1972 tradition). Robert J. Stahl, “Using ‘Think-Time’ and ‘Wait-Time’ Skillfully in the Classroom” (ERIC Digest, 1994). Borrow the pause.

For the student

A claim is a sentence about the past that you can show. A named source is the person or piece that lets someone else check you. Your job today is one sentence that does both. You may talk it first. Then you may write it.

What this idea is. Looking becomes history when you say what you think *and* point. “I claim the ferry ran that morning because this notice, printed that week, lists the times.” That sentence can be argued with. “People liked boats” cannot. A limit is allowed: “This notice cannot tell us whether anyone missed the boat.” Limits make you more careful, not weaker.

Tiny worked example (illustration). You have a short shop notice: maker, date, hours. You write:

1. This shop notice, dated that Monday, lists opening hours.
2. I claim the shop was not open in the evening, because the notice ends in the afternoon.
3. This notice cannot tell us whether the owner changed the hours later that week.

Three sentences. A name. A claim. A limit. That is enough.

Try 1. On this week’s piece, write or say: “I claim ____ because [source name / maker] shows ____.” Star the line.

Try 2. Add one limit: “This source cannot tell us .” *If you have two short accounts, try: “A emphasizes ; B emphasizes ; I still need .”*

Explain it back. Tell someone at the table the difference between a claim that points and a summary that could fit any week.

Challenge. If you are ready: write a short paragraph that names two sources and one difference. Or take a library or museum hour and come home with a dated card that could only have been written after looking at *that* item. You may revise tomorrow for a stronger evidence tie — not to make the page prettier.

You may change your mind when you look. You may write “I don’t know yet.” You do not have to sound like a textbook. You do not have to let a window write the blanks.

If it isn't clicking

Three diagnostics. No shame. Correct a wrong reason without crushing the look.

1. Summary-first or vibe-only. Symptom: a fluent story or a feeling, and no maker. Next move: cover the body; TALK-01; then WRITE-01 with sentence 1 forced as the source sentence. If they cannot yet hold a written sentence, stay oral for a week. Oral is honest at 11–12.

2. Chatbot smoothness or parent-filled silence. Symptom: the page does not sound like the student; or you hear your own paragraph coming back to you. Next move: closed-window sitting. TALK-01 for *you* as much as for them. WRITE-05 on a draft they actually wrote — one evidence target. If a tool was the partner during the attempt, that sitting does not count as their claim. Try again.

3. Quote dump, overclaim, or combat. Symptom: copied lines with no sentence; a claim bigger than the excerpt; two accounts turned into a villain. Next move: three-sentence cap (WRITE-01); triple box (WRITE-02); or WRITE-07's three-clause frame. If archaic prose is the blocker, you read a line — that is access — then they still make the claim.

When to slow down. They cannot yet name maker/date/type before a claim. Return to Chapters 1–2 for a few sittings. A claim week on top of an unsourced piece trains the wrong habit.

When to go ahead. The three-sentence page holds after a night. They can show the claim two ways — spoken and written — on a fresh short piece. Then limitation, two-source paragraph, or a library-card exit is fair.

When to get a human tutor. Writing itself is the wall — forming sentences, holding a pencil through four lines — and an English-hour teacher or occupational support would help access. Point once to *English for Young Minds* for craft; then return. This chapter will not become a grammar book. If argument about founding texts is the real aim, point once to *Publius* or to the older civics chapter in *History for Homeschooling*, then return to one sourced claim.

Hearing a wrong reason, then asking a better question, then naming a better move, is teaching. “Never correct the adolescent” is not this book's rule. A scolding lecture about honesty is not teaching either.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers for you. The History Hour chapter already holds the full AI box. Point back.

You may, on *your* account, after they have tried — or before, for your prep — ask a tool to explain this week’s claim idea from a *named* lesson or credited primary; to make extra claim frames with a **parent key** the student never sees; to give you a **SCRIPT** of questions to say after they draft; to offer *revision questions* after a real draft (not a rewrite); to hint with a question or a named idea, not a finished essay; or to diagnose a cropped photo of the page. You hear the diagnosis. You talk to the student.

You may not ask the tool to write the student’s paragraph or “fix this to an A.” You may not generate a diary, letter, or speech as if it were a real primary. You may not put a model summary on the table as the source. You may not park an unsupervised chatbot as the only partner — not at 11, not at 14. You may not detector-grade a claim. Detectors fail often enough that a score is not honesty.²⁴ Fabricated citations are a parent-side risk; if you asked a tool for a paper on primary sources, open the Library of Congress Teaching with Primary Sources page or the C3 Framework PDF instead.²⁵

At 11–12 you hold the account. At 13–14 you co-hold and stay in the room. Turning 13 is not a licence. The student may sit next to you while you use a tool. They may hear revision questions after they have drafted. They may type their own “I claim ____ because [named source] says . **A limitation is** .” The blanks are theirs. A model that fills the blanks is still the crutch.

The same off-age caution as in the History Hour: a high-school math trial showed unguarded chat helping practice and hurting the closed-window test.²⁶ The kitchen rule: the model may prepare you; it may not write the claim when the claim is the lesson.

Paper tools that earn their keep: star pencils; triple boxes; dated index cards; a

²⁴Weixin Liang et al., “GPT Detectors Are Biased Against Non-Native English Writers,” arXiv:2304.02819 (2023). Do not detector-grade a student’s “According to this letter....”

²⁵William H. Walters and Esther Isabelle Wilder, “Fabricated citations in academic papers,” *Scientometrics* (2023). Parent-side: open the C3 PDF or the LOC page instead of trusting a fluent bibliography.

²⁶Hamsa Bastani et al., “Generative AI Can Harm Learning,” *PNAS* (2025). High-school math; off-age for this history band. One crutch sentence.

two-source T-chart; the Accountable Three card used once and put away. A voice-to-text accommodation is access if writing motor work is the wall — labelled, you in the room — while they still choose the claim and the line. Audio that replaces looking at today's piece is a substitute, not an accommodation.

What “done enough” looks like

Not a perfect paragraph. Not an A. Not a diploma.

This week's checklist (place by skill, not birthday)

- ☐ The student can say or write a claim that names a source and points at a line.
- ☐ Attribution happened before the claim.
- ☐ At 13–14, or when ready, one limitation sentence is present.
- ☐ One talk try-it and one write try-it happened; one outing or a homebound archive-screen equivalent if you can.
- ☐ One revision targeted evidence, not polish.
- ☐ The page lives in the dated notebook under **History** or **Social Studies** — never a brand, never Young Minds History I.
- ☐ You heard one wrong turn (no source, no claim, chatbot smoothness, combat, your own paragraph) and asked a better question.

Band exits

- 11–12: “I claim ____ because [source name / maker] shows ____.” One sentence. Maybe one quote scrap. Oral counts.
- 13–14: Short paragraph: claim; evidence with attribution; one limitation or a second account acknowledged lightly. Still not AP.

Life of the habit (not a ninth chapter). Revisit next Tuesday: read last week's claim aloud and ask whether the star still holds. Mix last week's two accounts if you have them. Stop while a look remains. A path through middle-grades history looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A percentile is not.

When to move on. The three-sentence page holds after a night. They can show the same skill two ways — spoken and written, or two different pieces. If they only repeat your model sentence, the piece was decoration. Rerun with your model in your pocket and their pencil on a fresh line.

A “grade 7 social studies workbook” essay prompt is a publisher's scope, not a

legal grade, and not a transcript line. Several short written arguments across a term, saved, are enough for an honest sample. That is not a national minutes study. Chapter 8 turns these exits into kitchen checks you can reuse. Chapter 9 files them where a stranger can read the title.

Chapter 8

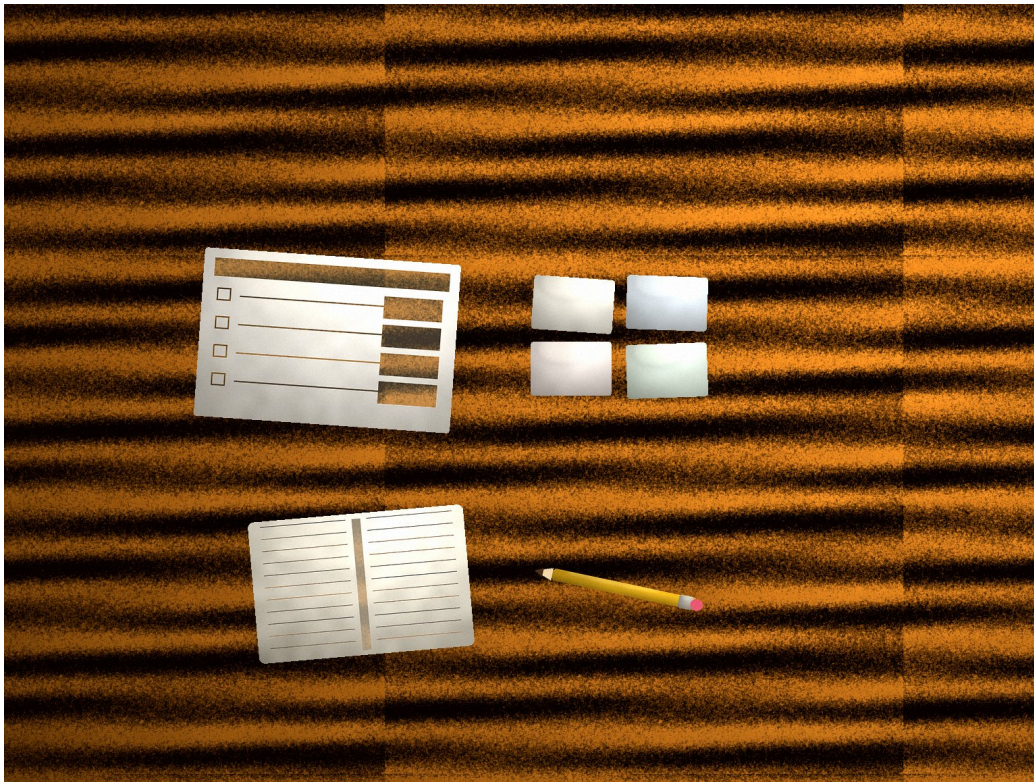


Figure 10: Four plain kitchen skill cards — source a claim, corroborate, short argument, done-enough — beside a dated notebook and a simple three-skill progress chart with no percentages. Still-life. No people. No brand logos.

Short assessments and progress checks

Why this matters

What can you show me two ways today — and what still needs practice?

That question is the spirit of kitchen assessment for ages 11–14. Assessment here means a dated notebook, a claim that names a source, two short accounts set beside each other, a short written argument, an exit ticket, one explained miss, and a done-enough checklist by skill. It does not mean a percentile as a personality. It does not mean NAEP. It does not mean a homemade high-stakes battery. It does not mean “not a history kid.”

Families need two truths at once. First: every History Hour already assesses. The source card, the starred line, the sticker-plus-reason, the three-sentence claim — those are information. Second: a dedicated Friday rhythm keeps the week honest when hope, coverage itch, or a publisher’s quiz would skip the look. Screening a skill is a teaching signal. It is not an identity. Formal evaluation, when a family seeks it for reading or writing access, is a different column. Kitchen checks decide Tuesday’s piece.

Wineburg reviewed a century of “kids don’t know history” stories built on fact tests. Light tours leave few traces; more encyclopedia hours are the usual panic, and they still leave few traces.²⁷ This chapter will not panic you into a binder of years. National Assessment scores for grade-8 U.S. History exist for schools. They are not a twelve-year-old’s census, and the federal statistical agency has never published a nationally representative *homeschool* U.S. History NAEP score.²⁸ Passing or missing a state’s reading-and-math sitting does not prove a history year worked. A publisher’s review booklet checks recall inside a scope. It does not license a national percentile.

What this idea unlocks is calm evidence you can hold in a notebook a stranger could read: they can source before the body; they can point to a line; they can say

²⁷Sam Wineburg, “Crazy for History,” *Journal of American History* 90, no. 4 (2004): 1401–1414. Fact-test jeremiads are old; light coverage leaves few traces. Access date for this book’s research: 13 September 2026.

²⁸National Assessment of Educational Progress grade-8 U.S. History and civics highlights are school-population scores (sister-stream 2022 figures). NAEP Proficient is not a grade-level pass/fail. NCES has not published a nationally representative homeschool U.S. History NAEP score.

what matches across two accounts; they can write a short argument that names a source. You will know what to reteach Tuesday. You will know when a skill holds after a night. You will know when to grow from a sentence to a paragraph — by skill, not birthday.

You do not need to be a psychometrician. You need a dated notebook, a pencil, three kitchen objects you can rotate, and the locked question.

This week you can learn to run one diagnostic wrong explained and a done-enough checklist on Friday. Today the student can show the same skill two ways — oral and written, or two different pieces — and name one thing still in practice.

Picture two Fridays. In one, a printout of a score sits on the fridge and no one can say what the student can *do* with a fresh letter. In the other, a chart with three skill names — source, corroborate, claim — has a date and a note: “holds on a new piece; limitation still shaky.” Both rooms feel like they measured something. Only one told you what to put on the table next week.

For the parent: understand it yourself

Many adults remember assessment as a secret test, a red number, and a hallway conversation. Others remember no checks at all — only “we finished the chapter.” For a History Hour, assessment is frequent, short, kind, and useful. Five to eight minutes of this section, then the warm-up, is enough for Friday. The student still shows the skill.

Everyday picture. Friday, about twenty minutes inside a History Hour. You put a *fresh* short excerpt on the table — not Monday’s. Source card (4 minutes). One oral claim that points (3 minutes). The same claim in three written sentences (6 minutes). You ask what still needs practice (2 minutes). You tick two done-enough boxes and write Tuesday’s hold (2 minutes). The student leaves knowing what worked. You leave knowing whether the skill transferred.

Precise picture — three columns

Kitchen check	Optional program review	State or clinic sitting
What to teach Tuesday	Recall and listening inside a purchased scope	Compliance or documentation in <i>that</i> lane

Kitchen check	Optional program review	State or clinic sitting
Source a claim; corroborate two sources; short written argument; exit tickets	Chapter questions, pretests, quizzes when you already use that program	Reading/math portfolios, commercial batteries, evaluations — not a history NAEP
Parent-run; skill-based; screening $\neq$ identity	Not a national percentile; not a kitchen trial	Not replaced by this book; not a proof the history year “worked”

Keep the columns separate until they stick.

Three kitchen objects (rotate; one Friday can hold two if you stay short)

1. **Source a claim.** Cover, caption, letterhead. Who made this, when, and why — “I don’t know yet” allowed. Then one claim that points. Write it.
2. **Corroborate two sources.** Two short texts, or a text and an object. Where they agree, where they differ, what that does to the claim. First move is not “one is lying.”
3. **Short written argument.** A dated paragraph — at 13–14, toward a page or two — with evidence from the sources. Not a five-chapter thesis. Not a timed Advanced Placement essay.

Add crumbs: daily exit tickets (2–4 minutes); one diagnostic wrong explained each Friday; AS-04 Further Investigation Mini as a retest after a night; a progress chart with skill names, not percentages.

A 2016 parent survey found social science, history, or social studies taught that year to 82 percent of homeschooled sixth-through-eighth-graders.²⁹ You are not inventing a subject. You are checking the looking move inside a subject most families already name. There is no national study of daily homeschool history minutes. Do not write one into your notebook. Regular narrative or document work, a map habit most weeks, and several short written arguments across a term are an honest dose.

No state in the five-state grain this book uses requires a course titled Young Minds

²⁹Meghan McQuiggan, Mahi Megra, and Sarah Grady, *Parent and Family Involvement in Education: Results from the National Household Education Surveys Program of 2016*, NCES 2017-102, Table 9, grades 6–8: social science/history/social studies 82 percent. Geography as a separately ticked line: 41 percent.

History I. Texas’s leading case names reading, spelling, grammar, math, and good citizenship — not the word history. North Carolina’s test list is English grammar, reading, spelling, and mathematics — not history. Pennsylvania asks elementary homes for geography, U.S. and Pennsylvania history, and civics, and secondary homes for geography and social studies (civics, world history, U.S. and Pennsylvania history); the grade-8 portfolio tests are reading/language arts and mathematics, not history. Virginia lets the parent write the list. New York names geography and U.S. history in grades 1–6, and history and geography (two units) in grades 7–8.³⁰ None of that is legal advice. Read your own statute. File the kitchen work under **History** or **Social Studies** — World History, U.S. History, Geography, or Civics only when the work is actually that. Never a brand.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. *Birthday gate*. “You’re only eleven, so we don’t do documents” or “You’re thirteen, so you must do AP packets.” Repair: run the three objects at this week’s grain. Adjust length. Place by skill.
2. *Percentile identity*. “You’re a 40th-percentile history student.” Hear the mash. Translate to a skill: sourcing before the body is shaky; corroboration still jumps to a villain.
3. *NAEP panic*. A news story about grade-8 scores becomes an encyclopedia year. Repair: one piece, one question, one move. Fact tests are not the Hour.³¹
4. “*Not a history kid*.” A miss filed as a type of person. Repair: screening ≠ identity. Shorter sources. Clearer caption. One claim only. Retest after a night.
5. *Program quiz as the only measure*. The pretest booklet stands in for looking. Repair: keep the booklet if it helps recall. Add a sourced claim on a real piece the booklet never saw.

³⁰Five-state middle grain from opened statutes and rules (access date 13 September 2026): Texas *Leeper* subjects; North Carolina Division of Non-Public Education test list; 24 P.S. § 13-1327.1 (Pennsylvania); Va. Code § 22.1-254.1; 8 NYCRR 100.10 (New York). This paragraph is not legal advice.

³¹Sam Wineburg, “Crazy for History,” *Journal of American History* 90, no. 4 (2004): 1401–1414. Fact-test jeremiads are old; light coverage leaves few traces. Access date for this book’s research: 13 September 2026.

A sixth: *no checks* — *just the next lesson*. Hear abandoned transfer. A skill that only works on Monday's familiar letter is not done-enough.

Five-to-eight-minute parent warm-up

Do this alone, before Friday's sitting.

Minute 1. Open the dated notebook to a blank grid (templates below).

Minute 2. Pick one diagnostic wrong you actually expect this month: summary first; textbook-as-primary; one-must-be-lying; civic meme without a source card; model summary as the source.

Minute 3. Write the repair move in one sentence.

Minute 4. Practice the locked opening aloud.

Minute 5. Choose today's object: source-a-claim, corroborate, or short argument — or a two-ways pair (oral + written on the same skill).

Minute 6. Print or sketch a done-enough checklist with *skill names*, not percentages.

Minute 7. Choose a fresh piece. Transfer dies if Friday reuses Monday's letter with the answers still in the air.

Minute 8. Put the pencil down. You are ready. They show you two ways.

How to teach it this week

Assessment is not a separate subject titled Young Minds History I. It lives inside History / Social Studies as short probes. Friday often carries the longer sweep. Daily exit tickets stay tiny. The History Hour's five beats still hold. The "one try" is the check.

Band 11–12 weekly rhythm

- Daily: 2–4 minute exit ticket matched to the sit (sourcing sentence; sticker plus reason; one oral claim).
- Mid-week: one three-sentence WRITE-01 page *or* one two-account sticky (match / differ).
- Friday: one kitchen object on a *fresh* piece; one diagnostic wrong explained; done-enough checklist; note Tuesday's hold.

- Across a term: several short written arguments saved. Not a battery every Friday.

Band 13–14 weekly rhythm

- Daily exit may be a limitation sentence or a two-source note.
- Mid-week: corroboration on a new pair, or a paragraph draft.
- Friday: paragraph + limitation on a fresh piece *or* a transfer outing (library or museum with a new object and the same skill); diagnostic wrong; done-enough.
- Across a term: a one-to-two-page argument as a culminating sample, still sourced.

Exact wording you can say:

- “What can you show me two ways today — and what still needs practice?”
- “Wrong isn’t shame — wrong is information.”
- “Show me with your voice and with the pencil.”
- “Source this, then say the same claim on a new piece.”
- “Faced with two accounts, what’s your first move?”
- “We’re checking the skill, not naming your worth.”
- “You may write I don’t know yet.”

Age-band moves

11–12: Oral plus short written. Fresh piece still short. Adult scaffolds archaic lines, then they source and claim. Program review questions, if you use a purchased scope, sit *beside* the kitchen object — they do not replace it.

13–14: Paragraph plus limitation plus a transfer check outside the house when you can. Still not AP. Still not CLEP. College-level exams and high-school registrar export live in *History for Homeschooling*. One pointer, then return. SAT Subject Tests are discontinued; they are not a middle-grades plan.³²

Fade help. First you model how to explain a miss (“I started with the story instead of the credit line”). Then they explain with a frame. Then they classify the miss with the codebook below. Stop talking when they are mid-explanation.

When to stop talking. After the locked question. After they show the first way,

³²College Board discontinued SAT Subject Tests (announced January 2021; last international sitting June 2021). Out of band except this sentence. No CLEP as a middle-grades diploma; no AP as this band’s default.

wait before you ask for the second. If they perform a memory of Monday, put a new piece down. Do not turn Friday into a fight about a number.

A sample Friday (illustration, not a calendar)

Labelled hypothetical. Focus this month: source a claim.

- Exit ticket Monday–Thursday: one sourcing sentence each day on that day’s piece.
- Friday: fresh excerpt; locked opening; oral source-a-claim; same skill written in three sentences; student explains one miss if it appears; done-enough ticks; Tuesday note: “limitation still needs a box.”
- Optional Saturday or mid-week: AS-04 as retest — one question they still have, one realistic next source type.

A later Friday might hold corroboration on a new pair. Another might hold the short argument. Rotate. Do not run all three as a ceremony every week.

Practice that actually builds learning

The practice in this chapter is the check. Time, materials, safety, the fun, the skill still apply. Library and museum transfer checks are outings. They do not replace the looking move.

Safety is ordinary: roads; courtesy; hands off; no stranger quizzes; no photographing patrons; cemetery soft only with family consent if you ever use that outing as a transfer (optional, 13–14).

Object 1 — Source a claim

Time: 10–20 minutes. **Band:** both (oral-heavy at 11–12; written at both).

Materials: A fresh credited excerpt or image; cover sheet or paper to hide the body; notebook grid.

Safety: No generated diary as the “fresh piece.” Honesty card on reproductions.

The fun: Being able to say “I don’t know yet” and still pass the check.

The skill: Who / when / why before the body; then one claim that points.

Blank template

Date	Piece (title / maker)	Who / when / type	Why / for whom (or unknown)	Claim that points	Limit or “not yet”

Steps: Cover the body. Student says or writes attribution. Uncover. One claim that could only come from this piece. Star the line. Optional limit.

Error patterns: Summary first; textbook-as-primary (“the book just says the facts”); model summary on the table as the source.

Two ways: oral attribution + written claim; or the same skill on two different pieces.

Exit crumb: Grid row dated. Tuesday reteach = whichever cell was blank or invented.

Object 2 — Corroborate two sources

Time: 15–25 minutes. **Band:** both (very short pair at 11–12).

Materials: Two short accounts of one small, low-heat event; two sticky notes.

Safety: No culture-war pair as the default. No “one must be lying” as your first question.

The fun: Finding a match that is actually on both pages.

The skill: Match / differ / which question each answers; what that does to the claim.

Blank template

					Question A an- swers	Question B an- swers	What this does to my claim
Date	Source A	Source B	Matches	Differs			

Steps: Source both. Star matches. List differs. Name each account’s question. (13–14) say what a third piece would need to show.

Error patterns: Villain hunt; merging without attribution; forcing both to answer everything.

Two ways: stickies + spoken; or the grid + a three-clause sentence (WRITE-07).

Exit crumb: “First move on two accounts: find matches, not a liar.”

Object 3 — Short written argument

Time: 20–40 minutes. **Band:** 11–12 as three to six sentences; 13–14 as a paragraph toward a page.

Materials: One or two already-sourced pieces; dated paper.

Safety: Closed window during the attempt. You in the room.

The fun: A page that looks like a real notebook, with names a stranger can find.

The skill: A claim about the past with evidence from the sources; one limitation at 13–14.

Blank frame

1. Sources: [names, dates, types].
2. I claim:
3. Evidence (starred):
4. A second source does this to the claim:

5. A limitation is:

Steps: Unaided first. Then, if needed, one revision target on evidence (WRITE-05). Do not rewrite to an A.

Error patterns: Chatbot claim; quote dump; overclaim; a summary that could fit any week.

Two ways: spoken walk-through of the frame + the written page; or the same frame on a library item later in the week.

Exit crumb: Dated sample saved. Several across a term beat a single “big essay.”

Exit-ticket shapes (from every bank — crumbs, not a second hour)

Use one line. Two to four minutes.

- **SRC / AS:** “Writer: ; **audience:** ; purpose guess: ____.”
- **DOC:** One Observe, one Reflect, one Question on stickies.
- **CORR:** Same / different / still wonder.
- **CTX:** One “their world” sentence.
- **CIV:** Then-word / now-word for one charged word; maker named.
- **MAP:** Sticker + “near ____ / far from us.”
- **TIME:** “The date helped because ____.”
- **TALK:** Claim + starred phrase.
- **WRITE:** Three-sentence page or triple box.
- **OUT:** Photo of *notes* + one claim sentence on a dated card.

Done-enough on a ticket is right, or wrong-with-a-reason you can use tomorrow — not a percentage.

Diagnostic wrongs (codebook)

Composite patterns. Not transcripts. Hear the miss. Repair once. Do not file as a type of child.

Hear this	Likely miss	Repair this week
Story before the credit line “The book just says the facts”	Summary first Textbook-as-primary	Cover the body; Chapter 1 opening; wait Primary beside the textbook; who made each?
Two accounts → a villain A slogan with no maker	One-must-be-lying Civic meme without source card	“Which question is each answering?” Honesty card; then-words; Chapter 5 opening
A fluent window paragraph on the table “Founder diary” in the folder “Too young / old enough for AP” “You’re not a history kid” Pretest booklet as the only Friday	Model summary as source Generated primary filed as real Birthday gate Percentile or identity mash Program quiz as sole measure	Remove it; credited piece; tool after the try Label fiction; replace with a credited excerpt This chapter’s objects; adjust grain Skill name + reteach; screening ≠ identity Keep booklet; add a kitchen object on a fresh piece
Silence, then your paragraph	Parent-filled check	Wait; oral first; they write the blanks

One incorrect example to diagnose, labelled illustration: a parent prints an “eighth-grade history pretest,” times it, and records 70 percent. The student cannot source a fresh letter on Monday. Repair: keep any recall the pretest revealed. Friday’s object is source-a-claim on a piece the pretest never showed. The notebook records the skill, not the percent, as the identity of the week.

AS-04 Further Investigation Mini — the retest

Time: 20–30 minutes. **Band:** both.

Materials: Yesterday’s or last week’s piece; the Library of Congress pair of ques-

tions — what more do you want to know, and how might you find out?³³

Safety: Next source type is realistic (another letter; a map; a plaque; a library shelf). Not “google until true.” Not “ask the window until it agrees.”

The fun: Being the person who designs Tuesday.

The skill: Transfer. A question that comes from the piece; a next source *kind*.

Steps: One question. One next source type. Optional: go find that type (library, archive screen with adult, or a second excerpt you already hold). Then run Object 1 or 2 on the new piece. That is the retest.

Error patterns: Infinite questions; AI as the next source without a label.

Exit ticket: Question + next source type + (if found) a new source-a-claim row.

Holds after a night. If Friday’s claim collapsed on Saturday’s fresh piece, the skill is not done-enough. That is information. It is not a failure of character.

Out-of-home transfer checks

Same skill, new object. That is the point.

Library hunt as transfer (OUT-01 grain). 30–45 minutes. Adult. One new photo book or local-history item. Source card at a table. Claim sentence on a dated card. No ten-book binge. No photos of patrons.

Museum one object as transfer (OUT-02 grain). 30–45 minutes. One object they have not already written about. Observe before the placard. Spoken claim that would fail in the next room. Who wrote the placard, if known.

Plaque / courthouse as transfer (OUT-03 / MAP-04 grain). 25–40 minutes. Public building. Who commissioned the plaque? Home-map sticky later. No trespassing. No filming people.

If you are homebound, an archive screen with an adult (OUT-04) is a fair transfer: narrow question, one saved item, source card, stable title or URL in the notebook. Parent holds the session at 11–12. Co-hold at 13–14.

³³Library of Congress, Teaching with Primary Sources analysis tool: further investigation — what more do you want to know, and how might you find out. Opened 13 September 2026.

Progress chart without percentile identity

Draw this once. Update with dates and short notes. Compare the student to yesterday's self.

Skill	First try (date + note)	After a night (date + note)	Two ways?	Still in practice
Source before the body			oral / written / new piece	
Point to a line				
Two accounts: match / differ				
first				
Claim names				
a source				
Name a limit				
Map / timeline as a tool				
Civic line as a document				

No percentages. No sibling column. No fridge ranking. A shaky cell becomes Tuesday's hold, not a label on the person.

Talk box

Opening (locked): "What can you show me two ways today — and what still needs practice?"

Follow-ups (use three to five):

1. Observe: "Can you source before the body on this *fresh* piece — what do you see on the credit line?"
2. Maker / how do you know: "Point to a line. How do you know from *this*?"
3. Two accounts: "Faced with two accounts, what's your first move?"
4. Civic check: "Faced with a civic clause, do you rant before sourcing — or do you fill a source card?"

5. Write / revise: “Can you write a three-sentence claim that names a source? You may change your mind. What still needs practice?”

How to wait. After you ask, a slow three. After they show the first way, wait before you evaluate. If they are mid-explanation of a miss, do not cut them off. Look at the piece, not at the adolescent, if the silence is hard. Wait-time research is science-class and discussion-craft in origin; borrow the pause.³⁴

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague (“so... how did you do?”). Wait-time was zero. They are hunting a score you have not named. The fresh piece never landed. They are performing Monday’s answer. They think a check means “repeat the parent’s story.” Archaic prose needs a scaffold before the check — access, not rescue of the skill. Your job is to pose, wait, and point at the sourced line — not to fill the silence with a grade, and not to turn Friday into a fight.

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked (new as a check). One object. One fresh piece. Source-a-claim alone. No second document “to make it official.”

Mixed (when one object holds). Oral + written on the same skill. Or kitchen object + transfer outing. Or Friday object + AS-04 as Saturday’s retest. Still one focus skill in the notebook line.

For the student

A check is a chance to show a skill two ways and to name what still needs practice. It is not a name for you. It is not a race with a sibling. It is not a number on the fridge.

What this idea is. You already do checks every time you cover a credit line, star a sentence, or write “I claim ____ because ____.” Friday just uses a *new* piece so we know the skill travels. “I don’t know yet” is an honest cell. Inventing a maker is not.

³⁴Mary Budd Rowe, wait-time in elementary *science* (1972 tradition); Robert J. Stahl, think-time / wait-time (1994). Borrow the pause. Do not mash as a kitchen history trial.

Tiny worked example (illustration). Friday’s piece is a short notice you have not seen. You cover the words. You say who made it, when, and what kind of text it is. You uncover. You claim one thing the notice can support, and you point. Then you write the same three sentences. If two notices sit side by side, your first move is “what matches,” not “who lied.” That is a good Friday.

Try 1. Show sourcing two ways on a fresh piece: say the credit line, then write the claim that points.

Try 2. After a night, look at a new pair *or* write one question you still have and one kind of source that might help (a map, another letter, a plaque). That is a retest, not a trick.

Explain it back. Tell someone at the table what “done enough” means for you this month — a skill you can show two ways that still works tomorrow — and one cell that is still in practice.

Challenge. If you are ready: write a short paragraph that names two sources and one limit, then try the same skill on a library or museum object you have not used yet. You may explain one miss without shame. Wrong is information.

You may change your mind when you look. You do not have to be “a history kid.” You do not have to beat a percentile. You do have to point.

If it isn’t clicking

Three diagnostics. No shame. A miss is a teaching signal.

1. The skill dies on a fresh piece. Symptom: Monday’s letter is fluent; Friday’s letter is a freeze or a guessed year. Next move: shorter piece; cover the body; Object 1 only. AS-04 after a night. If archaic prose is the wall, you read one sentence — access — then they still source. Slow down. Do not add a two-source paragraph to “catch up.”

2. Identity or score ate the check. Symptom: “not a history kid”; a pretest percent as the week’s name; sibling comparison; NAEP talk at the table. Next move: close the score page. Open the three-skill chart. Write one skill sentence: “Sourcing before the body is shaky.” Repair that cell. Screening $\neq$ identity. If a state sitting is due, keep it in its column. It is not this Hour.

3. The wrong first move is stable. Symptom: two accounts still produce a villain;

a civic line still produces a rant; a window still writes the claim. Next move: the matching codebook row. Chapter 3 opening for accounts. Chapter 5 source card for a civic line. Closed window and WRITE-01 for a chatbot claim. One Friday, one repair. Do not run a ceremony of all five wrongs.

When to slow down. Attribution before the body is not stable on 3 of 4 short trials. Stay in Chapters 1–2 with crumbs from this chapter. A fourteen-year-old can live here without apology. Birthday is not a gate the other direction either. A thirteenth birthday is not a reason to hand over Advanced Placement packets.

When to go ahead. They source before the body on a fresh piece, point to a line, take match/differ as the first move on two accounts, and write a three-sentence claim that names a source. The same skill holds after a night and shows two ways. Then limitation, a longer paragraph, or an outing transfer is fair.

When to get a human tutor. Reading or writing access is the wall across subjects, and a reading specialist or writing support would help the student *reach* the piece. This book does not diagnose dyslexia or anything else. Kitchen checks are not a clinic. If high-school exams, registrar language, or college-level tests are the real question, point once to *History for Homeschooling* and return. No CLEP as a middle-grades diploma. No AP as this band's default.

Hearing a wrong reason, then asking a better question, then naming a better move, is teaching. Silence in the face of “not a history kid” is not kindness. A lecture about grit is not teaching either.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers for you. The History Hour chapter already holds the full AI box. Point back.

You may, on *your* account, ask a tool to make extra blank grids and claim frames with a **parent key** you keep; to explain a named miss pattern *to you*; to give you a SCRIPT of Friday questions; or to diagnose a cropped photo of a page they already wrote. You hear the diagnosis. You decide.

You may not paste a packet and take the key. You may not let a window write the Friday paragraph. You may not generate a primary for the “fresh piece.” You may not put a model summary on the table as the check. You may not detector-grade the claim. You may not print a certificate of history. You may not park

an unsupervised chatbot as the only partner. At 11–12 you hold the account. At 13–14 you still co-hold and stay in the room.

The same off-age caution: a high-school math trial showed unguarded chat helping practice and hurting the closed-window test.³⁵ Friday is a closed-window sitting when the skill is the lesson.

Paper tools that earn their keep: the three templates above; the codebook; the skill chart; dated cards from outings; an optional program-review booklet kept in its column. A stopwatch is almost never useful here. Speed is not the skill.

What “done enough” looks like

Not a perfect Friday. Not a percentile. Not a diploma.

This week’s checklist (place by skill, not birthday)

- ☐ The student showed one skill two ways (oral + written, or two pieces, or kitchen + outing).
- ☐ The check used a *fresh* piece, or a transfer object, not only Monday’s answers.
- ☐ Attribution came before the body on the check piece.
- ☐ One diagnostic wrong was named and repaired, without an identity label.
- ☐ A done-enough box was ticked only if the skill held — or was left open with a Tuesday note.
- ☐ After a night, a crumb retest (AS-04 or a new one-line ticket) was planned or done.
- ☐ The notebook line is dated and filed under **History** or **Social Studies** — never a brand, never Young Minds History I.
- ☐ Optional program review, if used, sits in its own column.

Band exits

- 11–12: Oral + short written on source-a-claim. Two short sources with match/differ. A paragraph is a stretch, not a gate.
- 13–14: Paragraph + limitation + transfer on a new object. Two sources without you holding the answer. Still not AP.

³⁵Hamsa Bastani et al., “Generative AI Can Harm Learning,” *PNAS* (2025). High-school math; off-age for this history band.

Showable two ways, holds after a night. That is the house definition. A skill that only works while you nod is not done. A skill that only works on one familiar letter is not done. A skill that returns on Saturday, on a new notice, is done enough to grow.

Life of the habit (not a ninth chapter). Revisit next Tuesday: pull last Friday's grid and ask the same skill on a new crumb. Mix last week's two accounts if both still sit in the folder. Stop while a look remains. Keep the dated notebook inside History / Social Studies. Chapter 9 is the file a stranger can read. This chapter is the check that fills it.

When to move on from this chapter's *focus*. The three objects are usable on demand. You are not "done with assessment." You are fluent enough to run a Friday without a ceremony and without a panic. A publisher's "grade 7 social studies" test is a scope, not a legal grade, and not a transcript line. A path through middle-grades history looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A culture-war win is not. A percentile is not.

Chapter 9

Records

The history *work* can be as ordinary as a library biography and as serious as any classroom hour. The *credit* is a family claim until a stranger can use it — a receiving seventh-grade teacher, a Pennsylvania evaluator, a New York quarterly reader, a later high-school transcript the family will someday write. That stranger will not have sat at your table. They will have a page.

This chapter is how you make that page at ages 11–14. Lawful, honest, and readable to a stranger are three jobs. Keep them in view.

This week you can date one sourced claim and one short argument in a notebook so a stranger could almost read them. Today the student tries the page. You write the line, or they write the paragraph.



Figure 11: An open notebook titled History / Social Studies, a dated line with a sourced claim and a short paragraph, a pencil, a library postcard. No diploma seal. No grade. No brand. No adolescent.

What you are making

You are making a **dated notebook of History / Social Studies**, with the task named, plus a **sourced claim**, plus a **two-source corroboration**, plus a **short written argument**, plus optional publisher review questions when you use a purchased program. You are not making a national diploma. You are not making Young Minds History I.

There is often **no** middle-grades transcript. When a stranger asks, the title is **History** or **Social Studies**. World History, U.S. History, Geography, or Civics only when the work is actually that. Never a brand. Never Story of the World Volume 3. Never Beautiful Feet Early American 4–6. Never History Quest Middle Times.

Never Mystery of History Volume II. Never All American History. Never History Odyssey. Never DIG. Never **Young Minds History I**. The dated notebook, the sourced claim, the two-source corroboration, and the short written argument live *inside* History or Social Studies.

There is no federal homeschool diploma and no national history credit at this age.³⁶ Texas, North Carolina, and New York do not issue one. Pennsylvania’s supervisor or approved-organization diploma after listed graduation courses is a high-school object, not a twelve-year-old’s file. Virginia’s list of subjects is a list, not a transcript. A parent-issued diploma can be a real piece of paper later. It is not a registrar’s national history credit now.

Two readers, if anyone outside the kitchen asks. The **state**, in a thick jurisdiction: an IHIP, an affidavit, a portfolio — with history samples where the statute named history. A **later stranger**: a public school on transfer; a private school; a future high-school transcript. State compliance is not a history diploma. A thick Pennsylvania portfolio can be in statutory compliance with geography and social-studies samples and a grade 8 *reading/math* sitting. A silent Texas year can be lawful with no file at all, provided bona fide written reading, spelling, grammar, math, and good citizenship are happening. Neither fact is a reason to skip the past. Both facts are a reason not to fake a credit.

A family that invents “Young Minds History I, 1.0, A” for a twelve-year-old has created a slogan. A receiving teacher cannot map it. AP, CLEP, and college exams are the wrong object for this book. They belong to *History for Homeschooling*.

The national survey of homeschool subjects offered **social science, history, social studies** and **geography** checkboxes. In 2016, among grades 6–8-equivalent homeschoolers, social science, history, or social studies was taught that year to **82 percent**; geography to **41 percent**.³⁷ Informal learning does not arrive as “Social

³⁶No national homeschool diploma: Texas Education Agency Home Schooling and Alternative Schooling pages (state does not award a homeschool diploma); North Carolina DNPE (the home school issues any later diploma; the State does not); Pennsylvania 24 P.S. § 13-1327.1(d.1) diploma is a high-school object; New York 8 NYCRR 100.10 (home instruction does not yield a local or Regents diploma); Virginia list of subjects is a list, not a transcript. Access date for URLs in these notes: 13 September 2026.

³⁷Jiashan Cui and Rachel Hanson, *Homeschooling in the United States: Results from the 2012 and 2016 Parent and Family Involvement Survey*, NCES 2020-001, Table 9: grades 6–8 that year — social science, history, social studies **82 percent**; geography **41 percent**. Total K–12 for comparison: history/SS 78; geography 41. Quote those middle-grades rows. Do not paste elementary history 70 / 78 or geography 32 / 54 into a Young Minds sentence. Arithmetic, computer science,

Studies, 1.0, B+.” If a thick state later wants a log, the translation is: name the task, name the text or place, date it, keep a sample.

Titles a stranger can read

Print these and only these as middle-grades names, if a name is needed at all:

History / Social Studies. World History or **U.S. History** (only when the year’s work is that). **Geography** or **Civics** (only when the work is actually that). Reading / Language Arts / English. Mathematics / Arithmetic. Science. Art, Music, Physical Education.

Those names travel. They are the names public middle-school reports already use. They are the names homeschool files, when they exist, already follow.

Never a brand. Never Young Minds History I.

The brand, if used at all, sits in a parenthetical or in a description: “Social Studies (Story of the World Volume 3; library biographies; two DIG-style source lessons; museum visit notes).” Combining objects is allowed. Combining does not mint a new title. Library book plus one purchased lesson plus a museum note is still History or Social Studies.

A publisher’s “grade 7 social studies workbook” is a scope, not a legal grade, and not a transcript line. Placement is by skill, not birthday.

Here is an illustration, labelled as such, not a reported family:

13 September 2026. Sources: a short letter excerpt (credit line named) and a period map of the same year. Task: source a claim; corroborate two sources. Student: “The letter shows X because [named maker / date]; the map matches on place, differs on who is named. Claim paragraph: one page with one limitation.”

That is a record a parent, a Pennsylvania evaluator, or a New York quarterly narrative can actually use. It is not a credit. It is not NAEP. It is not a diploma. It is not a publisher placement test, though a publisher review sheet may sit in the same folder as a starting document.

basic reading, inquiry, and foreign-language percents from the same table are other subjects. The 2023 First Look (NCES 2024-113) did not republish subject-taught tables.

The law is a pattern, not one form

U.S. homeschooling is state law. There is no federal history office. Dates and subject lists change. Read your current department page and the statute it cites. Five official-page examples show the range. **None of them requires “Young Minds History I.”** History / social studies is sometimes named, sometimes left to the parent’s list, and sometimes neither named nor tested.³⁸ This chapter is not legal advice. The parent reads their own statute.

Texas. The Agency does not regulate home-school programs. Parents follow a bona fide written curriculum: reading, spelling, grammar, math, and a course in **good citizenship**. *Leeper*, restated on TEA’s Alternative Schooling page, does **not** name the word history. Good citizenship is the nearest TEA object; it is not a Government credit. The state does not award a homeschool diploma. The kitchen still benefits from a dated notebook if the family later transfers. Transfer is treated like an unaccredited private school. “We did Story of the World Volume 3” is not, by itself, a public-school credit. A district may test for placement. TEKS Chapter 113 is the public-school map, not a homeschool mandate.

North Carolina. Notice of Intent. Nine calendar months. Each year, a nationally standardized test in **English grammar, reading, spelling, and mathematics** — not history. The home school, not the State, issues any later diploma. A five-hour day is a recommendation, not the statute. DNPE tells the family not to name the homeschool after a curriculum brand. A looking notebook is extra. The annual battery is compliance — not this book’s kitchen check, not NAEP, and not a percentile promise.

Pennsylvania. Elementary **shall include geography; history of the United States and Pennsylvania; civics** (among other subjects). Secondary **shall**

³⁸Texas *Leeper*, restated on TEA Alternative Schooling: reading, spelling, grammar, math, good citizenship — history not named as a word. North Carolina DNPE: annual nationally standardized test includes English grammar, reading, spelling, and mathematics — not history; do not name the homeschool after a curriculum brand. Pennsylvania 24 P.S. § 13-1327.1: elementary shall include geography; history of the United States and Pennsylvania; civics; secondary shall include geography and social studies (civics, world history, history of the United States and Pennsylvania); portfolio tests in grades 3, 5, and 8 in reading/language arts and mathematics; 990 secondary hours. New York 8 NYCRR 100.10(e)(2): grades 1–6 require geography and United States history among other subjects; grades 7–8 require history and geography (two units) cumulative; a unit is 6,480 minutes; quarterly reports; annual assessment named tests or narrative. Virginia § 22.1-254.1: parent writes a list of subjects; evidence of progress. None of the five requires a named “Young Minds History I.” This chapter is not legal advice. The parent reads their own statute.

include geography and social studies, to include civics, world history, history of the United States and Pennsylvania. No “Young Minds History.” Many 11–14-year-olds sit on both sides of the elementary/secondary line — put the work under the statutory title that matches the child’s program level. Portfolio tests in grades 3, 5, and 8 are in **reading/language arts and mathematics**, not a history sitting. Drop geography and social-studies samples into the log. 900 hours elementary / **990** hours secondary are whole-program hours, not a history-minutes table. A supervisor diploma is Pennsylvania’s, and it is high school.

Virginia. Notice, a parent-written **list of subjects**, and evidence of progress: a composite score at or above the fourth stanine, or an equivalent SAT, ACT, or PSAT score, or an evaluation letter. History is not named as required because no subject is named as required; the parent writes the list. **History** or **Social Studies** is the ordinary word to write. Those sittings are not this book’s short check. A publisher history quiz does not, by itself, satisfy Virginia’s fourth-stanine object.

New York. Letter of intent, an Individualized Home Instruction Plan, quarterly reports, and an annual assessment. Grades 1–6 required subjects include **geography** and **United States history** among others. **Grades 7–8** require **history and geography (two units)** cumulative, plus English, science, mathematics, and **library skills on a regular basis**. A unit is 6,480 minutes. Put the work under those titles in the quarterlies. A library biography can be named under history; *Story of the World* is a **material**, not a required unit. Home instruction does not yield a local or Regents diploma. Annual assessment: named commercially published tests or, in some grades, a written narrative. Keep the IHIP subject line ordinary: **History** or **Social Studies**, or the named geography / United States history line when that matches the work.

If you live in none of those states, you still have a department page. Open it.

What a short check is

Five objects, not a battery.

1. **A dated notebook.** Date, task named, what the student read or saw, one sentence of what happened. Under **History** or **Social Studies** if a title is needed. Titles of books and sources actually opened belong in the log when a thick state wants materials listed.

2. **Source a claim.** Who made this, when, and for whom — from the credit line, cover, caption, or letterhead. “I don’t know yet” is allowed. Write it. Compare the claim to the piece on the table.
3. **Corroborate two sources.** Put two short texts, or a text and an object, next to each other. Say where they agree, where they differ, and what that does to the claim. Refuse “one must be lying” as the first move.
4. **A short written argument.** Continuous prose with a clear job — a claim about the past with evidence from named sources, and (at 13–14) one limitation. About a paragraph to a couple of pages for most of this band. Revised once when you can. Kept in the notebook. Not a five-chapter thesis. Not a blank page with no plan.
5. **Optional publisher review** (the organization sells the questions). Story of the World written review; History Quest study-guide prompts; Mystery of History pretest or quiz; All American History lesson review; History Odyssey discussion or writing — when you use that program. Use to check listening and recall inside a scope. IES does not certify them as randomised trials. They do not license a national percentile. They do not satisfy North Carolina unless the chosen test is a nationally standardized achievement battery covering English grammar, reading, spelling, *and* mathematics — a publisher history chapter quiz generally is not that battery.

A parent who feels rusty on names and dates can turn the check into a performance with a tight jaw. The useful move is still: date the work, keep one wrong turn you can reteach, and leave the looking in the student’s hands while they try.

Screening is not an identity label. A short check that finds a student cannot yet corroborate two sources, or invents a piece-from-then that belongs to a film, is a teaching signal. It is not “this adolescent is not a historian.” Reteach with shorter sources, a clearer caption, or one claim only. Do not file the miss as a permanent label.

Bands: **11–12** — written retell plus who/when/why; two short sources; a paragraph with one named source. **13–14** — more independent look; two sources without the adult holding the answer; a one-to-two-page argument with a limitation; a civic clause gently when ready. Fit across a sibling pair is allowed.

What a short check is not

NAEP. A percentile promise. A homemade high-stakes middle-school battery. Homeschooling was 3.4 percent of K–12 students in 2022–23 (~1.765 million); the 6th–8th cell was 3.0 percent. Instruction at home at 5.2 percent is a different bucket.³⁹ There is no nationally representative homeschool NAEP U.S. History score. A North Carolina annual battery and a Pennsylvania grade 8 sitting are compliance objects in reading and math, not a history percentile for this book. CLEP. AP. SAT Subject Tests — discontinued; U.S. sittings ended January 2021, last international administrations May and June 2021.⁴⁰ No CLEP for middle grades as a diploma. No AP as this band’s default check. Those objects belong to *History for Homeschooling*. This book does not reprint that fight.

Dual enrollment, AP, and credit-by-exam are not this chapter. Scores help a stranger believe a *high-school* transcript. They do not replace a dated sourced claim and a short argument at twelve. One pointer to *History for Homeschooling* for later NCAA, AP, and CLEP — then stop.

If they transfer

Transfer is a local placement problem. A brand in the title column will not be read as History or Social Studies. Another reason the title should already look like History or Social Studies.

A receiving teacher who sees “Young Minds History I, A” has been given a slogan. A teacher who sees “Social Studies — dated notebook; sourced claim from a named letter excerpt; two-source corroboration with a period map; one-page argument with one limitation” has been given a year they can place.

³⁹NCES 2024-113: 3.4 percent homeschooled in 2022–23, about 1,765,000; 6th–8th grade equivalent **3.0 percent**. Instruction-at-home 5.2 percent is a different bucket (homeschool or full-time virtual). NCES has never published a nationally representative homeschool NAEP U.S. History score. There is no opened national study of daily homeschool history minutes.

⁴⁰College Board, 19 January 2021 announcement: SAT Subject Tests discontinued; U.S. sittings ended immediately; last international administrations May and June 2021. No CLEP for middle grades as a diploma. No AP as this band’s default. Those objects belong to *History for Homeschooling*.

Place by skill, not birthday

Can the student name who made the piece before the body? If not, they are still in sourcing, whatever their age. Can they say what matches across two short accounts? If not, they are still in corroboration. Can they write a claim that points at a named source? If not, they are still before the short argument. Can they treat one civic clause as a document with a maker? If not, they are still before civic edges. High-sounding *titles* cannot skip those moves. Skill first. Publishers opened for this book say the same: choose by development, interest, and ability; grade stickers are not legal grades.

What to keep in the file

1. A dated notebook: date, task named, what the student read or saw, one wrong turn you will reteach. Under **History** or **Social Studies**.
2. Sourced claims from the week — a few honest pages, not every worksheet.
3. Two-source corroborations and short written arguments — samples across a term, not every draft.
4. Optional publisher review, if you used one — as a listening check, not as a yearly IQ.
5. State objects that actually apply: a Pennsylvania portfolio sample under geography, U.S. and Pennsylvania history, civics, or secondary social studies if you are in Pennsylvania; a New York quarterly under history and geography if you are in New York; a Virginia list that includes History or Social Studies if you write the list; a North Carolina annual battery in its own lane if you are in North Carolina. Compliance stays in its lane.

Life of the habit, as the file you keep, lives here: date the work; name the skill; keep one wrong turn you can reteach. Revisit next Tuesday is a move in Chapters 7 and 8. The notebook is how Tuesday leaves a trace.

A path through middle-grades history looking is the promise. A diploma is not. A percentile is not. A culture-war win is not.

For ages 5–10 retell, who-made-this, and then/now checks, see *History for Little Thinkers* — this book teaches the 11–14 History Hour. For grades 1–12 survey, transcript titles, and later AP/CLEP edges, see *History for Homeschooling*.

Chapter 10

Resources

This chapter names programs families actually meet. It does not rank them. It does not sell them. It is a fit list so you can match an object to the table you already have: how much of the teaching you will carry, whether a kitchen can use it tonight, what it costs in money and in minutes, and whether the adolescent will still look, source before the summary, and write a short claim from a named piece.

A “grade 7 social studies workbook” is a publisher’s scope, not a legal grade. Placement is by skill. The record, as Chapter 9 said, still says **History** or **Social Studies**. Combining two honest objects does not mint a new title. Library biography plus one purchased lesson plus a museum note is still Social Studies.

Independent trials of these programs *in homeschool* remain scarce. A chapter review quiz is not an IES-certified randomised trial. Choose by fit: parent load, style, age label, cost shape, and whether the student’s eyes stay on the credited piece and the student’s hand stays on the claim.

This week you can name *why* tonight’s object fits this student — usually a library book and a postcard before a catalog cart. Today the student tries that page. They are not on a shopping task.



Figure 12: A library card, a museum postcard, a generic book spine with the title unreadable, a lined notebook page and pencil. No logos. No portraits.

How to read a program

Four questions do the work.

Parent load. Are you hosting a shared read and written review? Managing many titles on the table? Letting a year-plan run with discussion at the end? Booking a museum Sunday?

Style. Narrative spine? Literature pack? Christian chronological timeline? Secular independent year-plan? Looking move with a document? Living books and written narration as a method?

Cost shape. Nothing tonight with a library card. A book you already own. A print set whose dollars change. Fees this book did not verify. Confirm a current price

on the page before you buy. This chapter omits list prices that were not locked for 2026.

Age label. An eleven-year-old may still need a shared spine and a short claim frame. A fourteen-year-old may still need taught looking before an independent year-plan. Birthday is a weak prior.

Reach numbers on an organization's page are that organization's copy, not a home-school census and not an effect size. Homeschooling was about 3.4 percent of U.S. school-age children in 2022–23 (~1.765 million); the 6th–8th cell was 3.0 percent.⁴¹ That is the pond. It is not a finding that most middle-grade homeschoolers use any one spine.

Library and museum — \$0 first

A public-library card. A young-adult, biography, or nonfiction history shelf. Research help. A museum, historical site, or local history room. That is tonight.

Fit. Parent load: presence and talk, not a script. Chronology: whatever the shelf and the exhibit offer — often thematic, not a four-year cycle. Looking: objects and labels in a gallery are natural who-made-this and two-source prompts. Placement: the student's interest and reading stamina, not a grade sticker. Cost shape: **\$0 first** with a card. Fines, holds, museum admission, and parking are local objects — this book does not invent a national free-museum guarantee.

In 2016, 61 percent of 6th–8th-equivalent homeschool households used the library as a source of curriculum and books. In 2022–23, 53 percent of the Homeschool-total row had visited a library in the past month, against 29 percent of all K–12; 43 percent had visited an art gallery, museum, or historical site, against 23 percent.⁴² Those are different questions in different years. Both are a free-or-low-cost hour. At ages 11–14 the free hour is research and argument, not storytime: take out a narrative or two short sources, name who made them, write a dated paragraph.

⁴¹NCES 2024-113: 3.4 percent homeschooled in 2022–23, about 1,765,000; 6th–8th grade equivalent 3.0 percent. Instruction-at-home 5.2 percent is a different bucket. Access date: 13 September 2026.

⁴²NCES 2020-001 Table 6: library as a source of curriculum and books, 61 percent at 6th–8th in 2016 (66 percent of all homeschool households). NCES 2024-113 Table A-5: Homeschool-total row, library visit past month 53 percent versus 29 percent of all K–12; art gallery / museum / historical site 43 percent versus 23 percent (2022–23). Different questions, different years — do not swap 53 for 61. Access date: 13 September 2026.

A gallery walk is not a transcript line by itself. It does not replace a chronological spine for a family that wants one. It is the honest starting inventory before a catalog purchase. Library and museum outings motivate. They do not replace the source-before-summary looking move.

Transcript. Not a course. Materials under History or Social Studies if a log is needed: “library biographies, titles listed; two-source notes; museum visit notes.” Never Young Minds History I. Never “Library Hour 1.”

The teaching chapters of this book are written for this object first. A purchased program is a fit, not a requirement.

Living books + written narration — method, not a brand

Reading a well-written history or biography, then asking the student to tell back — and write — what happened in their own words; then add who-made-this and a short claim. That is the method. It needs a library card and a blank page — \$0 beyond paper and whatever the library already holds.

Fit. Parent load: select a book, sit nearby, read the first written retell without rewriting it into adult prose. Chronology: whatever books you choose — can be thematic. Looking: weak unless you add source-a-claim and two-source work on purpose. Placement: length and difficulty track reading stamina, not a birthday. Pairs honestly with *Story of the World* reading lists, Beautiful Feet packs, or a naked library bag.

Living books plus written narration is a method. Put the work under History or Social Studies, not under a brand.

Transcript. Materials under History or Social Studies: “living books + written narration, titles listed.” Never “Charlotte Mason Year 6” as a fake credit unless the family’s whole program is being described in a narrative log — and even then the stranger-readable title remains History or Social Studies.

***The Story of the World* (Susan Wise Bauer; Well-Trained Mind Press)**

A four-volume narrative spine covering the sweep of human history — Ancient Times; The Middle Ages; Early Modern Times; The Modern Age — as the publisher describes it. Suitable for early and middle grades. The Activity Book turns each volume into a full-year curriculum in history and geography: map exercises, activities, projects, and reading lists. Designed primarily for **grades 1–4**; extendable for grades 5–8. “You need not use every assignment with every child.” Choose by age, development, interest, and ability. Elementary students answer review questions orally; **intermediate students can write** their answers. Library reading lists of “real books.”⁴³

Fit. Parent load: moderate if the adult still hosts maps and written review; lower if the 11–14-year-old reads independently and writes answers. Narrative spine, not a high-school textbook and not a document seminar. Not marketed as a Christian worldview curriculum on the pages opened for this book (the same press sells a separate *Telling God’s Story* line — keep those lines separate). Age: sits cleanly in **11–14** when Volumes 2–4 (and a careful Volume 1 review year) are used as independent or shared read. High-school credit: the publisher does not claim AP World. A Volume year is not NCAA “World History.”

Story of the World is a narrative spine many families use for early and middle grades; the Activity Book is labelled primarily grades 1–4 and extendable 5–8. Fit, not rank.

Transcript. Social Studies, History, or World History. Never “SOTW 3.”

History Quest: Middle Times and United States (Pandia Press) — secular

History Quest is labelled a complete elementary history curriculum. **Middle Times:** grades 1–6; 1st–4th as a read-aloud; **5th grade+ as an independent**

⁴³Well-Trained Mind Press / *The Story of the World* series and Activity Book support text: early and middle grades; Activity Book primarily grades 1–4, extendable 5–8; intermediate students write review answers; “You need not use every assignment with every child.” Access date: 13 September 2026. This chapter omits unverified 2026 list prices.

read; Fall of the Roman Empire through Elizabethan Times; secular; religious beliefs from the period presented as sources and perspectives through a historical lens — as the publisher describes it. **United States:** recommended grades 3–6; 3rd–5th as a read-aloud; **6th grade+ as an independent read;** U.S. history and civics from the 1500s to the early 21st century. Study guides add year-long lesson plans, literature, geography, discussion, and writing.⁴⁴

Fit. Parent load: read-aloud presence at the bottom of the band; independent read plus study-guide writing at 11–14. Secular narrative spine — the explicit secular alternative many families seek next to *Story of the World*. Age: **in band** as independent read (Middle Times 5+; United States 6+). United States is the civics-and-U.S. neighbor. Not a Christian worldview product on the opened pages. Not a high-school survey.

Transcript. Social Studies, World History, or U.S. History. Never “History Quest.”

History Odyssey (Pandia Press) — secular; middle-to-high-school year-plans

A secular, four-part series; comprehensive, yearlong study plans for **middle school to high school** students — as the publisher describes it. Through reading, discussion, critical thinking, independent study, and hands-on activities. Parts named: Ancients; Middle Ages; Early Modern; Modern Times (aimed at older students). History Compass is named as a guide to historical thinking, research, and writing.⁴⁵

Fit. Parent load: lower day-to-day if the student works the year-plan independently; the adult still hosts discussion and looks at writing. Secular; more independent and more research-shaped than History Quest’s elementary narrative. Age: the **13–14** half of this band and the high-school edge. Prefer History Quest or *Story of the World* if the student still needs a shared spine.

⁴⁴Pandia Press History Quest: Middle Times and United States product pages: secular; Middle Times grades 1–4 read-aloud / 5+ independent; United States grades 3–5 read-aloud / 6+ independent; recommended 3–6. Access date: 13 September 2026. Omit unverified 2026 list prices.

⁴⁵Pandia Press History Odyssey series page: secular yearlong study plans for middle school to high school; Ancients, Middle Ages, Early Modern, Modern Times. Access date: 13 September 2026. Omit unverified 2026 list prices.

Transcript. Social Studies or World History. Never “History Odyssey.” Never “HO Middle Ages.”

Mystery of History Volume II (and III as older-edge sibling) — Christian chronological

Volume II covers world history from the ascension of Jesus Christ (c. A.D. 33) to the invention of the printing press (1456); blends early-church history with world-wide Middle Ages events on one timeline — as the publisher describes it. Student Reader with Companion Guide: pretests; **activities for Younger, Middle, and Older students**; review work; literature lists. Written from a biblical worldview; integrates sacred and secular history on one continuous timeline. Volume III (Renaissance, Reformation, and Growth of Nations) is the older-edge sibling inside this band.⁴⁶

Fit. Parent load: moderate-to-high if all tracks run; lower if Middle/Older activities only. Christian chronological, multi-age. Age: **Middle** track is the 11–14 grain; Older leans 13–14 and up. Volume I is the *History for Little Thinkers* object. Not secular. Not a document seminar. Label the worldview honestly. Neither hide it nor mock it.

Transcript. Social Studies or World History. Never “Mystery of History Volume II” as the credit line.

Beautiful Feet Books — Early American History (4–6)

Homeschool social studies and history for **4th–6th grade**; literature-based; Socratic-style questions; **3–4 lessons per week for a one-year study** — as the publisher describes it.⁴⁷

⁴⁶Mystery of History Volume II Second Edition and How-to-Use pages: A.D. 33–1456; Companion Guide activities for Younger, Middle, and Older students; biblical worldview; Volume III as older-edge sibling. Access date: 13 September 2026. Omit unverified 2026 list prices.

⁴⁷Beautiful Feet Books Early American History 4–6 Teacher Guide page: literature-based; 3–4 lessons per week for a one-year study. Access date: 13 September 2026. Omit unverified 2026 list prices.

Fit. Parent load: moderate-to-high book management (many titles on the table); lower daily script density once the guide is open. Literature-pack, not a single narrative spine. Age: **11–12** maps cleanly; a 13–14-year-old may find it light unless the family wants a literature-rich U.S. year with heavier written work added. U.S. focus.

Transcript. Social Studies or History (U.S.). Never “Beautiful Feet Early American 4–6.” Never “BFB.”

All American History Volume I (Celeste W. Rakes; Bright Ideas Press)

Volume I units: Age of Exploration, colonization, American Revolution, establishment and expansion; **32 weekly lessons**; Student Reader plus Companion Guide (note-taking, reviews, tests, activities, timeline, mapping, reading lists) — as the publisher describes it. The series is labelled for students in **grades 5 to high school**, adaptable for younger students.⁴⁸

Fit. Parent load: moderate; more textbook-shaped than a picture-book pack. Age: **in this band** — a twelve-year-old can sit Volume I without the kindergarten warning *History for Little Thinkers* needed. Volume II sits at 13–14 and the high-school edge. Christian narrative U.S. survey with a companion, not a document seminar.

Transcript. Social Studies or History (U.S.). Never “All American History Volume I.”

Digital Inquiry Group *Reading Like a Historian* — looking move, not a year

Each lesson revolves around a central historical question and a set of primary documents designed for groups of students with a range of reading skills; teaches sourcing, contextualizing, corroborating, and close reading — as the organization describes it. Free with a DIG account. Marketing is classroom and district. Intro

⁴⁸Bright Ideas Press All American History Volume I: 32 weekly lessons; series labelled grades 5 to high school, adaptable younger (neighboring-stream vendor copy). Access date: 13 September 2026. Omit unverified 2026 list prices.

objects include Lunchroom Fight and Evaluating Photographs — useful as kitchen-scale looking demos.⁴⁹

Fit for ages 11–14. Parent load: moderate if one short lesson is adapted; high if a secondary pacing calendar is forced. **This is the band where the looking move becomes usable** without pretending the student is in APUSH. Still **not a year-long middle-grades survey**. Not a franchise of this book. Borrow the looking move. Do not treat a classroom curriculum as a grade-7 year.

Transcript. Never “SHEG” or “DIG” as the credit line. If used, materials under History: “primary-source looking lessons (DIG).”

Library of Congress Teaching with Primary Sources — looking neighbor

Primary sources are the raw materials of history — original documents and objects created at the time under study; secondary sources retell, analyze, or interpret at a distance — as the Library describes it. Observe the source; think about the response; ask about the creator’s purpose; ask whether the source agrees with other sources; offer students a chance to demonstrate learning by writing an essay, delivering a speech, or creating a museum display. Primary Source Analysis Tool and Primary Source Sets are named.⁵⁰

Fit. Parent load: low if one short source and the analysis tool; high if a full set is treated as a year. **Looking neighbor**, not a curriculum franchise. Pairs with DIG or with a naked library hour. Civic texts gently: a constitution clause or a short speech can be the day’s source when the student can name who made it.

Transcript. Materials under History: “Library of Congress primary-source analysis.” Never “LOC TPS” as the credit.

⁴⁹Digital Inquiry Group inquirygroup.org history-lessons page: Reading Like a Historian; free classroom curriculum; sourcing, contextualizing, corroborating, close reading. Classroom origin. Not a middle-grades year franchise. Access date: 13 September 2026.

⁵⁰Library of Congress Getting Started with Primary Sources page: Observe–Reflect–Question grain; Primary Source Analysis Tool; Primary Source Sets. Looking neighbor, not a franchise. Access date: 13 September 2026.

Placement by skill at the shelf

An eleven-year-old may follow a narrative spine and still need a short claim frame. A fourteen-year-old may still need taught looking before an independent year-plan. That is fit. It is not a percentile ladder.

Ages 11–12. Shared or independent read of a middle-extendable spine. Written who/when/why. Two short sources. A paragraph with one named source. Prefer library biographies, living-books written narration, *Story of the World* Volumes 2–3 with written review, History Quest Middle Times / United States as independent read when ready, Beautiful Feet Early American 4–6, Mystery of History Volume II Middle track, All American History Volume I. Soft entry on DIG or LOC: one short lesson or analysis tool, not a full secondary calendar.

Ages 13–14. More independent chapter work. Two sources without the adult holding the answer. A one-to-two-page argument with a limitation. History Odyssey when ready; Mystery of History Volume III at the top of the band; Volume 4 of *Story of the World*; a carefully adapted DIG or LOC two-source lesson after a museum label. Civic clause gently when the student can name the maker.

A family may teach both bands in one hour with different exit tasks. Share the piece; split the try. The older student needs their own looking move — not only tutoring the younger one.

Put the kitchen checks from Chapter 8 and Chapter 9 next to whatever spine you choose: date the work; source a claim; corroborate two sources; write a short argument. The program supplies the story. The notebook supplies the stranger-readable line.

Combining honestly

Need: \$0 start → library + museum.

Need: narration habit without a brand → living books + written retell.

Need: chronological world narrative, middle grades, written review → *Story of the World* Volumes 2–4.

Need: secular chronological narrative, independent at 11–14 → History Quest Middle Times / United States.

Need: secular independent year-plan, more research → History Odyssey (open the level page; Modern Times is older).

Need: Christian chronological multi-age → Mystery of History Volume II (Middle/Older tracks); Volume III at the top of the band.

Need: literature-pack U.S. for 11–12 → Beautiful Feet Early American 4–6.

Need: Christian U.S. narrative with companion tests, in-band → All American History Volume I.

Need: looking move with a document → DIG lesson adapted, or LOC TPS analysis tool.

A family may combine. Common honest combinations: library shelf + *Story of the World* or History Quest spine; Beautiful Feet pack as the year's U.S. literature path; Mystery of History for a Christian timeline with Middle activities; History Odyssey when the student is ready to work a year-plan; one DIG-style or LOC two-source lesson after a museum label. Combining does not authorize a franken-course title. The transcript still says **History** or **Social Studies**.

A looking-heavy path that assumes the student can already decode dense primary sources will not teach story-listening to an eleven-year-old still consolidating fluency. That is a fit warning, not a slur. A student who cannot yet source a claim is not “behind in DIG”; they are still in a narrative-and-written-retell year.

High-school Notgrass surveys, NCAA social-science worksheets, AP, and CLEP belong to *History for Homeschooling*. One pointer; then stop. Ages 5–10 retell and then/now neighbors belong to *History for Little Thinkers*. One pointer; then stop.

A publisher quiz is not an IES RCT. We name fit: parent load, style, placement, cost shape, age label. Fit chooses. Ranking does not.

A Note on Sources

Studies named in the chapters are listed in Notes, in one series at the back. That is where the full citations live, so the teaching pages can stay a teaching voice.

Some items the research behind this book did not open stay out of the teaching voice. I did not invent a coefficient, a statute, or a product feature to fill a hole. If a study is in the chapter, it is in the notes. If we could not open it, it is not used as a finding here.

Program hours, credit claims, and product descriptions in the resources chapter are taken from the companies' own pages. Access date 13 September 2026.